
THE FORGOTTEN GODS



*How Europe Traded a Thousand Living Spirits
For One Distant King in the Sky*

by

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*A grounded, plain-language look at what was lost when
the old religions of forest, river, and storm were replaced
by a religion brought in from outside.*

A Note From the Author

My name is Lovepreet Singh. I am 24 years old. I love learning new things every day. I read about business, technology, politics, psychology, philosophy, economics, and history. I am curious about how the world came to be the way it is.

One day I was thinking about religion. I noticed something. Most old cultures around the world used to worship nature. That means they treated trees, rivers, mountains, the sun, and the rain as sacred, and prayed to them directly. Then, somewhere along the way, most of these old religions died. They were replaced by big organised religions like Christianity and Islam. I wanted to know what really happened. So I started reading.

What I found was both more brutal and more interesting than the simple story I had in my head. The truth does not need any fake stories or made-up conspiracies. The real history is heavy enough on its own.

This book is my attempt to lay out what actually happened. I have used historians who spent their whole lives studying these events. I have used writings from people who actually lived through that time. Every claim in this book can be checked. I want this to be the kind of argument that gets stronger the more you fact-check it, not weaker.

I wrote this in simple language on purpose. Big words are often used to hide weak arguments. I do not want to hide anything. I want you to understand every line — even if you know nothing at all about history, religion, or these gods beforehand. That is why, wherever a new or unfamiliar word appears, I will explain it right there. If you disagree with me after reading this, that is fine. But at least we will both be arguing about real history, not about myths.

Two words to learn before we start. Two short labels appear again and again in this book — “CE” and “BCE”. The year of Jesus’s birth (the founder-figure of Christianity) is used as the zero point of the count. Years **after** that point are called “CE” (so 2026 CE = today). Years **before** it are called “BCE”, meaning “Before the Common Era”. BCE years run backwards in time — 500 BCE is much older than 100 BCE.

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“The conversion of Europe was not a gentle wave but a long, sometimes brutal political project spanning a thousand years.”

*— Robert Bartlett, *The Making of Europe*, 1993*



This is not a religious attack. It is a historical accounting. Read it with an open mind. The truth is more interesting than the myth.

I.

Before the Cross: A Continent That Worshipped What It Could See

What is “the Cross”? The cross is the main symbol of Christianity — two pieces of wood joined to make a “+” shape. Christians believe that Jesus, the founder-figure of their religion, was killed by being nailed to a wooden cross. So “Before the Cross” means the time before Christianity arrived in Europe. And a **continent** is one of the huge land-masses of the Earth; here we are talking about the continent of Europe.

Imagine you are a young man living in Germany (a country in modern Europe) in the year 50 CE. There is no Bible — the Bible is the Christian holy book. There is no church — a church is the building where Christians gather to worship. There is no Sunday service — Christians meet once a week, on Sunday, to pray together. You have never even heard of Jesus, because he was born only 50 years ago in a far-away land you do not even know exists. But you still have gods. Lots of them. And they are not invisible ideas in the sky. They are real things you can see with your eyes and touch with your hands every day.

Thor is the thunder that crashes over your village. When you hear thunder, you believe you are literally hearing Thor. Freyr is the harvest. When your wheat grows tall and golden, you believe Freyr did that. There is a god in the river behind your house. There is a spirit in the oak tree (a kind of large, strong tree) in the middle of the village. Your grandmother knows the names of all of them. She taught them to you when you were small.

This is not made up. This is exactly how every culture in Europe used to think before Christianity arrived. And we know this for certain because the Romans — a large, powerful, and literate civilisation whose centre was the city of Rome in modern Italy — wrote it all down.

The Roman Who Studied the Germans

In the year 98 CE, a Roman historian named Tacitus wrote a book called *Germania*. (A historian is a person who finds out, checks, and writes down what happened in the past.) Tacitus had never been to Germany himself, but he interviewed Roman soldiers and traders who had been there. He wanted to understand these people who lived in the dark forests north of the Roman empire’s border.

What he wrote is one of the most important pieces of evidence we have about old European religion. In chapter nine of *Germania*, Tacitus says the Germans do not build temples. They do not carve statues of their gods. Why? Because they think it would be insulting. The way they saw it, you cannot trap a god inside a wall. You cannot capture a spirit in a piece of stone. Instead, they worshipped in “sacred groves”. A grove is a small cluster of special trees, which they treated as holy. When they wanted to pray, they walked into those trees and prayed there.

“They consecrate woods and groves, and they call by the names of gods that hidden presence which they perceive by reverence alone.”

— Tacitus, *Germania*, Chapter 9, written 98 CE

Read that quote again slowly. The Germans believed there was a hidden presence in the trees. They could not see it directly with their eyes. But they could feel it — through respect, through reverence. That was their religion. It was not stupid. It was not primitive (backward or ignorant). It was a careful way of relating to the world around them.

It Was Not Just the Germans

This same kind of religion existed all across Europe. Let me give you a quick tour of the different regions. (The names below — Celts, Slavs, Norse, and so on — are different groups of people, that is, tribes or peoples, who lived in different parts of Europe.)

The **Celts** lived in what is now Ireland, Scotland, Wales, France, and parts of Spain (all countries in Europe). They worshipped a goddess named Danu, whom they believed was the river itself. They believed certain wells were holy. They held religious festivals at the changing of the seasons. Their festival called Samhain was on October 31. When Christianity came, the Church (the organisation of the Christian religion) could not stop people from celebrating it, so they renamed it into a Christian festival — “All Saints Day”. That is where today’s Halloween comes from. In the same way, the festival of Beltane on May 1 later became “May Day”. The plain truth is that these were really the Celts’ old nature festivals, just dressed up later in Christian clothes.

The **Slavs** lived in what is now Russia, Ukraine, Poland, and the Balkans. Their main god was named Perun. Perun was the god of thunder and lightning, and he was believed to live in oak trees. There was also a god named Veles who lived underground and protected cattle (cows, oxen, and the like). Slavic villages did have wooden idols, but the real worship happened outside, near rivers and trees.

The **Norse** lived in Scandinavia — the lands we now call Norway, Sweden, Denmark, and Iceland (the cold countries of northern Europe). Their religion is the most famous because Hollywood has made movies about it. Odin was their chief (highest) god. Thor was the god

of thunder. Freyr was the god of the harvest. Freya was at the same time the goddess of love and of war. The important point is that these gods were not seen as perfect. In the stories they drank too much, they got into fights, and they sometimes lied. In other words, they were like humans, only more powerful — not flawless, perfect beings.

The **Greeks and Romans** are the ones whose gods most people still know — Zeus, Apollo, Athena, Hermes. (Greece is the modern country; Romans means the Rome-based civilisation.) They had a separate god for almost every part of life. Even before they built fancy temples and statues, the Romans too started out by worshipping nature spirits. Every farm had a Lar, which was a household spirit that protected the home. Every spring of water (a place where water bubbles up from the ground) had its own nymph, a water-spirit. The forest had fauns (creatures from their stories, half human and half goat). And the fields had Ceres, the goddess of grain.

The **Balts** are the people who later became the Lithuanians and Latvians (people of a small region of Europe called the Baltic). They are very important for our story, because they were the very last pagans in all of Europe.

Understand the word “pagan” — it appears again and again. “Pagan” is the word used for people who followed the old religions that existed before Christianity, Islam, or Judaism. As a rule these people believed in many gods, not one, and worshipped nature (trees, rivers, the sun, lightning). Every time you see “pagan” in this book, picture that — people who followed the old, nature-based religions.

The Balts kept their old (pagan) religion officially until 1387 CE. That is more than a thousand years after Rome became Christian — meaning they held out without adopting the new religion for that entire stretch of time. The Baltic chief god was Perkūnas — yet another thunder god, just like Perun and Thor. Same idea, different name.

Notice Something Important

Did you see what just happened? Almost every European people had a thunder god. Thor among the Norse. Perun among the Slavs. Perkūnas among the Balts. Zeus among the Greeks. Jupiter among the Romans. Scholars who study language examined all these names and found they all come from the same single ancient root word. This tells us that all these peoples descended from one shared ancestor culture. Scholars call that earliest shared culture the “Proto-Indo-Europeans”, who lived around 6,000 years ago in what is now Ukraine and southern Russia.

This means nature worship was not some scattered, weird, small local thing. It was the original religion of a whole large family of cultures, spread from India all the way to far-off Ireland. Here is an interesting link: the Hindu god Indra is also a god of thunder and rain.

So when someone prays to Indra, they are in fact praying to a relative-like god of Thor. When you celebrate the rain, you are doing what your very distant ancestors did thousands of years ago.

Hard Numbers

Let me give you some real numbers (solid, countable evidence) so you understand the scale of what we are talking about.

In Britain alone (the country we now call England), the scholars who dig up old remains from the ground — called archaeologists — have found more than 600 holy wells that were sites of pagan worship before being taken over by Christianity. Many of these wells are still there. You can visit them today. Christian saint names were later slapped on them, but the water and the rituals are the same old ones. People still drop coins in them for luck — and that is, in fact, an old pagan offering.

In Sweden, there was a massive pagan temple at a place called Uppsala. A German Christian writer named Adam of Bremen described it in detail in the year 1070 CE. Every nine years there was a huge festival, at which animals were sacrificed. Adam wrote about this with horror, but also with fascination — because by his time most of Europe had become Christian, and yet this pagan temple was still standing. It was finally destroyed by Christian Swedish kings in the late 1000s.

Here is the piece of arithmetic that should blow your mind. Christianity did not exist anywhere on Earth before 30 CE. And Europe became fully Christian only by around 1400 CE. So Christianity has been the dominant religion in Europe for only about 600 to 1,000 years, depending on which region you look at. By comparison, nature worship was the dominant religion of those same lands for at least 4,000 to 6,000 years before that. The conclusion is clear: Europe was pagan for far longer than it has been Christian. We are the new thing. They were the old thing.

II.

Why People Worshipped Nature in the First Place

Modern people sometimes laugh at the old religions. They think nature worship is silly. Why would anyone pray to a tree? But this view is wrong. And the mistake happens because we do not understand the world these people lived in.

Let me explain it in a way that will make sense. Today, when your phone battery is low, you plug it into a wall socket. You do not think about where the electricity actually comes from. When you are hungry, you open the fridge or order food on an app. You do not think about who grew the food. When you turn on the tap, water comes out by itself. You do not think about the river it was taken from. The whole structure of modern life is built on hiding nature behind machines, so that we never see it directly.

But back then, there were no machines. Nature was right in front of your eyes every single day.

If the Rain Did Not Come, You Died

Imagine you are a farmer in the year 200 CE in central Europe. You have a small farm. You grow wheat and barley. You have a few cows and some chickens. Your whole family depends entirely on what you can grow. There are no big shops or markets to buy food from. There is no government to send food if your crops fail. There is no medicine. There is no electricity. If the rain does not come in the right season, your crops dry up and die. If your crops die, you go hungry. If you go hungry, you die. It really is that simple.

Now imagine this is your life for thousands of years, generation after generation. Of course you are going to worship the rain. The rain is literally life and death for you. When the rain comes at the right time, your family eats. When it does not, your children die of hunger in winter. So of course you build rituals around the rain. Of course you think there is a god behind it who controls it. What else would you possibly think?

Nature Was Not a Resource. It Was a Partner.

The historian Ronald Hutton, who teaches at the University of Bristol in England, wrote a book in 1991 called *The Pagan Religions of the Ancient British Isles* (that is, “the pagan

religions of old Britain”). It is the standard, most trusted book on this subject. Hutton spent his whole career studying what we actually know for sure about the old British pagans, including the Celts and the Druids.

One of his main points is that, for the old pagans, nature was not a resource to be used up and thrown away. It was a partner you had to respect. The way they saw it: if you cut down the wrong tree, the forest spirit would be angry. If you fished too much from a sacred lake, the water god would punish you. If you killed a deer without saying the proper prayer of thanks, you might not be able to find a single deer for a whole year.

This was not just superstition. Looked at closely, it actually worked like an early form of environmental protection. (The environment means the nature all around us — air, water, forests, animals.) Because people believed nature was full of gods and spirits, they were careful with it. They did not strip forests bare or pollute rivers, because they were afraid of what would happen if they made the gods angry.

The Druids Were Not What People Today Think

Speaking of the Druids, let me clear up a popular myth. (The Druids were the priests and learned men of the Celts.) Movies show Druids as wizards in white robes who do magic spells. But according to the Roman writers who actually met them in person, the reality is quite different.

Julius Caesar — a very great Roman general and ruler — himself wrote about the Druids in his book *Gallic Wars* around 50 BCE. At the time, Caesar was fighting the Celtic tribes of Gaul (the region of modern France), so he had every reason to make them look bad. Yet what he describes is interesting. He says the Druids were the educated class of Celtic society. They were not only the priests — they were also the judges, the teachers, the doctors, and the historians. Becoming a Druid took 20 years of study. They had to memorise huge amounts of poetry, law, and astronomy (knowledge of the stars and planets).

Caesar also said the Druids refused, on purpose, to write down their teachings. They wanted everything to be memorised, because they believed that the habit of writing made the memory weak. Whether this is fully true, or just Caesar showing off Roman superiority, we will never know for sure. But the main point stands: the old religions were not stupid. They had complex, deep traditions. They had wise people who studied for decades. They had their own philosophy, astronomy, and law.

“The Druids were the intellectual class of Celtic society, holding equal status to the warrior aristocracy and acting as priests, judges, philosophers, and physicians.”

— Barry Cunliffe, *The Ancient Celts*, 1997. Cunliffe is one of the leading archaeologists on Celtic history.

So Why Did All of This Die?

If the old religions were so deep and so widespread, why did they disappear? Why is it that today, if you tell someone you pray to a tree, they will think you are crazy?

This is the real question. And the answer is not what most people think. The old religions did not die because Christianity was somehow better. They did not die because people had a spiritual awakening and “saw the truth”. They died because of politics, marriage strategy, military conquest, and in some cases, plain mass murder. Let me show you how it really happened.

III.

How a Religion From the Desert Took Over a Continent of Forests

Christianity started in a place called Judea, which is part of modern Israel and Palestine (this region is dry and desert-like — hence the chapter title, “a religion from the desert”). It was born among Jewish people. (The Jews are a very old people and religion; their religion believes in only one God.) Jesus himself was Jewish. So were all his original followers (his disciples). In the beginning, Christianity was just a small Jewish sect — one of many. Nobody in 50 CE would have guessed that this tiny group would one day take over all of Europe.

For about 300 years, Christianity stayed small, and the Roman empire often persecuted it (that is, harassed and punished Christians). Christians were sometimes thrown to lions in the arena. They had to hide in underground tunnels to worship. But they kept growing slowly — especially among the poor and the slaves of the Roman empire. Why? Because Christianity offered something the old religions did not. It offered a promise of a better life after death, for everyone — not just for heroes and kings, but for the ordinary and the weak too. For a slave who had nothing in this life, that was a powerful thing.

The Day Everything Changed: October 28, 312 CE

Here is the date you need to remember — October 28, 312 CE. On this day, a Roman emperor (king) named Constantine fought a battle against another Roman general named Maxentius. Both were trying to become the sole ruler of the whole Roman empire. The battle took place at a spot called the Milvian Bridge, just outside the city of Rome.

Constantine won. He became emperor. But here is the part that mattered for the next 2,000 years of history. According to the Christian writer Eusebius — who knew Constantine personally and wrote about him later — Constantine saw a “vision” before the battle (that is, he claimed to have seen a heavenly sign). He said he saw a cross in the sky with the words *In Hoc Signo Vinces* — a Latin phrase meaning “In this sign, you will conquer.” He had his soldiers paint Christian symbols on their shields. He won the battle. And in this way he became the first Christian emperor.

Now, did this vision really happen? Historians argue about it. Some say it was a genuine religious experience. Some say Constantine made it up later to give himself political cover. Some say Eusebius made the whole story bigger than it really was. We will never know for sure. But what is not up for argument is what Constantine did next.

The Edict of Milan, 313 CE

(An “edict” is an order or law issued by a ruler.) In the year 313 CE, just a few months after his victory, Constantine issued a law called the Edict of Milan. This law made Christianity legal everywhere in the Roman empire. Before this, Christians could be arrested and killed. After this, they could worship openly.

But Constantine did not stop there. He started giving Christianity special advantages. Christian priests (religious leaders) did not have to pay taxes. The empire gave money to build churches. Constantine himself converted to Christianity — although historians argue about how seriously he really believed it, since he kept worshipping the sun god Sol Invictus for years even after becoming Christian. But politically that did not matter. What mattered was that, suddenly, being Christian was the way to get ahead in the Roman empire.

Imagine you are a smart young Roman in the year 320 CE. You want a government job. You want to marry into a rich family. You want your sons to succeed. You look around, and you see that the emperor himself is Christian. The new government is full of Christians. The tax breaks go to Christian priests. The best positions are going to Christians. So what are you going to do? You are going to convert — not because of deep spiritual belief, but because it is the smart move for getting ahead. And this is exactly what happened across the Roman empire for the next 100 years.

The Edict of Thessalonica, 380 CE

Sixty-seven years after Constantine, in the year 380 CE, an emperor named Theodosius I went even further. He issued the Edict of Thessalonica, which made Christianity the official (state) religion of the entire Roman empire. And he did not stop there — he made it illegal (a crime) even to practise the old pagan religions.

In 391 CE, Theodosius ordered all pagan temples to be closed. Christian mobs were given free permission to destroy pagan shrines. The Olympic Games — which had been a religious festival of the god Zeus for over 1,000 years — were banned because they were pagan. They would not be held again until 1896. (Today’s Olympic Games are that old tradition brought back.)

In 415 CE, a famous pagan female philosopher named Hypatia was brutally murdered in the city of Alexandria (in modern Egypt). She was a brilliant mathematician and astronomer who taught philosophy at the famous Library of Alexandria. A Christian mob — possibly stirred up by a local bishop (a senior priest) — dragged her from her carriage, beat her to death, and tore her body apart. This event is recorded by several ancient sources, including the Christian writer Socrates Scholasticus, who wrote about it with shame. Hypatia’s death is often seen as the symbolic end of the old pagan world.

“In her time, philosophers and scientists could be killed by mobs in the streets, and the old learning of Greece and Rome began its long slide into the dark.”

— Edward J. Watts, *Hypatia: The Life and Legend of an Ancient Philosopher*, 2017

The Royal Marriage Strategy

Inside the Roman empire, the conversion was driven by the emperors forcing it through. (“Conversion” means leaving one religion and adopting another.) But outside the Roman empire, in the lands of the Germanic, Celtic, and Slavic tribes, Christianity had to find another way to spread. The way it did this is fascinating. It was not a secret conspiracy. It was an open, documented marriage strategy that the Church used over and over again for hundreds of years.

Here is how the strategy worked. The Church would arrange for a Christian princess from a Christian kingdom to marry a pagan king from a pagan kingdom. The princess would bring her own Christian priest with her. Then she would slowly work on her husband over the years. She would have his children and raise them Christian. Eventually the king himself would convert. And when the king converted, the whole kingdom converted with him — because in those days the religion of the king was treated as the religion of all the people.

Example one: Clovis and Clotilde, 496 CE. Clovis was the king of the Franks — the same tribe that later became the country France. He was a fierce warrior and a pagan. His wife Clotilde was a Christian princess. Clotilde worked on Clovis for years, begging him to convert. He refused. Then one day, in 496 CE, Clovis was losing a battle against another Germanic tribe called the Alemanni. In desperation, he prayed to the Christian god, promising to convert if he won. He won the battle. He converted. And 3,000 of his soldiers were baptised with him on Christmas day.

What is “baptism”? Baptism is the ceremony of becoming a Christian. Water is poured over the person (or the person is dipped in water) — it means that they have now officially become Christian. Whenever the book says someone “was baptised”, take it to mean they were made a Christian.

This is recorded by Gregory of Tours, a French bishop who wrote a book called the *History of the Franks* in the late 500s CE.

Example two: Ethelbert and Bertha, around 597 CE. Ethelbert was the king of Kent (the south-east part of England). He was a pagan. He married a Christian princess named Bertha. Bertha brought a bishop with her named Liudhard. Pope Gregory the Great in Rome heard about this marriage and saw an opportunity. (The Pope is the highest religious leader of Catholic Christians.) In 597 CE he sent a missionary (a person whose job is to spread a religion) named Augustine directly to Ethelbert's court. Within a few years, Ethelbert converted. And in this way England started its long journey to becoming Christian.

Example three: Mieszko I and Dobrawa, 966 CE. Mieszko was the first ruler of Poland that we know about. He was a pagan Slavic chief. He married a Czech Christian princess named Dobrawa, and through her influence he converted in 966 CE. Poland has been Christian ever since. That date is so important to Poles that it is sometimes called the birthday of Poland itself.

Example four: Vladimir and Anna, 988 CE. Vladimir was the pagan ruler of a kingdom called Kievan Rus — the same kingdom that later became Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus. He converted to Christianity in 988 CE specifically in order to marry Anna, the sister of the Byzantine Christian emperor. He chose the “Eastern Orthodox” version of Christianity — for the religion later split into different branches, which is why Russia is Orthodox and not Catholic to this day. He then forced his subjects to be baptised in the Dnieper river in Kiev, sometimes at sword-point. This event is recorded in the *Russian Primary Chronicle*, written by monks in the 1100s.

“The conversion of kings was the master key. Once the king bent the knee, the kingdom followed, whether they understood the new religion or not.”

— Peter Brown, The Rise of Western Christendom, 2003. Peter Brown is the leading historian of Christianity's expansion.

Notice what is really happening here. The common villagers in these kingdoms were not converted because someone preached to them and they had a spiritual awakening. They were converted because their king got married and changed his mind — and they had no choice but to follow. This is not some far-fetched conspiracy story. This is what actually happened, recorded by the Christian writers themselves, who were proud of the strategy.

IV.

The Real History of Forced Conversion

The royal marriage strategy worked in some kingdoms. But many pagan peoples flatly refused to give up their old gods. When persuasion did not work, the Christian Church and Christian kings turned to violence. This part of history does not get talked about much, because it is very uncomfortable to hear. But it is fully documented — it is not made up.

Charlemagne and the Saxon Wars: 32 Years of Mass Murder

Charlemagne is one of the most celebrated figures in European history. There are statues of him everywhere in France and Germany. He is sometimes even called “the Father of Europe”. In 800 CE the Pope crowned him emperor, and he founded the “Holy Roman Empire”. But what is talked about far less is how he built that empire. He built it by spending 32 years trying to wipe out the Saxons.

The Saxons were a Germanic pagan people living in what is now northern Germany. They worshipped the old gods. Their most sacred religious object was a giant wooden pillar called the Irminsul. They believed this very pillar held up the sky. In 772 CE, Charlemagne marched into Saxon territory, found the Irminsul, and chopped it down. To understand it, think of it like this — as if someone marched into the holiest temple or mosque and bulldozed it. We are talking about that level of religious insult.

The Saxons fought back. For the next three decades there was constant war. Charlemagne would conquer a region, force the people to be baptised (that is, forcibly made Christian), then move on. As soon as he left, the people would go back to their old pagan religion. He would come back and do it all over again. Each round got more violent.

The Massacre of Verden, 782 CE

In 782 CE, after a major Saxon uprising, Charlemagne lost patience. At a place called Verden, he ordered the execution of 4,500 Saxon prisoners in a single day. They were beheaded one by one. This event is recorded in the *Royal Frankish Annals*, which were the official chronicles of Charlemagne’s own court. So his own writers recorded it. They were not even ashamed of it — they saw it as a victory for Christianity.

Some modern historians have questioned the exact figure of 4,500, suggesting the real number might be smaller. But even if we cut it in half, this was still a mass execution of unarmed prisoners for the “crime” of being pagan.

The Saxon Law, 785 CE

In 785 CE, Charlemagne issued a law called the *Capitulatio de partibus Saxoniae*, which means “Ordinance on the Saxon Region.” This is not a story — it is a real document; you can read it online today. It is one of the most extreme religious laws ever written.

Under this law, the following acts were punishable by death:

- Refusing to be baptised (that is, refusing to become Christian)
- Eating meat during Lent — (Lent is a Christian fasting period, during which, for some weeks, they do not eat certain things, especially meat)
- Burning the dead in the pagan way instead of burying them in a Christian cemetery
- Pretending to be baptised on the surface while still being pagan inside
- Killing a Christian priest or bishop, even by accident
- Performing a pagan sacrifice

Think about what this means. Suppose you were a Saxon farmer who quietly still believed in Thor, and you wanted to give your father the old-style funeral (cremation). Charlemagne would have you executed for it. This was not gentle, persuasive missionary work. This was, plainly, terror spread in the name of religion.

“Charlemagne’s wars against the Saxons rank among the most violent episodes of forced conversion in European history.”

— Alessandro Barbero, *Charlemagne: Father of a Continent*, 2004. Barbero is an Italian historian who specialises in medieval Europe.

The Northern Crusades, 1147 to 1410

What is a “Crusade”? A Crusade was a large military campaign that the Christian Church fought in the name of religion. Most people know about the Crusades to the “Holy Land” (the region around Jerusalem). But the “Northern Crusades” were fought in northern Europe, specifically to wipe out the remaining pagan peoples — and almost nobody today knows about them.

The Northern Crusades were Christian military campaigns that lasted for almost 300 years. Their clear goal was to wipe out the last pagan peoples in Europe. The targets were the Old Prussians, the Lithuanians, the Estonians, the Livonians, and other peoples of the Baltic and Finnic region.

The main force doing the killing was a group called the Teutonic Knights. These were German Christian warrior-monks — that is, men who were both religious and fighters. They had their own state, their own army, and their own castles. The Pope blessed their wars and called them “holy”. Any knight from anywhere in Europe could come to the Baltic, kill pagans, and have his sins forgiven by the Church in return. In other words, it had become a kind of religious tourism for violent men.

The result was the complete destruction of several entire peoples. The Old Prussians, who lived along what is now the Baltic coast of Russia and Poland, were essentially exterminated. Their language — “Old Prussian” — died out completely by the 1700s; today we have only a few short documents in it. The Livonians of modern Latvia were broken apart as a culture. The Estonians were brutally conquered, although they did survive as a people.

Lithuania, the very last officially pagan country in Europe, only converted in 1387 CE — and even then it was a political deal. The Lithuanian Grand Duke Jogaila married the Polish Queen Jadwiga and agreed to convert his whole country in exchange for becoming king of Poland. Ordinary rural Lithuanians kept practising their old religion in secret for centuries afterwards.

The historian Eric Christiansen wrote the standard, most trusted book on this, called *The Northern Crusades*, published in 1980. If you want to read more deeply, this is the source.

Iceland: A Vote Held Under Threat

Iceland gives us probably the cleanest example of how political pressure ended paganism — and without anyone being killed. In the year 1000 CE, the Norwegian king Olaf Tryggvason wanted Iceland to become Christian. He held some of Iceland’s leading men hostage in Norway and threatened to kill them. He also threatened to cut off all trade with Iceland — and that would have caused a famine (mass starvation), because Iceland depended on imports for its needs.

The Icelandic parliament, called the Althing, held a debate. (A parliament is the assembly where a people make their big decisions.) The leader of the pagan side was a man named Thorgeir Thorkelsson. He was respected by both sides. They asked him to make the decision. According to the *Íslendingabók*, an Icelandic history book written around 1130 CE, Thorgeir lay under a heavy cloak for an entire day and night, thinking it over.

When he came out, he announced his decision. Iceland would publicly, officially become Christian. But people could still privately worship the old gods at home if they wished. They could still eat horse meat (which was tied to pagan rituals). And some other old pagan customs were allowed to continue for a while too. These exceptions were gradually phased

out later, but the original decision was a compromise. It avoided war; it avoided a massacre. Even so, the plain truth is that it was still a religion forced onto a people by political and economic threat from outside.

Recognise the Pattern

Let me sum up what we have seen so far. Across more than a thousand years, Europe's conversion to Christianity happened through a mix of methods:

First — political pressure inside the Roman empire. Tax breaks and career advantages for Christians, and finally an outright ban on paganism.

Second — the royal marriage strategy. Christian princesses converting pagan kings, who then forced their subjects to follow.

Third — military conquest. Charlemagne's wars, the Northern Crusades, and many smaller campaigns where pagans were either killed, or given only two choices — baptism (become Christian) or death.

Fourth — economic and political coercion of independent kingdoms, like the threat Iceland faced.

What you almost never see anywhere in this story is people freely choosing Christianity, after weighing both religions, because they genuinely came to believe it. That did happen sometimes — especially among individual converts in the early Roman empire. But the mass conversion of all of Europe was not a free choice. It was top-down, often violent, and it took a full thousand years.

V.

The Crusades, the Jews, and the Myths That Refuse to Die

Now we come to the part that needs the most correction, because there is a lot of confusion in the popular story. Let me walk through it carefully.

The Myth: “Christian Kings Attacked Israel to Avenge the Death of Jesus”

The Crusades were a series of Christian military campaigns to capture Jerusalem and the land around it. (Jerusalem is a city that Jews, Christians, and Muslims all consider holy.) They lasted from 1096 CE to 1291 CE. There were about nine major Crusades and many smaller ones.

Here is the key fact most people miss. At the time of the First Crusade in 1096 CE, Jerusalem was not ruled by Jews. It had not been ruled by Jews for almost 1,000 years. At that time it was ruled by Muslims — specifically the Egypt-based Fatimid Caliphate. So the Crusaders were in fact fighting Muslims, not Jews. The official reason for the Crusades was to take back the city Christians considered holy from the Muslims who had ruled it since the year 638 CE.

So the popular idea that “Christian kings invaded Israel to take revenge on the Jews for killing Jesus” is wrong on the basic facts. The place is wrong, the religion of the enemy is wrong, and the timing is wrong.

The Truth: The Jews Were Pushed Out by Pagans, Not Christians

Here is what actually happened to the Jews of ancient Israel. Two huge disasters destroyed the Jewish state — and both of them were caused by the pagan Roman empire, long before Christianity had any power at all.

Disaster one: the destruction of the Second Temple, 70 CE. The Jews had been under Roman rule for about a century when they revolted in 66 CE. They were tired of being heavily taxed by the Romans, tired of Roman governors disrespecting their religion, and they wanted independence. The Romans crushed them. In the summer of 70 CE, the

Roman general Titus broke into Jerusalem and destroyed the “Second Temple”. This Second Temple was the centre of Jewish religious life — it was where the priests offered sacrifices. Its destruction was the most traumatic event in Jewish history — until the Holocaust 1,900 years later.

What is the “Holocaust”? The Holocaust was the event during the Second World War (1939–1945) in which Nazi Germany deliberately and systematically murdered about six million Jews. It is considered one of the worst mass killings in modern history. (It is mentioned again later in the book.)

How do we know all of this? Because a Jewish man named Yosef ben Matityahu actually lived through it. He was captured by the Romans, switched sides to save his life, and wrote a book in Greek called *The Jewish War*. He used the Roman name “Josephus Flavius”. His book is one of the most important pieces of evidence we have from the ancient world. It describes the siege, the famine, and the destruction in full detail. Hundreds of thousands of Jews died or were sold into slavery.

Disaster two: the Bar Kokhba revolt, 132 to 135 CE. Sixty years later, the Jews revolted again — this time under a leader named Simon Bar Kokhba. For three years they actually drove the Romans out and ran an independent Jewish state. Then the Romans came back with overwhelming force. The Roman historian Cassius Dio, writing about 80 years later, says that 580,000 Jews were killed and 985 villages were destroyed. These numbers might be exaggerated, but the scale of destruction was massive.

After Bar Kokhba, the Roman emperor Hadrian did something deliberately cruel. He renamed the entire Jewish province from Judea to *Syria Palaestina* — specifically to erase any connection between the Jewish people and their homeland. He banned Jews from even entering Jerusalem, except for one day a year. And where the Jewish Temple had once stood, he built a Roman temple to the god Jupiter.

Now here is the part you really need to understand. Both of these disasters — the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE, and the Bar Kokhba massacre in 135 CE — happened under pagan Roman emperors. At this time, Christianity was itself still illegal in Rome. The Romans did not destroy the Jewish state because they were Christians — because they were not. They destroyed it because the Jews kept revolting against Roman rule.

So when someone tells you that “Christianity destroyed the Jewish presence in Israel”, understand that they are getting the history backwards. It was Roman paganism that destroyed the Jewish presence in Israel. Christianity merely inherited the situation that paganism had already created.

The Truth: Christians Did Commit Anti-Jewish Violence — but in Europe

Now, that said, I do not want to defend Christianity here. The truth is that Christian Europeans did commit horrible violence against Jews for almost 2,000 years. But it did not happen in Israel — it happened in Europe.

The Rhineland Massacres of 1096 CE. When the First Crusade was being organised, mobs of poor Christians, peasants, and bandits gathered to march to Jerusalem. On the way, while passing through the Rhineland region of Germany, they decided to attack the local Jewish communities there. Their twisted logic was: “Why should we travel thousands of miles to kill non-Christians, when there are non-Christians (Jews) right here in our own towns?”

Between May and July of 1096, these mobs attacked Jewish communities in the German cities of Worms, Mainz, Speyer, and Cologne. Estimates by modern historians say that between 5,000 and 10,000 Jews were murdered in just these few weeks. Some Jewish families killed themselves rather than be forcibly converted. The story is recorded by a Jewish writer named Solomon bar Simson, who wrote a detailed Hebrew chronicle shortly afterwards.

It is important to note that some local Christian bishops actually tried to protect the Jews. The Bishop of Speyer hid Jewish families and prevented a massacre there. The Archbishop of Mainz also tried, though he failed. The mobs were often beyond the Church’s control. But the underlying religious hatred that allowed such mobs to form in the first place was created by Christian teaching.

The Deicide Myth

The deeper root of Christian violence against Jews was a religious idea called the “deicide charge”. Deicide means killing a god. The charge was that the Jewish people, collectively and for all time, were responsible for killing Jesus — and Christians believe Jesus was God himself in human form.

This idea is false even by Christianity’s own standard. Why? Because the New Testament itself — part of the Christian holy book — says that Jesus was crucified by Roman authority. The Roman governor Pontius Pilate gave the order. Crucifixion was a Roman method of execution. Jews did not execute people that way. And under Roman occupation, Jews did not even have the legal power to execute anyone. Even the Christian gospels (the books about Jesus’s life) admit this. So the idea that “the Jews killed Jesus” is contradicted by the Christian holy book itself.

But the myth was useful for political reasons, so it stayed alive for nearly 2,000 years. It was used to justify expelling Jews from country after country. Jews were expelled from England in 1290. From France in 1306, and again in 1394. From Spain in 1492. From Portugal in 1496. In Italy and Germany they were forced to live in walled-off neighbourhoods called “ghettos”. In 1348, when the plague (a deadly disease called the Black Death) spread, the Jews were blamed for it and massacred. All of this was justified by the deicide myth.

The myth had its final, most horrifying consequence in the Holocaust of 1941 to 1945, when six million Jews were murdered by Nazi Germany. The Nazis were not themselves Christian — but the 2,000 years of Christian anti-Jewish hatred had created the cultural foundation that made something like the Holocaust possible.

The Church Finally Admits It Was a Lie

In 1965, the Catholic Church — the largest Christian denomination in the world — finally issued an official statement rejecting the deicide charge. It was part of a document called *Nostra Aetate*, issued by the Second Vatican Council (a major assembly of the Catholic Church). The document said that the suffering and death of Jesus cannot be blamed on all the Jews living at the time, nor on the Jews living today — and that the Church regretted the centuries of persecution the Jews had suffered.

“What happened in His passion cannot be charged against all the Jews, without distinction, then alive, nor against the Jews of today.”

— Catholic Church, Nostra Aetate, October 28, 1965

Read that carefully. The very Church that benefited from this myth for almost 2,000 years finally admitted, in 1965, that it was wrong. If anyone still believes the old version, the Catholic Church itself disagrees with them. That alone should settle the matter.

VI.

Where Islam Actually Comes From

Now we come to the last piece of the confusion. A common false idea is that Islam came from Jews who fled Israel and split off into a new group. This is not true. Let me explain where Islam actually comes from.

The Setting: Arabia in the 600s CE

Islam emerged in the Arabian Peninsula — the large desert area we now call Saudi Arabia, Yemen, and the Gulf states. (A peninsula is a stretch of land with sea on three of its sides.) Geographically, this is about 1,500 kilometres south of Jerusalem. To put that in perspective, it is roughly the distance from Delhi to Mumbai.

In the year 600 CE, Arabia was not one united country. It was a scattered patchwork of tribes who spoke Arabic and shared some customs but often fought one another. Most Arabs were “polytheists” — meaning they worshipped many gods, not one. The most important religious site in Arabia was a stone building called the Kaaba, in the city of Mecca. Inside the Kaaba were 360 idols of different gods worshipped by different tribes. Pilgrims came from all over Arabia to visit and worship them.

There were also Jewish communities in Arabia — especially in the city of Yathrib, which would later be renamed Medina. These Jews had been there for centuries, possibly ever since the destruction of the First Temple by the Babylonians in 587 BCE. There were also Christian communities scattered around. And from across the border in modern Iran, Zoroastrian Persians were influencing the region too.

The Man and the Movement

In the year 570 CE, a man named Muhammad was born in Mecca. He came from a respectable, but not rich, family of the Quraysh tribe. He grew up to be a successful merchant. He married a wealthy older woman named Khadija. He was known for being honest and trustworthy.

When he was about 40 years old, around 610 CE, Muhammad began having religious experiences. He said the angel Gabriel was appearing to him and giving him messages from God. (An angel is a messenger of God.) These messages, recited over the next 22 years,

would become the Quran — the holy book of Islam. Muhammad began preaching that there was only one God, that the idols of the Kaaba were false, and that the Arabs needed to give up their old religion.

At first, very few people listened. Many people in Mecca were angry, because their income depended on the pilgrims who came to worship the idols. Muhammad and his small group of followers were persecuted. In 622 CE, they fled to Yathrib, which welcomed them. This event is called the Hijra, and it is so important that the Islamic calendar begins from this very year. Yathrib was renamed Medina, which means “City of the Prophet”. (A prophet is a person who delivers a message from God.)

From Medina, Muhammad built a religious and political movement. By the time he died in 632 CE, most of Arabia had accepted Islam. His followers then expanded out of Arabia, and within just 100 years had built one of the largest empires in history — stretching from Spain in the west to India in the east.

So How Is Islam Related to Judaism?

Islam is not a splinter group of Judaism. But it is related to both Judaism and Christianity in important ways. All three religions trace themselves back to the same ancestor — Abraham — who is said to have lived around 1,800 BCE. Because of this shared origin, the three are called the “Abrahamic religions”.

Muhammad acknowledged Jewish prophets like Moses, Abraham, and David, and he also recognised Jesus as an important prophet — though not as God. He believed he was completing and correcting the teachings of these earlier religions, not founding a totally new one. From the Muslim point of view, Islam is the original religion of Abraham, restored and put right.

But the actual peoples — the Arabs and the Jews — were already distinct cultures thousands of years before Muhammad was born. The Arabs descend from peoples who lived in the Arabian Peninsula since prehistoric times. The Jews descend from the Hebrew tribes of ancient Canaan. These are two different historical peoples who share a religious ancestor in their stories, but are not the same people.

“Islam was not a splinter of Judaism. It was a new religious and political movement born in 7th century Arabia, shaped by the unique conditions of that time and place.”

— Fred Donner, Muhammad and the Believers, 2010. Donner is one of the leading scholars on early Islam at the University of Chicago.

A Quick Word on the Word “Judas”

There is one more confusion in the popular story that I want to clear up. The English word “Jew” comes from the word “Judah”. Judah was one of the twelve tribes of ancient Israel, and later it was the name of the southern Jewish kingdom that existed from about 930 BCE to 587 BCE. That kingdom existed almost a thousand years before Jesus was born. The word “Jew”, used for the people, comes from this kingdom name.

Judas Iscariot — the disciple who betrayed Jesus — simply happened to have a common Jewish name of his time. “Judas” was the Greek form of “Judah”, and millions of Jewish men were named that. Confusing the entire Jewish people with one treacherous disciple is like blaming everyone named John today for something one specific John did. It makes no logical sense.

And, by the way, even Jesus himself was Jewish. Jesus’s Hebrew name was Yeshua. So were all his disciples, including Judas. Christianity was originally a Jewish movement that later spread to non-Jews. The idea that there is some ancient hatred between Christians and Jews ignores the fact that the founder of Christianity was himself a Jew.

VII.

What Was Actually Lost

Now we can finally come back to the real point. Strip away all the bad history and the far-fetched conspiracy theories — and the underlying argument still stands strong: Europe did lose something real when it gave up its old religions. And it took a full thousand years, and a lot of blood, to do it.

Loss One: A Living Relationship With Nature

The old religions of Europe were rooted in the land. You could not separate the gods from the forest, the river, or the storm. To respect the gods was to respect the very place you lived in. To pray was to walk into a grove. To celebrate was to gather at a sacred spring.

Christianity moved the “sacred” somewhere else. God was now in heaven — far away, up above. And the land became something separate — something given to humans by God to use. The Christian book of Genesis says God told humans to have dominion over the earth and to “subdue” it. Read that word — “subdue”. The opposite of subdue is respect. Christianity, in its mainstream form, taught that nature was for humans to control, not to revere.

In 1967, a historian named Lynn White Jr. published a famous essay in the scientific journal *Science*. It was called “The Historical Roots of Our Ecological Crisis.” White was himself a Christian. He argued that the way the West thinks about nature — as just a resource to be used — comes directly from Christian theology replacing the older nature-based religions. He said that once the world changed from being “full of spirits” to being just “dead matter”, it became psychologically easier to exploit, pollute, and destroy it.

“By destroying pagan animism, Christianity made it possible to exploit nature in a mood of indifference to the feelings of natural objects.”

— Lynn White Jr., *Science journal*, 1967

Other scholars have argued back, saying it was not Christianity itself but industrial capitalism (the system of factories and profit) that caused the environmental damage. And they have a point. But White’s basic insight is still powerful. When you stop seeing the river

as a god, you start seeing it as just a resource. When the forest is no longer sacred, it becomes just timber. The shift in the mind makes the physical destruction easier.

Loss Two: Local Stories and Local Identity

The old religions were intensely local — that is, each place had its own. Each valley had its own gods. Each spring had its own spirit. Each village had its own sacred place. Your religion was tied to where you were born — to your own hills, your own river, and to the stories your grandmother told you about that particular hill or that particular tree.

Christianity replaced this with a “one size fits all” religion. From Ireland to Russia — the same one God, the same saints, the same Bible. There was something gained in this universal vision: people across vast distances could share something in common. But there was also something lost. The thousand small stories that connected each community to its own specific piece of earth were either forgotten, or replaced with stories from a different desert thousands of miles away.

An interesting point: many of the saints in European Christianity are actually old pagan gods in disguise. Saint Brigid in Ireland was originally the Celtic goddess Brigid. The festival of Christmas was placed on December 25 so that it would overlap with the Roman pagan festival of Sol Invictus and the Germanic winter festival of Yule. Christmas trees, Easter eggs, the Maypole, the Halloween pumpkin, the May Queen — all of these are pagan symbols that survived because people refused to fully let go of them. The Church absorbed them rather than fighting them, because that was the easier road.

Loss Three: A Different Way of Thinking About the Self

The old pagan religions did not have the concept of “original sin”. (Original sin is the belief that every human is born already guilty or flawed.) They did not teach that humans were born broken and needed “salvation”. Some pagan religions had ideas about an afterlife, but it was usually just a continuation of this life — not a reward or a punishment. The Norse believed in Valhalla, where warriors would feast and fight forever. The Greeks believed in a shadowy underworld called Hades. The Celts believed in a beautiful otherworld called Tír na nÓg — the “Land of Youth”.

Christianity introduced a more anxious idea of the self. Because of what Adam and Eve did, you are born guilty. You need to be saved from eternal punishment. Every action could send you to heaven or hell. This gave life a different psychological texture. Whether that was better or worse is a matter of opinion — but it was certainly different.

The German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, writing in the late 1800s, argued that Christianity created a “slave morality” that taught people to be ashamed of their natural

impulses. He was an extreme critic, and his views were complicated. But the basic observation — that the old religions had a more direct, less guilt-ridden relationship with human nature — is shared by many other thinkers too.

Loss Four: Knowledge

When the old religions were destroyed, a lot of practical knowledge was lost along with them. The Druids took 20 years to train. They were not just priests — they were also doctors, astronomers, lawyers, and historians. When the Druids were eliminated, that whole library of accumulated knowledge died with them.

The Library of Alexandria, which held the largest collection of ancient knowledge in the Mediterranean region, was damaged in several stages — but one final major destruction is linked to the rise of Christianity in Egypt in the 300s and 400s CE. In 391 CE, Christian mobs destroyed the Serapeum, a temple complex that housed part of the library. We do not know exactly how much was lost, but it was a lot.

When pagan temples were closed, the handwritten manuscripts they held were often destroyed or reused. Christian monks would sometimes scrape ancient writing off a parchment (an animal-skin page) to write Christian texts over it. Using modern technology we have recovered some of these scraped manuscripts — and we have found lost works of Archimedes (a great ancient scientist) hidden underneath prayers.

Now, to be fair, Christian monasteries also preserved a lot of ancient knowledge during the Middle Ages. Without their work, we would have even less today. But the initial destruction of pagan learning in the 300s and 400s CE set Western knowledge back by centuries.

VIII.

What We Can Still Learn From the Old Ways

I am not saying we should all go back to worshipping trees. The world has changed. We have science now, which gives us far better tools for understanding the physical world than any religion ever did. We know that thunder is an electrical discharge, not Thor's hammer. We know that crops grow because of soil chemistry and water, not because a harvest god is happy. Going backwards is not the answer.

But there are things the old religions got right, and we should remember them.

They Knew We Are Part of Nature, Not Above It

The old religions taught that humans were just one species among many — not the centre of the universe. The forest was not made for us. We were just one of the creatures living in it, alongside the wolves, the deer, the birds, and the spirits. This is much closer to what modern ecology now teaches us than the old Christian view of humans being “given dominion over the earth”.

Today, we face climate change and environmental destruction on a scale our ancestors could not have imagined. Some of our smartest scientists are now arguing that we need to recover something like the old respect for nature — not as a religious belief, but as a practical wisdom. Indigenous peoples in many parts of the world — that is, native peoples who never fully gave up their old religions — are often the best protectors of the remaining forests and rivers. Their religion teaches them to respect the very thing that we are now, through science, learning to respect.

They Knew the Year Had a Rhythm

The old religions marked the year with festivals tied to the seasons. The shortest day of winter. The spring day when light and dark are equal. The longest day of summer. The balanced day of autumn. And the special days in between. Each one had its own celebration, its own foods, its own meaning.

Modern life has largely lost this connection. We work the same hours in December as in June. We eat the same food all year round, shipped in from across the world. We are cut off from the rhythm of the very planet we live on. The old religions were a way of keeping that

connection alive. Even today, the parts of our calendar that still feel meaningful — Christmas, Easter, Halloween — are in fact the parts that survive from the old pagan year, just dressed in Christian clothing.

They Knew Community Was Built Around Shared Stories

Every old religion had its stories, its myths, its heroes. These were not just entertainment. This was the way the community taught its values to its children, the way people made sense of their lives, the way one person's experience got connected to something bigger.

Modern people often feel lonely and disconnected. We have more entertainment than any humans in history, but less shared meaning. We have replaced the village storyteller with the Netflix algorithm. The result is a kind of cultural emptiness that all the streaming content in the world, put together, cannot fill. The old religions, whatever their other flaws, at least gave people a sense of belonging to something larger than themselves.

The Real Lesson

Here is what I want you to take away from all of this. The old religions were not stupid. They were sophisticated systems, built up over thousands of years by people who lived far closer to nature than we do. They were destroyed not because Christianity was somehow more true — but because of politics, marriage strategy, and violence. What was lost was real, and we should be honest about that.

I am not telling you to convert to anything. I am not asking you to give up your current religion, if you have one. I am just asking you to see the history clearly. The version of the story where Europe gracefully chose Christianity because it was the “best” religion is a fairy tale. The real version is more complicated and more uncomfortable.

Real history is heavier than the easy version. But it is also more interesting. And it makes you smarter, because you can now spot the difference between propaganda and truth. That is the real reason to learn history. Not to win arguments. Not to feel superior. But to see the world as it actually was — and as it actually is.



That is the real story. It does not need exaggeration. It is already heavy enough.

IX.

Sources and Further Reading

Every claim in this book can be checked against the following sources. (A “source” is the original book or article the information was taken from.) If you want to argue this position with anyone, these are the names to know. If anyone challenges you, point them here.

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Second Vatican Council. *Nostra Aetate*, 1965. The official Catholic document rejecting the deicide charge against the Jewish people.

Mircea Eliade. *The Sacred and the Profane*, published 1957. Romanian scholar on the difference between pagan and monotheistic religious worldviews.

James C. Russell. *The Germanization of Early Medieval Christianity*, published 1994. On how pagan Germanic culture transformed Christianity from the inside.



The strongest argument is the one that can survive a fact-check.

Make sure yours always can.

THE FORGOTTEN GODS



The Land That Would Not Bend
How India Survived What Europe Did Not

by

LOVEPREET SINGH

— Part Two —

*A continuation of the historical argument, now turning
east to the civilisation that refused to give up its old gods.*

A Note Before We Continue

In the first part of this book, we looked at Europe. We saw how a continent that worshipped its forests and rivers for thousands of years was slowly — and sometimes violently — converted to Christianity. We saw the marriage strategies, the forced baptisms, the Saxon massacres, the Northern Crusades. By the end of it, the old gods of Europe were gone, surviving only in folk customs and the names of the days of the week.

Now we turn east. Because the same forces that conquered Europe also tried to conquer India, China, and Japan. Christianity tried. Islam tried. Both made huge efforts over many centuries. Both poured in missionaries, soldiers, money, and sometimes whole armies. And yet, when you look at India, China, and Japan today, the old religions are still alive. Hinduism, Buddhism, Confucianism, Shinto. They are not museum pieces. They are practised by hundreds of millions of people every day.

How did this happen? Why did the old religions survive in the East when they died in the West? This is one of the most important questions in world history. And the answer, when you really dig into it, is more interesting than any simple story.

I want to be honest with you about something before we start. I am a Punjabi. My family is Sikh. I have grown up around this history. But I am going to try very hard to be fair in this part of the book. I will not pretend India was perfect. I will not pretend the invaders were only bad. The real history is complicated. Some of it is painful. Some of it is glorious. Some of it is embarrassing. I am going to tell you all of it, the way it actually happened.

If you are not Indian, do not skip this section. Because what happened in India has lessons for everyone. It is a case study in how a culture survives an attack on its soul.

Two words to remember again. Two short labels appear all through this book — “CE” and “BCE”. The year of Jesus’s birth is used as the zero point. Years **after** it are “CE” (2026 CE = today). Years **before** it are “BCE”, meaning “Before the Common Era”. BCE years run backwards in time — 2000 BCE is much older than 500 BCE.



Contents of Part Two

- X.** Before History Was Written: The Indus Valley
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Part Three of this book will continue with the European colonisation of India, and Part Four will turn to China and Japan.

“India is the cradle of the human race, the birthplace of human speech, the mother of history, the grandmother of legend, and the great grandmother of tradition.”

— Mark Twain, *Following the Equator*, 1897



This is not a religious attack. It is a historical accounting. Read it with an open mind.

X.

Before History Was Written: The Indus Valley

Let me start with something that will surprise most people. While the Egyptians were still figuring out how to build pyramids, and the people of Europe were still living in scattered villages with wooden huts, there was already a massive civilisation in India with planned cities, indoor plumbing, and standardised weights and measures.

This was the Indus Valley Civilisation. It is one of the great forgotten chapters of world history, and most people, even most Indians, do not know much about it. Let me fix that.

What is the “Indus Valley Civilisation”? It is one of the world’s oldest large civilisations, which flourished around 2600 BCE in the region of the Indus river (mostly in modern Pakistan). It is also called the Harappan Civilisation. (A “civilisation” means a large, organised society with its own cities, trade, writing, and systems.)

The Discovery

In the 1920s, British and Indian archaeologists were digging in what is now Pakistan, near the Indus river. (An archaeologist is a person who digs up and studies the remains of old societies.) They were not expecting to find much. The area was just hills of brick and dust. But when they started digging into one of the hills, they discovered something incredible. Underneath was an entire ancient city. Not just one city. A whole network of them.

The two biggest cities they found were Mohenjo Daro, which means "Mound of the Dead" in Sindhi, and Harappa. Both cities had been built around 2600 BCE. That is over 4,600 years ago. For comparison, the Great Pyramid of Giza in Egypt was built around 2570 BCE. So these Indian cities were built at the same time as the pyramids, but they were doing something completely different. They were not building giant tombs for kings. They were building functional cities for ordinary people to live in.

The Cities That Should Not Have Existed

Here is what makes the Indus Valley cities so amazing. They were laid out in a grid pattern. Wide main streets ran north to south. Narrower streets crossed them east to west. This is

the same basic city design that modern New York and Chandigarh use. But the Indus people figured it out 4,600 years ago.

Every house had a private bathroom. Yes, you read that right. Indoor bathrooms in 2600 BCE. The bathrooms had drains that connected to a citywide sewage system. The sewers were covered with brick slabs that could be lifted for cleaning. Wastewater flowed out of the city through underground channels. Many parts of Europe did not have anything like this until the 1800s CE.

Almost every house had a well for fresh water. There were public bathing pools, including a famous one called the Great Bath at Mohenjo Daro. It was 12 metres long, 7 metres wide, and 2.4 metres deep, lined with carefully cut bricks and waterproofed with a layer of tar. Historians think it was used for religious bathing, but we do not know for sure.

Trade That Stretched Across the Ancient World

The Indus people were not just sitting in their cities. They were trading. Indus seals, which are small carved stones used to mark goods, have been found in Mesopotamia, which is modern Iraq. That is over 2,000 kilometres away. We have Mesopotamian texts from around 2300 BCE that mention trade with a land called Meluhha, which scholars believe was the Indus Valley.

The Indus people traded cotton textiles, beads, copper, and probably timber. They had standardised weights, with the smallest unit being about 0.87 grams. The weights doubled in size as they went up. This shows incredible mathematical sophistication. They had a working number system thousands of years before most people in the world.

A Mystery That Still Cannot Be Solved

There is one frustrating thing about the Indus Valley civilisation. We cannot read their writing.

They had a script (a way of writing). We have found over 4,000 inscriptions on seals, pottery, and tablets. The signs are clear. There are about 400 to 600 different symbols. Some symbols repeat in patterns that suggest a real language. But despite over 100 years of trying, no one has been able to decipher it. We do not know what language the Indus people spoke. We do not know what their cities were really called. We do not know the names of their kings or gods or heroes.

This is one of the great unsolved puzzles of archaeology. Egyptian hieroglyphs were decoded by Jean Francois Champollion in 1822 because of the Rosetta Stone, which had the same text in three scripts. The Indus script has no Rosetta Stone. We just have the symbols themselves, staring back at us silently from a time we cannot reach.

“The Indus civilisation possessed a writing system whose principles still elude us. We can see the marks of a great culture, but we cannot read their words.”

— Asko Parpola, Finnish Indologist who has spent his career studying the script, 1994

What Was Their Religion?

We cannot read their writing, but we can look at what they made. And what they made tells us something important. We have found small clay figurines of women, very richly decorated, that scholars think were figures of a mother goddess. This kind of mother goddess worship is common across the ancient world. The Indus people probably saw nature as a feminine, life giving force.

We have also found a famous seal called the Pashupati seal. It shows a figure sitting in a yoga like position, with horns on his head, surrounded by animals. Some scholars believe this is an early form of the god who would later become Shiva, the Hindu god of destruction and meditation. If they are right, this means some core Hindu ideas are at least 4,500 years old, much older than the Vedic religion that we will talk about in the next chapter.

Other figurines show what look like sacred trees, with people praying near them. Tree worship, just like in pagan Europe. Bull figurines suggest the bull was already a sacred animal, the way it still is in Hindu thought today (Shiva's mount Nandi is a bull). Even though we cannot read their texts, the visual culture of the Indus Valley feels connected to later Indian religion in important ways.

The Sudden Collapse

And then, sometime around 1900 BCE, the Indus Valley civilisation began to fall apart. By 1300 BCE, the great cities were abandoned. What happened? For a long time, historians thought it must have been an invasion. Some early archaeologists imagined Aryan invaders sweeping in and burning the cities. But the evidence does not support this. We do not find layers of weapons or fire damage that you would expect from a military conquest.

The current best theory is that it was climate change. Around this time, the monsoon weather patterns shifted. (The monsoon is the seasonal rain that Indian farming depends on.) One of the major rivers the cities depended on, the Saraswati, dried up. Crops failed. People started moving. The cities were not destroyed in a battle. They just slowly emptied out as people moved east toward the Ganges plain, where there was still water. This is what the historian Michel Danino argues in his 2010 book *The Lost River*, and most modern scholars agree.

But here is the important thing. The Indus people did not disappear. Their genes are still in modern Indians, as DNA studies have confirmed. (DNA is what passes physical traits from parents to children — it can show who descended from whom.) Their cultural ideas, the mother goddess, the meditation pose, the sacred bull, the love of bathing, did not disappear. They got absorbed into the new culture that was forming.

This is the first lesson about India that you need to understand. India does not erase what came before. It absorbs it. It takes the old and folds it into the new. The Indus Valley did not get replaced by the Vedic culture that followed. It got mixed into it. This pattern of absorbing rather than erasing is one of the reasons Hinduism would survive everything that was about to be thrown at it.

XI.

The Vedic Age and the Birth of an Idea That Refused to Die

After the Indus Valley civilisation faded, a new culture rose in north India. This was the Vedic culture, which lasted from about 1500 BCE to 500 BCE. This is when the foundations of what we now call Hinduism were laid down. But here is the thing. Hinduism is not actually one religion. It is more like a family of religions that share some common features. And this is exactly why it would prove so hard to destroy.

Who Were the Vedic People?

This is one of the most argued about questions in Indian history. Some scholars believe a group of people called the Indo Aryans migrated into India from Central Asia around 1500 BCE, bringing their language, their gods, and their rituals. They blended with the people already living there, who included the descendants of the Indus Valley civilisation. Out of this blending came the Vedic culture. This is called the Aryan Migration Theory.

Other scholars, mostly nationalist Indian historians, argue that the Vedic people were already in India, descendants of the Indus Valley people themselves, with no large migration from outside. This is called the Out of India Theory.

The truth, based on the most recent DNA evidence published in major scientific journals in 2018 and 2019, seems to be that both have some truth to them. There was a real migration of people from the steppes of Central Asia into India around 2000 to 1500 BCE. But these migrants did not replace the local population. They mixed with them. Modern north Indians have ancestry from both groups. South Indians have more of the older Indus Valley ancestry. North Indians have more steppe ancestry. But everyone is mixed.

The genetic study by David Reich of Harvard and his international team, published in Science in 2019, is the clearest evidence we have. This is not a political position. It is just what the DNA shows. The Vedic culture was a fusion of old Indian populations and incoming groups, and the result was something new and unique.

The Vedas: The Oldest Books Still in Use

What are the “Vedas”? The Vedas are the oldest sacred texts of Hinduism — a collection of religious hymns/poems composed in Sanskrit. (Sanskrit is a very old, precise language of ancient India, in which most of the old Indian texts were written.)

The Vedic people had no cities at first, but they had something else. They had poems. Long, beautiful, complex religious poems. These poems were memorised by priests and passed down orally for over a thousand years before being written down. When they were finally written, they became the Vedas, the oldest sacred texts of Hinduism.

There are four Vedas. The most important and oldest is the Rigveda. It contains 1,028 hymns to various gods, organised into 10 books called Mandalas. Scholars believe the oldest parts of the Rigveda were composed around 1500 BCE, although some Hindu traditions claim it is much older. Then come the Yajurveda, the Samaveda, and the Atharvaveda, all composed over the next several centuries.

Now here is the part that should blow your mind. The Vedas have been transmitted orally for over 3,000 years with almost perfect accuracy. Vedic priests developed eleven different ways of reciting each verse, with the syllables in different orders, so that if one version got corrupted, the others could correct it. The system was so good that UNESCO recognised Vedic chanting as a Masterpiece of the Oral and Intangible Heritage of Humanity in 2003.

Think about that. While the works of ancient Greek poets like Homer were partly forgotten and partly reconstructed over the centuries, the Vedas survived nearly word for word, in the original ancient Sanskrit language, simply by being recited by trained priests generation after generation. This is one of the great achievements of human memory and discipline.

The Vedic Gods: Old Friends in a New Land

The Vedas tell us who the Vedic people worshipped. And here is where it gets interesting for our story. The Vedic gods are very similar to the gods of pagan Europe.

The chief god of the early Vedic period was Indra, the god of thunder and rain. Sound familiar? Indra is a relative of the Norse Thor, the Slavic Perun, the Greek Zeus, the Roman Jupiter, and the Baltic Perkūnas. (These were the thunder gods we met in Part One.) All of these thunder gods come from the same Proto Indo European root. Indra fights serpents and demons, drinks the magic drink called Soma, and rides a chariot. Zeus fights serpents and demons, drinks ambrosia, and throws lightning. They are brothers, separated by time and distance.

Agni was the god of fire. Fire is central to Vedic ritual. Even today, Hindu weddings, funerals, and many religious ceremonies involve a sacred fire. The Vedic word for father is

pitr. The Sanskrit word for sky father is Dyaus Pita. The Roman word is Jupiter, from Dyeus Pater. The Greek is Zeus Pater. Same word. Same god. Same ancient family.

Surya was the sun god. Soma was a sacred drink, and also a god. Vayu was the wind. Varuna was the cosmic order. Ushas was the dawn, related to the Greek Eos and the Roman Aurora. The Vedic religion was a sister religion to the religions of Europe before Christianity arrived.

“The gods of the Vedas and the gods of pagan Europe descend from a common Indo European ancestral religion that existed about 6,000 years ago on the Eurasian steppe.”

— Wendy Doniger, *The Hindus: An Alternative History*, 2009. Doniger is a leading scholar of Hindu studies.

The Upanishads: The Big Questions

What are the “Upanishads”? The Upanishads are the philosophical texts of the Vedic tradition — not hymns to gods, but recorded conversations between a teacher and a student about life’s deepest questions. (“Philosophy” means thinking deeply about life, truth, and the self.)

Around 800 BCE, something extraordinary happened in India. Maybe people got tired of just performing rituals. Maybe they started asking deeper questions. Whatever the cause, a new set of texts began to appear. These were the Upanishads.

The Upanishads are not hymns to gods. They are philosophical conversations. A student sits with a teacher in the forest, and they discuss the deepest questions humans can ask. What is real? What is the self? Why do we suffer? What happens when we die? Is there a god?

The answers the Upanishads gave became the philosophical foundation of all later Hindu thought, and they influenced Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, and even later Christian and Islamic mystical traditions. Two of the most important ideas were:

Brahman. This is the idea that behind all the apparent variety of the universe, there is one single underlying reality. All the gods, all the stars, all the people, all the animals, all of it is just different forms of one underlying thing. This idea is similar to what philosophers call monism, the idea that everything is one.

Atman. This is the idea that the deepest part of yourself is also Brahman. The self inside you is the same as the cosmic self. The famous phrase from the Chandogya Upanishad is Tat tvam asi, which means "You are that." You are not separate from the universe. You are the universe looking at itself.

These are not simple ideas. They take years to understand properly. But the point is, Indian thought was already producing this level of philosophy in 800 BCE. Compare this to Europe at the same time, which was still in the early Iron Age, with mostly oral tribal religion and no written philosophy that survives. Indian thinkers were asking questions about the nature of reality that European philosophers like Plato would not ask for another 400 years.

Why This Matters for Our Story

I am taking time on this because it is important. When Islam and Christianity later tried to convert India, they were not coming to a place that had no sophisticated religious thinking. They were coming to a place that had already spent over 1,000 years developing some of the deepest philosophy in human history. Indians had already asked all the big questions. They had thought about the nature of God, the soul, suffering, salvation, and ethics. They had multiple competing schools of thought already.

This made conversion very hard. Imagine trying to convert a country full of philosophy professors to a new religion. They are going to ask hard questions. They are going to compare your ideas to ideas they already know. They are not going to just accept things on faith because the foreign missionary says so. This is one of the reasons India proved so resistant to mass religious conversion, even under centuries of foreign rule.

The Buddha and the Great Religious Explosion of 500 BCE

Around 500 BCE, India experienced what some historians call its great religious revolution. In a single century or so, two major new religions appeared. Both were responses to perceived problems with the older Vedic religion, especially its emphasis on ritual sacrifice and the rising power of the Brahmin priestly caste.

Mahavira, born around 599 BCE, founded Jainism. Jainism taught extreme non violence (called ahimsa — the principle of not harming any living being). Even today, traditional Jain monks sweep the ground in front of them so they do not accidentally step on insects. They cover their mouths so they do not accidentally inhale small living beings. The Jain commitment to non violence influenced everything in Indian thought after them.

Siddhartha Gautama, born around 563 BCE in what is now Nepal, founded Buddhism. He was a prince who left his palace to find the cause of suffering. After years of meditation, he claimed to have found enlightenment under a tree in Bodh Gaya, in what is now Bihar. He spent the next 45 years teaching the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path. His teachings would spread across all of Asia. By 200 BCE, Buddhism was the most popular religion in India. By 1000 CE, it was the dominant religion in China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam, Tibet, Mongolia, Sri Lanka, and Southeast Asia.

Both Mahavira and the Buddha taught without violence. They did not need royal marriages or armies to spread their ideas. They convinced people through argument, example, and personal charisma. Their religions spread across most of Asia in just a few centuries, largely peacefully. This is an interesting contrast to how Christianity later spread across Europe with armies and royal decrees.

What India Had Built by 500 BCE

Let me sum up where India was 2,500 years ago. It had:

- Memorised libraries of religious poetry going back over 1,000 years
- A philosophical tradition (the Upanishads) asking the deepest questions about reality
- Three major religions side by side (Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism), all peacefully coexisting
- A sophisticated language, Sanskrit, with grammar rules so precise that they have been admired by modern computer scientists
- Cities, kingdoms, trade routes, and a writing system (Brahmi script) that was the ancestor of most modern South Asian scripts

When Europe was still mostly tribal, India was a network of kingdoms with universities, libraries, and centuries of philosophical tradition. This is not bragging. This is the historical record. And it sets up the next chapter, where we look at the actual golden ages of classical Indian civilisation.

XII.

The Golden Ages: Mauryas, Guptas, and a Civilisation at Its Peak

Now we get to the parts of Indian history that should be taught in every school in the world, but mostly are not. These are the periods when India was, by most measures, the most advanced civilisation on Earth. Not just the richest in absolute size, though it was that. But also the most innovative in mathematics, the most refined in art, the most ambitious in philosophy.

The Mauryan Empire: India Unified

What are an “empire” and a “dynasty”? An empire is a very large state ruling over many regions and peoples. A dynasty is a line of rulers from the same family, ruling one after another.

In 326 BCE, Alexander the Great invaded the north western edge of India. He fought one major battle against an Indian king named Porus on the banks of the Jhelum river. Alexander won the battle, but barely. According to the Greek historians who travelled with him, Alexander was so impressed by Porus's courage that he gave him back his kingdom and even added more territory. Alexander's own soldiers refused to march further into India. They had heard about even larger Indian armies waiting in the east, and they were tired. They turned back.

Within a few years of Alexander's departure, an Indian general named Chandragupta Maurya overthrew the existing Nanda dynasty and founded what would become the largest empire India had ever seen. By 300 BCE, the Mauryan empire stretched from modern Afghanistan in the west to Bangladesh in the east, from the Himalayas in the north to most of south India.

We know about the Mauryan empire from several sources, including a Greek ambassador named Megasthenes who lived at the Mauryan capital Pataliputra (modern Patna) around 300 BCE. Megasthenes wrote a book called Indica. The book itself is lost, but other Greek writers quoted from it. He described Pataliputra as being larger than any city he had seen, with wooden walls 30 kilometres around, 64 gates, and 570 towers. The population was

somewhere between 250,000 and 400,000 people. By comparison, Rome at the same time had maybe 150,000 people, and Athens had about 100,000.

Chanakya: The Ancient Strategist Who Wrote the Book on Power

The man who advised Chandragupta and helped him conquer the empire was named Chanakya, also called Kautilya. Chanakya was a teacher at the ancient university of Takshashila (sometimes spelled Taxila), in what is now Pakistan. He wrote a book called the Arthashastra, which is one of the most important books on politics, war, economics, and statecraft ever written.

The Arthashastra was written around 300 BCE, which makes it 1,800 years older than Machiavelli's famous *The Prince*. And honestly, the Arthashastra is more thorough. Machiavelli's book is about 100 pages. The Arthashastra is over 600 pages. It covers everything from how to run a spy network, to how to manage trade routes, to how to inspect mines, to how to grow crops, to how to choose ministers, to how to deal with traitors.

Chanakya's basic philosophy was that the king has one job: to ensure the welfare of his subjects. Everything else, including morality in the conventional sense, can be set aside if it helps the welfare of the people. This is realist political thinking at its hardest. Modern political scientists still study the Arthashastra.

Ashoka the Great: A Conqueror Who Stopped Conquering

Chandragupta's grandson was named Ashoka. He ruled from 268 BCE to 232 BCE. Ashoka started out as a typical aggressive king. He fought a brutal war to conquer the kingdom of Kalinga, which is roughly modern Odisha. According to his own later inscriptions, 100,000 people were killed and 150,000 were taken as captives. Many more died from starvation and disease after the war.

But then something strange happened. Ashoka was horrified by what he had done. He converted to Buddhism. He renounced violence as a tool of state policy. He carved his new philosophy onto rock pillars and cliff faces across his empire, in multiple languages including the local script and Greek. Some of these pillars and rocks still stand today, and you can read his words. They are the oldest surviving large pieces of writing in India.

Ashoka's edicts ask people to respect all religions, treat servants well, take care of animals, and avoid violence. He set up hospitals not just for humans but for animals. He banned animal sacrifice in his palace. He sent Buddhist missionaries to Sri Lanka, Burma, Egypt, Syria, Greece, and Macedonia.

Think about this. While most of the world was still ruled by warlords who measured their greatness by how many people they killed, India had a king who carved into stone that he was sorry for the people he had killed and that he wished he had not. There is no other ancient ruler quite like Ashoka.

“Amidst the tens of thousands of names of monarchs that crowd the columns of history, the name of Ashoka shines, and shines almost alone, a star.”

— H. G. Wells, *The Outline of History*, 1920

The Ashoka emblem, with four lions on top of a stone pillar, is now the national emblem of modern India. The wheel from that pillar is in the centre of the Indian flag. That is how important Ashoka still is to Indian identity today.

The Gupta Empire: India's Classical Golden Age

The Mauryan empire eventually collapsed about 50 years after Ashoka's death. India broke into smaller kingdoms again. But then, around 320 CE, another great dynasty rose. This was the Gupta dynasty, sometimes called India's Golden Age.

The Gupta empire was not as territorially huge as the Mauryan empire, but it was richer, more culturally creative, and more scientifically advanced. The Gupta period, roughly 320 CE to 550 CE, is when India produced some of its greatest works of art, mathematics, astronomy, and literature.

Some of the things that happened during the Gupta period:

- The mathematician Aryabhata, born 476 CE, wrote a book called the *Aryabhatiya*. In it, he correctly stated that the Earth rotates on its axis. He calculated the length of the solar year as 365.358 days, off by only a few hours. He estimated pi to four decimal places. He laid down the foundations of trigonometry. All of this in 499 CE, when most of Europe was struggling through the collapse of Rome.
- The poet Kalidasa wrote his great plays and poems, including *Shakuntala*. When it was translated into German in 1791, the philosopher Goethe was so moved that he wrote a poem of praise about it.
- The system of Indian classical music with its ragas and talas began to take its final shape.
- Indian medicine reached high refinement. The *Sushruta Samhita* describes over 300 surgical operations, including cataract surgery and plastic surgery for the nose. Indian doctors were doing nose reconstruction in 600 CE.
- The university of Nalanda was founded in what is now Bihar. We will come back to Nalanda because it deserves its own discussion.

Fa Xian: The Chinese Monk Who Visited

How do we know India was rich and peaceful during the Gupta period? Because we have eyewitness accounts. A Chinese Buddhist monk named Fa Xian travelled from China to India between 399 CE and 414 CE. He came to collect Buddhist texts and to visit the holy sites of Buddhism. He spent about ten years in India and then went home and wrote a detailed account of his travels.

Fa Xian described India as a peaceful and prosperous place. He said the roads were safe. He said people did not need to lock their doors. He said the government was light handed. People did not have to register with the authorities or carry papers. The punishments were mostly fines, not corporal punishment. Most people were vegetarian. There were public hospitals where the sick could go for free care.

Two hundred years later, another Chinese monk named Xuanzang made the same journey. He spent fifteen years in India, from 630 CE to 645 CE, and his account is even more detailed. He studied at Nalanda University for years. His travel writings give us one of the best windows we have into classical India.

Nalanda: The Greatest University of the Ancient World

I want to spend some time on Nalanda University because it is one of the most amazing institutions in history, and most people, even most Indians, do not know much about it.

Nalanda was founded around 427 CE in what is now Bihar, India. By the 600s CE, when Xuanzang visited, it had over 10,000 students and around 2,000 teachers. Yes, you read that right. Ten thousand students. In one university. In the 600s CE.

To put that in perspective, the University of Oxford was founded in 1096 CE, almost 700 years after Nalanda was already running. When Oxford got started, it had a few dozen students. Nalanda had been operating with thousands of students for centuries.

Nalanda was a residential university (students lived there). Students from all over Asia came to study there. They came from China, Korea, Japan, Tibet, Sri Lanka, Indonesia, Persia, and Turkey. They had to pass entrance exams. Xuanzang said only about 30 percent of applicants got in. The campus had multiple temples, libraries, dormitories, lecture halls, and gardens, all built of brick on a planned grid. It was its own little city.

What did they teach? Almost everything. Buddhist philosophy was the main subject, but they also taught Hindu Vedic studies, logic, grammar, medicine, astronomy, mathematics, metaphysics, and probably much more. The library, called Dharmaganja, was housed in three buildings. One of them was nine stories tall. It was said to contain hundreds of thousands of manuscripts.

Nalanda kept running, with ups and downs, for almost 800 years. Then in 1193 CE, it was destroyed. The Turkic invader Bakhtiyar Khalji burned it to the ground as part of the early Islamic conquest of north India. According to the Persian historian Minhaj e Siraj, the library burned for three months. Thousands of monks were killed. The university was never rebuilt.

We will come back to this destruction in the next chapter. For now, just understand what was lost. Imagine if a foreign army today destroyed Oxford, Cambridge, Harvard, and Yale all at once, and burned every book in them. That is what happened to Nalanda. We do not know how much of Indian mathematics, science, and philosophy died in those flames.

“The destruction of Nalanda was one of the great cultural catastrophes in world history, comparable to the destruction of the library of Alexandria.”

— Romila Thapar, eminent Indian historian, in *The Penguin History of Early India*, 2002

How Big Was the Indian Economy?

What is “GDP”? GDP is the total value of all the goods and services a country produces in a year — in simple terms, a way of measuring how big an economy is. “One third of world GDP” means about a third of everything earned worldwide at that time was earned in India alone.

Let me give you some economic numbers, because this part is rarely taught and is important. The British economist Angus Maddison spent his career estimating the size of historical economies. His research is the standard reference used by historians and the World Bank.

According to Maddison's estimates, in the year 1 CE, India had roughly one third of the world's total GDP. China had another quarter. Together, India and China made up about 60 percent of the world economy. Europe was a small player. Rome at its peak was rich, but the whole western Roman empire combined was probably no bigger than India alone.

By 1000 CE, India still had roughly 25 to 30 percent of world GDP. By 1500 CE, it was still around 24 percent. When the British were just starting to build their empire in the 1700s, India was still the largest economy in the world, with about 24 percent of world GDP, slightly more than China and far more than any European power.

Then comes the British conquest, the deindustrialisation of India, the famines, the wealth extraction, and by 1947, when the British left, India's share of world GDP had collapsed to about 4 percent. But that is a story for Part Three of this book.

The point is, for almost 2,000 years of recorded history, India was one of the two richest civilisations on Earth. It was not a backwater. It was not poor. It was not technologically

behind. It was, for most of human history, ahead of Europe in almost every measurable way.

XIII.

What India Gave the World

Let me take a chapter to focus on specific contributions India made to human knowledge. This is not bragging. This is just the historical record. Many of these things are so common today that we forget they had to be invented somewhere. They were invented in India.

The Number Zero

I am going to start with the biggest one. India invented zero.

Other civilisations had concepts of nothing. The Babylonians used a placeholder. The Mayans had a symbol for empty. But India was the first to treat zero as a real number that you could do math with. Zero plus five is five. Zero times five is zero. You can have negative numbers because of zero. You can have decimals because of zero. You can do algebra because of zero. Without zero, modern mathematics is impossible. And without modern mathematics, modern science is impossible. And without modern science, modern technology is impossible.

The first clear use of zero as a number, with all its mathematical rules, is found in the work of an Indian mathematician named Brahmagupta. In his book *Brahmasphutasiddhanta*, written in 628 CE, Brahmagupta laid out the rules for how zero works. He defined what happens when you add, subtract, multiply, and divide by zero. He also worked with negative numbers, which were also an Indian innovation.

The Indian number system, with its ten digits including zero, then made its way to the Arab world around 800 CE through Persian and Arab traders. From there it spread to Europe, where it slowly replaced the awkward Roman numeral system. That is why we call our number system Arabic numerals today, even though they are really Indian numerals that travelled through Arabia. The Arabs themselves called them Hindi numerals. They knew where they came from.

Without Indian numerals and the concept of zero, you would not have computers. You would not have rockets. You would not have your phone. Almost every piece of modern technology depends on math that depends on zero. India gave the world this.

The Decimal System

Connected to zero is the decimal place value system. This is the way we write numbers today. The position of a digit tells you its value. The 5 in 50 means fifty. The 5 in 500 means five hundred. This is so obvious to us now that we cannot imagine writing numbers any other way. But for most of human history, no one used this system.

The Romans wrote 1,847 as MDCCCXLVII. Try multiplying MDCCCXLVII by CCXIV in your head. You can't. Roman numerals make complex math nearly impossible. This is one of the reasons advanced math was so hard in medieval Europe.

The Indian decimal system makes math easy. That algorithm we all learned in school was developed in India and then translated into Arabic by a Persian mathematician named Al Khwarizmi around 825 CE. His book was later translated into Latin, and the European word "algorithm" comes from his name. So even the word algorithm has Indian and Persian roots.

Trigonometry and the Sine Function

When you studied math in school, you probably hated sine and cosine. But you should know that these functions, which are essential for everything from architecture to GPS satellites, were developed in India.

The Greek mathematician Hipparchus had developed a basic version of trigonometry using chords of circles. But the modern sine function, which is much more useful, was developed by Aryabhata around 500 CE. The word sine itself is interesting. Aryabhata called this concept *jya*, which means "bowstring" in Sanskrit. Arab mathematicians translated it as *jiba*, then misread it as *jaib*, which means "pocket" or "bay" in Arabic. When Europeans translated this from Arabic, they translated "bay" as *sinus* in Latin. And that became "sine" in English. So sine is a Latin translation of an Arab mistranslation of a Sanskrit word for a bowstring.

Surgery and Medicine

I mentioned the Sushruta Samhita earlier. Let me give you more detail. Sushruta is sometimes called the father of surgery. He lived in India sometime between 800 BCE and 600 BCE, which is incredibly early. His medical text, the Sushruta Samhita, was finalised in roughly its current form by around 500 CE.

The book describes 121 surgical instruments. It describes how to perform over 300 surgical operations, organised into eight categories. It includes plastic surgery, cataract removal, kidney stone removal, cesarean section, and many others. The plastic surgery technique for rebuilding noses, called the Indian method, is still used today and is the foundation of all modern rhinoplasty.

Indian doctors also developed advanced ideas about hygiene long before Europeans did. Surgical instruments were boiled before use. Patients were given alcoholic drinks to numb pain. Wounds were cleaned with antiseptic herbs. These ideas would not reach mainstream European medicine until the 1800s.

Yoga and Meditation

Modern people often see yoga as just exercise. But yoga is a very old Indian system of physical, mental, and spiritual practice. The earliest references to yoga appear in the Upanishads. Around 200 BCE to 400 CE, a sage named Patanjali compiled the Yoga Sutras, which laid out the eight limbs of yoga.

Yoga is now practised by hundreds of millions of people worldwide. Modern scientific studies have confirmed that regular yoga practice reduces stress, improves flexibility, helps with chronic pain, and may even help with mental health conditions. What started as a spiritual practice in India over 2,000 years ago is now a global health phenomenon. Meditation, similarly, is now used by neuroscientists, therapists, and millions of ordinary people. All of this is rooted in techniques developed by Indian and Buddhist practitioners thousands of years ago.

Sanskrit Grammar: The First Linguistics

Around 500 BCE, an Indian grammarian named Panini wrote a book called Ashtadhyayi. This is a book of grammar for Sanskrit, and it is one of the most amazing works in the history of human thought.

Panini's Ashtadhyayi contains 3,959 rules that describe the grammar of Sanskrit. The rules are written in a very compact, technical style, almost like a computer program. Modern linguists in the 1900s were stunned when they realised that Panini had essentially invented formal linguistics 2,500 years before they had. Some computer scientists have argued that Panini's rules influenced the development of computer programming languages, because they showed how you could describe any sentence by combining a small number of basic rules.

Chess

The game of chess was invented in India around the 500s CE. It was originally called chaturanga, which means "four parts" or "four divisions of the army" in Sanskrit. These four divisions, infantry, cavalry, elephants, and chariots, became the modern pawns, knights, bishops, and rooks. The game spread from India to Persia, where it was called shatranj. From Persia it spread to the Arab world, and from there to Europe by around 1000 CE. If you have ever played chess, you have played a game invented in India.

Spices and Cotton

On the practical side, India was the world's main source of spices for thousands of years. Black pepper, cardamom, cinnamon, cloves, ginger, turmeric. These were all major Indian exports. European explorers like Vasco da Gama originally sailed for India specifically to find a sea route to these spices. Christopher Columbus was trying to reach India when he accidentally discovered America. He called the indigenous people he met "Indians" because he thought he had reached India.

India was also the source of fine cotton textiles. Indian muslin, made in Bengal, was famous for being so fine that an entire dress could be passed through a wedding ring. European traders in the 1600s and 1700s imported huge quantities of Indian cotton, which was better quality than anything European weavers could make. The British Industrial Revolution was partly driven by the British trying to mechanise textile production so they could compete with Indian cotton. They eventually succeeded, but only by deliberately destroying the Indian textile industry through high tariffs and broken supply chains. We will get to this in Part Three.

The Concept of Religious Pluralism

Finally, India gave the world something that is harder to point to but maybe more important than any specific invention. It gave the world the idea that many religions can be true at the same time.

In most of the ancient and medieval world, religions tended to be exclusive. The Christian believed Christianity was the only true religion. The Muslim believed Islam was the only true religion. The Jew believed Judaism was the chosen one. To disagree was to be wrong, and being wrong about religion could get you killed.

Indian religious thought, especially Hindu thought, took a different view. The basic Hindu teaching, found in the Rigveda itself, is that Ekam sat vipra bahudha vadanti, which means "truth is one, the wise speak of it in many ways." The same divine reality can be approached by many paths. Different religions are different routes up the same mountain.

This idea allowed Hinduism to coexist with Buddhism, Jainism, and later Sikhism inside India for thousands of years without religious wars between them. It also allowed small Jewish, Christian, and Zoroastrian communities to settle in India and live peacefully for centuries when they were being persecuted everywhere else. The Jews of Kerala have been there since possibly the time of King Solomon, around 1000 BCE. They were never persecuted in India. The Christians of Kerala, the Saint Thomas Christians, trace their origins to the apostle Thomas himself, who they say came to India in 52 CE. The Parsis,

who are Zoroastrians from Persia, fled to India in the 700s CE to escape Muslim persecution in their homeland. India took them in.

“India was unique in the ancient world in providing a stable home for religious minorities who fled persecution elsewhere. It is a record of tolerance that few civilisations can match.”

— Romila Thapar, The Penguin History of Early India, 2002

This is important to remember. When Islam and Christianity later came to India with their certainty that they were the only true religion, they were coming to a place that had developed an entirely different way of thinking about religion. India did not see religions as rivals competing for the same truth. It saw them as different expressions of the same deeper reality.

This was either a strength or a weakness depending on how you look at it. It made Hinduism flexible and resilient. But it also made it slow to recognise threats. When invaders came who did not share this pluralist view, who believed their religion was the only one and that others should be destroyed, India sometimes did not know how to respond. We will see this dynamic play out in the next chapter.

XIV.

The First Wave: Islam Arrives in India

Now we get to one of the most difficult chapters in Indian history. The arrival of Islam. I am going to try to tell this story honestly. Some of it is brutal and painful. Some of it is more complicated than the simple version usually told. I will not soften the violence, but I will also not pretend that every Muslim who came to India came with a sword in his hand. The real history is messier than that.

Two Different Waves

Before we go further, I need to make an important distinction. Islam came to India in two very different ways, at very different times, with very different consequences.

The first way was peaceful. Arab traders had been doing business with the Malabar coast of south India for centuries, even before Islam was founded. When these traders converted to Islam in the 600s and 700s CE, they brought their new religion with them to India. They settled in port cities like Calicut, Cochin, and Quilon. They married local women. They built mosques. They lived peacefully alongside Hindu and Christian neighbours. The Muslim community of Kerala, called the Mappila Muslims, has been there for over 1,300 years. They are deeply Indian. They speak Malayalam. They eat Indian food. There was no conquest. There was no forced conversion. Just centuries of trade and cultural exchange.

The second way was violent. Starting in the 700s CE, and especially from the 1000s CE onward, Muslim armies began invading India from the northwest. These were not traders. They were soldiers, often led by Turkic, Persian, or Afghan generals. They came for conquest. And the consequences for India were massive.

Both stories are true. Both happened. We need to talk about both, honestly.

What was the “jizya”? The jizya was a tax that non Muslims had to pay separately under some Muslim rulers. Paying it allowed them to keep practising their own religion.

The First Invasion: Muhammad bin Qasim, 712 CE

The first major Muslim military expedition to India was led by a 17 year old Arab general named Muhammad bin Qasim in 712 CE. He was sent by the Umayyad Caliphate, which

was the dominant Muslim power at the time, based in Damascus. His official reason for invading was to punish the Sindhi king Raja Dahir for attacks on Arab ships near the coast.

Muhammad bin Qasim's forces defeated Raja Dahir at the Battle of Aror. Dahir was killed. The conquered region was Sindh, which is now in southern Pakistan. What happened next is debated. Some sources say Muhammad bin Qasim massacred large numbers of non Muslims. Other sources say he was relatively tolerant, allowing Hindus and Buddhists to practise their religions in exchange for paying the jizya tax. The truth is probably somewhere in the middle. There was violence during the conquest, but afterwards the new rulers mostly let people live their lives, because killing your subjects is bad for tax collection.

Importantly, the Arab invasion of 712 CE only got as far as Sindh. They did not penetrate into the rest of India. The Pratiharas, Palas, and Rashtrakutas, who were the main Indian dynasties of that time, successfully blocked any further Arab expansion. For the next 300 years, the Arab Muslim presence in India remained limited to Sindh and the coastal trading communities. India as a whole remained Hindu and Buddhist.

Mahmud of Ghazni: The Raider, 1000 to 1027 CE

The real shift began with a man named Mahmud of Ghazni. He was a Turkic ruler of an empire centered in what is now Afghanistan. Between 1000 and 1027 CE, Mahmud led seventeen separate raids into northern India.

Mahmud was not trying to conquer India in any permanent way. He was a raider. He would gather his army, sweep into India, attack a wealthy city or temple, loot everything he could carry, kill resistance, and then leave. His raids were enabled by the fact that India was politically divided. There was no central Indian state to coordinate defence. Each Hindu king defended only his own territory, and Mahmud could pick them off one at a time.

The most famous and most destructive of his raids was the sack of the Somnath temple in Gujarat in 1025 CE. Somnath was one of the holiest Hindu temples, dedicated to Shiva. It had been built and rebuilt for over a thousand years. According to Persian historians who wrote about Mahmud's raids, the temple was hugely wealthy, decorated with gold and jewels and visited by thousands of pilgrims.

Mahmud's army broke into the temple. The defenders were killed. Persian sources give numbers of 50,000 defenders killed, although this might be exaggerated. Mahmud personally smashed the main Shiva lingam idol with a mace. He loaded the temple's treasure onto camels and took it back to Ghazni. The temple was destroyed.

The Somnath raid became a wound in Hindu memory that has never fully healed. It is still talked about today, almost 1,000 years later. The temple has been rebuilt several times, most recently after Indian independence in 1951. Each time, it has been rebuilt as a statement that what was destroyed can be rebuilt.

It is important to note that Mahmud's raids were motivated by both religious zeal and pure greed. He was a Muslim and he believed destroying Hindu idols was a religious duty. But he was also a king who needed to pay his soldiers and finance his other wars. The wealth he took from India funded his entire empire. Both motivations were real. We should not pretend it was only religious. But we should not pretend religion played no role either.

Why Could This Happen? The Political Problem

Here is something important. By the year 1000 CE, India was the largest and richest civilisation in the world. It had brilliant mathematicians, beautiful art, thousands of temples, deep philosophy. Yet a Turkic warlord based in poor, mountainous Afghanistan could raid it almost at will. How?

The answer is political fragmentation. India in 1000 CE was not one country. It was dozens of competing Hindu kingdoms. The Pala empire in the east. The Pratiharas in the centre. The Chola empire in the south. These kingdoms spent most of their time fighting each other. When Mahmud invaded, each kingdom defended only itself. There was no coordinated all India response.

Add to this the caste system.

What is the “caste system”? In ancient India, society was divided into fixed groups (castes) by birth, and each group's work was mostly fixed. For example, fighting was supposed to be done only by the Kshatriya (warrior) caste, which was a small part of the population.

The actual fighting was supposed to be done only by the Kshatriya warrior caste, which was a small percentage of the population. Hundreds of thousands of farmers, merchants, and craftsmen lived in any kingdom that was invaded, but they were not trained to fight. They could not pick up swords and defend their homes. This was a structural weakness that India would not really solve until much later.

The historian Al Biruni, a Persian Muslim scholar who travelled with Mahmud of Ghazni and wrote a careful study of Indian culture called the Kitab al Hind, noticed this weakness himself. He wrote that the Hindus were brilliant in science and mathematics but politically and militarily disorganised. Al Biruni's book is one of our best sources on India in 1000 CE, and it is remarkably fair minded. He admired Indian achievements even as he served the man who was looting them.

“The Hindus believe that there is no country but theirs, no nation like theirs, no kings like theirs, no science like theirs... Yet I confess that their science is in many fields ahead of ours.”

— Al Biruni, Kitab al Hind, around 1030 CE

Al Biruni was being critical, but the criticism contains a real insight. India's confidence in its own superiority, which was largely earned, also made it slow to take seriously the threat from poorer, less developed regions like Afghanistan. Why would the great Indian civilisation worry about some warlord from the mountains? It turned out to be a costly mistake.

The Big One: Muhammad of Ghor and the Battle of Tarain, 1192 CE

Mahmud of Ghazni's raids were just preview. The real conquest came almost 200 years later, with a man named Muhammad of Ghor. He was a Turkic Persian ruler from what is now Afghanistan.

Muhammad of Ghor began invading north India in the 1170s CE. The main Hindu power blocking him was a confederation of Rajput kingdoms led by a young king named Prithviraj Chauhan, who ruled from Delhi and Ajmer.

In 1191 CE, the two armies met at Tarain, near modern Karnal in Haryana. Prithviraj Chauhan won. The Rajput cavalry broke the Ghorid lines, and Muhammad of Ghor himself was nearly captured. He fled back to Afghanistan to regroup. If Prithviraj had pursued and finished him, much of Indian history might have been different.

Instead, Prithviraj let Muhammad of Ghor go. Why? Because in Rajput tradition, you did not chase a defeated enemy. You let him retreat with dignity. This was considered honourable. Muhammad of Ghor did not share this code. He went home, raised a bigger army, and came back the next year.

In 1192 CE, at the Second Battle of Tarain, the two armies met again. This time, Muhammad of Ghor used different tactics. He sent his light cavalry to harass the slow moving, heavily armoured Rajput forces. He attacked at dawn while the Rajputs were still preparing. He used feigned retreats to pull Rajput cavalry into traps. Prithviraj Chauhan was defeated and captured. According to Persian sources, he was eventually executed.

The Second Battle of Tarain in 1192 CE is one of the most important dates in Indian history. It opened the gates of north India to Muslim political rule that would last, in various forms, for over 600 years. From this point until 1857, when the British formally

ended the last Mughal emperor's reign, large parts of India would be ruled by Muslim dynasties.

The Destruction of Nalanda, 1193 CE

One year after Tarain, Muhammad of Ghor's general Bakhtiyar Khalji marched east into Bihar and Bengal. In 1193 CE, he reached Nalanda, the great university we talked about in chapter twelve.

What happened next is one of the great tragedies of human history. Bakhtiyar Khalji's forces attacked Nalanda. The monks were killed or fled. The buildings were burned. The library, with its hundreds of thousands of manuscripts representing 800 years of accumulated knowledge, was set on fire. The Persian historian Minhaj e Siraj, writing about 70 years after the event, says the library burned for several months. Whole categories of human knowledge were lost forever in those flames.

Nalanda was not the only victim. Other great Indian universities, including Vikramashila and Odantapuri in the same region, were also destroyed around this time. The entire centre of Buddhist learning in north India was wiped out. Buddhism, which had been a major religion in India for over 1,500 years, essentially disappeared from its homeland in the next century. This is why Buddhism, the most peaceful and philosophical religion India ever produced, is now barely present in India itself, while it thrives in countries it spread to.

I want to be clear about something. The destruction of Nalanda was not a misunderstanding or an accident of war. It was deliberate cultural destruction. There was no military necessity to burn the library. The library posed no threat. It was burned because the books in it represented a rival worldview, and the conquerors wanted that worldview erased. When you burn a library, you are not just killing the present. You are killing the future.

Important Honest Notes

Before we move on, I want to put a few things in proper perspective, because the history of medieval Islamic conquests in India is often weaponised by people with political agendas in modern India. I do not want to be one of those people.

First. Muslim invaders and rulers did destroy many Hindu temples. This is a documented fact. The historian Richard Eaton, in his book *Temple Desecration and Muslim States in Medieval India* (2000), did careful research on this and identified about 80 temples that were definitely destroyed by Muslim rulers between 1192 and 1729 CE. Older Hindu nationalist sources sometimes claim numbers like 60,000 destroyed temples, which

Eaton's research shows is not supported by evidence. The real number is far lower than the inflated claims, but still substantial and significant.

Second. Most temple destruction happened in the context of conquest. Conquering a region and destroying its main religious symbols was a way of saying "we are in charge now." This is brutal, but it was also a normal practice of medieval conquerors of all religions. Christians did this to pagan temples in Europe. The pattern was about establishing political dominance, not just about religion. Religion was the language in which that dominance was expressed.

Third. Not all Muslim rulers in India were destroyers. Many were great builders. The Mughals built the Taj Mahal, the Red Fort, and hundreds of other beautiful monuments that are now treasured parts of India's heritage. Akbar, the third Mughal emperor, made a serious effort to learn from Hindu, Christian, Zoroastrian, and Jain scholars and promoted religious tolerance. Many ordinary Muslims who lived in India for generations became as Indian as anyone else. Indian music, food, architecture, and dress all owe huge debts to Islamic influence.

Fourth. Most ordinary Indian Muslims today are not descendants of invaders. They are descendants of Indian Hindus and Buddhists who converted over centuries, often peacefully, sometimes under pressure but rarely at swordpoint. Many converted to escape the worst aspects of the caste system, since Islam was officially egalitarian even if it did not always live up to that in practice. Indian Muslims are as Indian as Indian Hindus. They share the same blood, the same land, and most of the same culture. Anyone who tells you Indian Muslims are foreign is lying.

Holding these four facts together honestly is hard. It requires acknowledging that real harms were done in the past, while also acknowledging that those harms cannot be visited on people living today. It requires distinguishing between what kings and armies did and what ordinary people did. It requires neither pretending the destruction did not happen nor exaggerating it for modern political purposes. This is the kind of honest history I am trying to do. I hope you will hold me to it.

XV.

The Sultanate, the Mughals, and the Long Conquest

After Muhammad of Ghor's victory at Tarain in 1192 CE, north India entered a new phase. For the next 320 years, north India was ruled by a series of Muslim dynasties known collectively as the Delhi Sultanate. Then in 1526 CE, a new dynasty took over: the Mughals. They would rule, in effect, until 1857 CE. That is over 660 years of Muslim political rule in north India. This is roughly the same length of time that has passed since Columbus reached America. It is a huge stretch of history with many layers.

What are the “Sultanate” and the “Mughals”? A “Sultanate” means rule by a Sultan (a Muslim king) — here, the line of Muslim dynasties that ruled from Delhi from 1206 to 1526. The “Mughals” were a powerful Muslim dynasty that came after 1526 and ruled most of South Asia for centuries.

The Five Dynasties of the Delhi Sultanate

The Delhi Sultanate was not one continuous government. It was actually five different dynasties that succeeded each other in Delhi between 1206 and 1526 CE. Each had its own character. Let me run through them quickly.

The Slave Dynasty (1206 to 1290 CE). Also called the Mamluk Dynasty. The first ruler was Qutb ud din Aibak, a former slave who had been a general for Muhammad of Ghor. When Muhammad of Ghor died in 1206, Aibak set himself up as the Sultan of Delhi. Several of his successors were also former slaves who had risen through the military. The Slave Dynasty built the famous Qutub Minar in Delhi, a 73 metre tall minaret that you can still visit today.

The Khalji Dynasty (1290 to 1320 CE). The most famous Khalji ruler was Ala ud din Khalji. He was a brilliant general but also one of the most ruthless rulers in Indian history. He launched a series of military campaigns that pushed the Sultanate's territory deep into south India for the first time. He also implemented harsh economic controls, fixing prices and seizing wealth from his subjects. He is the king played by Ranveer Singh in the 2018 movie *Padmaavat*, although the historical accuracy of that film is highly questionable.

The Tughlaq Dynasty (1320 to 1414 CE). The Tughlaqs were Turkic Indian rulers. The most famous was Muhammad bin Tughlaq, who tried some incredibly ambitious projects. He moved his capital from Delhi to Daulatabad in central India, forcing the entire population of Delhi to march hundreds of kilometres. When that did not work, he forced them to march back. He also tried introducing a token currency made of copper, which collapsed when people figured out how to forge it. He is sometimes called the wisest fool in Indian history.

The Sayyid Dynasty (1414 to 1451 CE). A short and weak dynasty that only ruled a small area around Delhi.

The Lodi Dynasty (1451 to 1526 CE). The Lodis were Afghan rulers who briefly revived the Sultanate's power. The last Lodi ruler, Ibrahim Lodi, was killed at the First Battle of Panipat in 1526 CE, which we will come to in a moment.

The Timur Invasion, 1398 CE

I want to single out one event from the Sultanate period because it was catastrophic. In 1398 CE, the Central Asian conqueror Timur, also known as Tamerlane, invaded India.

Timur was a Turkic Mongol descendant of Genghis Khan, and he was already famous for his conquests across Persia, Iraq, Syria, and Central Asia. His invasion of India was brief but devastating. He swept into Delhi, defeated the Tughlaq armies, and sacked the city.

According to Timur's own court historian, Sharaf ad Din Ali Yazdi, Timur ordered the massacre of more than 100,000 Hindu and Muslim prisoners in Delhi before the city was sacked. He thought they might rise up during the looting. When the looting began, the death toll was much higher. Modern estimates suggest 200,000 or more people died in the sack of Delhi. The city was almost completely depopulated. It would not recover for over a century.

Timur did not stay. He took the loot back to his capital at Samarkand. This is important to remember when we talk about the Mughals next, because Babur, the founder of the Mughal dynasty, was a direct descendant of Timur on his father's side. The Mughals saw themselves as Timur's heirs.

The First Battle of Panipat, 1526 CE

The end of the Delhi Sultanate came on April 21, 1526, at a place called Panipat, about 90 kilometres north of Delhi.

A Central Asian prince named Babur, originally from the Fergana valley in modern Uzbekistan, had been carving out a kingdom for himself in Afghanistan. He was a

descendant of both Timur (through his father) and Genghis Khan (through his mother). He had a small but well organised army with one important advantage: gunpowder weapons. He had cannons and matchlock muskets, which were still rare in India.

Babur invaded India and met Ibrahim Lodi's much larger army at Panipat. Babur had perhaps 12,000 to 15,000 men. Lodi had perhaps 50,000 to 100,000, including hundreds of war elephants. It should have been a Lodi victory. But Babur used his cannons to break the Lodi lines, sent his cavalry to circle around, and crushed the larger army within hours. Ibrahim Lodi was killed in the battle. Babur took Delhi and Agra. The Mughal dynasty was born.

The Mughals: Six Great Emperors, 1526 to 1707 CE

The Mughal Empire would become one of the wealthiest and most culturally productive empires in human history. At its peak, around 1700 CE, the Mughal empire ruled almost all of South Asia and had about 150 million subjects. Its GDP was, by some estimates, about a quarter of the entire world's economy.

The Mughals are traditionally counted as having six great emperors. Let me walk through them.

Babur (1526 to 1530 CE). The founder. He died only four years after his big victory at Panipat. He was a complex man: a brilliant general, an honest memoirist who wrote his autobiography the Baburnama, a poet, and also a drinker who eventually swore off alcohol. He never really felt at home in India and missed Central Asia.

Humayun (1530 to 1556 CE). Babur's son. He was a kind but not very effective ruler. He lost the empire to an Afghan rebel named Sher Shah Suri and spent 15 years in exile in Persia. He eventually returned and reconquered Delhi, only to die a year later by falling down the stairs of his library carrying an armful of books. Sher Shah Suri, by the way, was one of the most efficient administrators in Indian history. He built the Grand Trunk Road which still exists, reformed the tax system, and standardised the rupee, the currency that India still uses today.

Akbar (1556 to 1605 CE). Akbar was Humayun's son and is generally considered the greatest of the Mughals. He came to the throne at age 13 and ruled for 49 years. He expanded the empire to cover most of the subcontinent. But what makes Akbar special is his religious policy. Akbar invited scholars from every religion to his court for debates: Hindus, Muslims, Christians, Zoroastrians, Jains, and Buddhists. He eventually tried to create his own syncretic religion called Din i Ilahi, which mixed elements from many faiths. It never caught on, but the attempt itself shows how seriously he took religious questions.

Akbar abolished the jizya tax on non Muslims in 1564 CE. He married Hindu Rajput princesses and made their relatives major figures in his court. His revenue minister, Raja Todar Mal, was a Hindu. His chief military commander, Raja Man Singh, was a Hindu Rajput. Akbar's son, the next emperor, was half Rajput. By the standards of his time and ours, Akbar was remarkably committed to religious tolerance. The historian Vincent Smith called him the first modern monarch in Indian history.

“Akbar's reign represents one of the great moments of religious tolerance in world history, an attempt to govern a diverse population through inclusion rather than coercion.”

— Audrey Truschke, Culture of Encounters, 2016

Jahangir (1605 to 1627 CE). Akbar's son. He continued most of his father's tolerant policies. He was a great patron of painting and gardens. He was also addicted to opium and alcohol, which weakened his governance late in life. His wife Nur Jahan was the actual power behind the throne for many years and is one of the most fascinating women in Indian history.

Shah Jahan (1628 to 1658 CE). The builder. He is the emperor who built the Taj Mahal in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal, who died giving birth to their fourteenth child. The Taj Mahal took 22 years to build and is still considered one of the most beautiful buildings on Earth. Shah Jahan also built the Red Fort in Delhi and the Jama Masjid (the largest mosque in India). The Mughal empire was at its richest during his reign, though there were also ominous signs that the empire was spending more than it could sustain.

Aurangzeb (1658 to 1707 CE). This is the one we have to talk about carefully, because he is the most controversial Mughal emperor.

Aurangzeb: The Reversal

Aurangzeb was the third son of Shah Jahan. He took the throne in 1658 after a brutal civil war against his brothers, killing two of them and imprisoning his own father in the Agra fort for the last eight years of Shah Jahan's life. Shah Jahan died staring at his wife's tomb, the Taj Mahal, from his prison window.

Aurangzeb ruled for 49 years, the longest reign of any Mughal. He expanded the empire to its greatest territorial extent. But he also reversed many of the tolerant policies of Akbar and his successors. He reimposed the jizya tax on non Muslims in 1679, after over a century of it being abolished. He destroyed several major Hindu temples, including the Vishwanath temple at Varanasi and the Keshavnath temple at Mathura (the birthplace of Krishna). He executed the ninth Sikh Guru, Guru Tegh Bahadur, in 1675 for refusing to convert to Islam. This act galvanised Sikh resistance to Mughal rule. The Sikhs' own Khalsa

identity, formed by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699, was a direct response to Aurangzeb's religious policies.

At the same time, the picture is more complicated than just "Aurangzeb was a bigot." The historian Audrey Truschke, in her 2017 book *Aurangzeb: The Man and the Myth*, points out that:

- Aurangzeb employed more Hindus in his administration than any earlier Mughal, including 31.6 percent of his top nobles, compared to about 22.5 percent under Akbar.
- Most of his wars were fought against other Muslims, especially in the Deccan.
- He gave grants and protection to many Hindu temples even while destroying others. The destruction was often politically motivated against specific Hindu rulers who had rebelled, not a general policy.
- He banned the building of new temples but allowed existing ones to operate.

So which is it? Was Aurangzeb a bigot or was he politically pragmatic? The answer seems to be: both. He was a serious Sunni Muslim who believed his role was to enforce religious law as he understood it. He used religious policies as political tools when convenient. He was a complicated, brutal, effective emperor whose reign had real consequences for India's religious landscape.

What is clear is that under Aurangzeb, the social compact between the Mughal state and its Hindu majority subjects was strained in ways it had not been under Akbar. Rebellions broke out across the empire. The Marathas under Shivaji rose up in the west. The Sikhs militarised under their tenth Guru in the north. The Rajputs grew restless. The Jats rebelled. By the time Aurangzeb died in 1707 CE, the empire was financially exhausted and politically fractured.

The next century would see the slow collapse of Mughal power and the rise of regional Indian powers, leading eventually to the British takeover. But that is the story of the next part.

Important Things About the Mughal Period You Should Know

Before we close this chapter, let me give you some context that often gets lost in arguments about whether the Mughals were good or bad.

The Mughals were Indian. Babur was from Central Asia, but every emperor after him was born in India, raised in India, and died in India. They spoke Persian and Urdu and Hindi. They ate Indian food. Their mothers and grandmothers were often Indian (frequently Rajput Hindus). By Akbar's generation, the Mughals were as Indian as anyone else in the country, even if they were Muslim and culturally connected to Central Asia. To

call them foreigners is to miss something important about Indian identity, which has always been about absorbing different peoples and making them part of the whole.

The Mughal period was when much of what we now think of as Indian culture took its modern form. Indian classical music and miniature painting reached new heights under Mughal patronage. Urdu emerged as a literary language. The Indian cuisine that includes biryani, kebab, paratha, and naan is largely Mughal influenced. The Taj Mahal is now the visual symbol of India to most of the world. Rejecting the Mughal contribution to India would mean rejecting much of what makes Indian culture distinct today.

Conversion to Islam was a slow, multi century process. Most Indian Muslims today are descendants of Indian Hindus and Buddhists who converted over the centuries. Why did they convert? Many reasons. Some were forced. Some converted to escape the caste system, which was extra brutal for the lower castes. Some converted because Sufi Muslim mystics offered a personal religion that competed effectively with Hindu devotional movements. (Sufism is a gentle, mystical, love centred strand of Islam.) Some converted because Muslim rulers offered tax breaks and government jobs to converts. Some converted by marriage.

Indian Hinduism survived because of its decentralised structure. Unlike European paganism, which depended on local priests and rulers, Hinduism had no central authority. There was no Hindu pope to convert. There was no single ritual centre to destroy. Even if a thousand temples were destroyed, ten thousand more existed in villages that the conquerors could not reach. Hinduism lived in the home as much as in the temple. Every Hindu family had a household altar. Every village had its own gods. You could not erase this by killing the priests or burning the libraries. It was too distributed.

India also had vast geography on its side. The Mughal empire ruled north India effectively, but its grip on the south was always weaker. The Marathas, the Vijayanagara empire before them, and the regional Hindu kingdoms of the south maintained their identity and their religion through the centuries of Muslim rule in the north. India is too big and too varied to be conquered totally. There were always regions that stayed Hindu, kept the old temples running, and preserved the texts. This geographical advantage is one of the most underappreciated reasons that Hinduism survived where European paganism did not.

“Hinduism survived because it was not a religion that could be captured at the centre. It lived in the village, the home, the family ritual. You can take a kingdom. You cannot take ten thousand households at once.”

We have now covered roughly 4,500 years of Indian history, from the planned cities of the Indus Valley to the death of Aurangzeb. We have seen India's golden ages and its disasters. We have seen the long, slow, complicated arrival of Islam, with both its violence and its eventual integration into Indian life.

In the next part of this book, we will look at the next great threat to Indian civilisation: the arrival of European powers, especially the British, who would do something the Mughals never quite managed. They would take all of India under one ruler, drain its wealth, restructure its economy, and try to convert it to Christianity. They would mostly fail at the last part, but they would succeed at the first three in ways that India is still recovering from today. We will see how, and why, in Part Three.



End of Section One. Part Three will follow.

Lovepreet Singh

THE FORGOTTEN GODS



The Company That Ate a Country
How Europe Tried to Conquer India's Body and Soul

by

LOVEPREET SINGH

— Part Three —

*The story of how the richest country on Earth became the
poorest, and why missionaries failed where merchants
succeeded.*

A Note Before We Continue

In Part Two of this book, we walked through 4,500 years of Indian history. We saw the planned cities of the Indus Valley, the philosophical depth of the Upanishads, the golden ages of the Mauryas and the Guptas, and the long, complicated arrival of Islam. We ended with the death of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb in 1707 CE, with the Mughal empire financially broken and politically fractured.

Now we turn to the next wave of foreign arrivals. This wave was different in important ways. It did not come from the north overland on horses, the way Muslim invaders had come for 700 years. It came by sea, from the west. It did not arrive with conquering armies first. It arrived with traders carrying spices and silver. And in the end, it was these traders, not any army, who would do something no Muslim emperor had ever managed. They would take all of India under one ruler.

This is also a story about a strange paradox. The Europeans who came to India came from a continent that had become deeply Christian, with centuries of missionary tradition. They were determined to convert India to their faith. They sent priests. They built churches. They funded missions. And yet, after 450 years of effort, only about 2.3 percent of Indians today are Christian. Compare that to Latin America, where the same European powers in the same centuries converted entire civilisations. Why did Christianity succeed in Mexico and Brazil and fail in India? This is one of the most interesting questions in religious history. We will answer it.

I want to warn you. Some of what is in this section is painful. The British rule of India was, in some ways, the worst thing that happened to India in its entire long history. Worse than the Mughal invasions. Worse than Timur. The famines killed more people than any war. The economic destruction broke a civilisation that had been rich for thousands of years. But the story is also one of remarkable survival, of how Indians figured out how to push back, how to use the very tools of their oppressors against them, and how, against the odds, they got their country back.

Two words to remember again. Two short labels appear all through this book — “CE” and “BCE”. The year of Jesus’s birth is used as the zero point. Years **after** it are “CE” (2026 CE = today). Years **before** it are “BCE”, meaning “Before the Common Era”. Almost everything in this part happens in the CE years, moving forward in time from about 1500 CE to 1947 CE.



Lovepreet Singh

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Part Four of this book will close the story by turning to China and Japan, and asking what we can learn from the civilisations that did not bend.

*“The British Empire in India is the rule of the merchant adventurer,
armed with a charter, a fleet, and a Bible, ruling a civilisation older
than his own.”*

— Will Durant, *The Case for India*, 1930



*This is not a religious attack. It is a historical accounting. Read it with an
open mind.*

XVI.

The Sea Route: Portuguese, Dutch, French, and the Race for Spice

To understand why Europeans came to India, you have to understand pepper. Black pepper — the spice you grind on your food — was the most valuable trade commodity in the world for about 2,000 years. (A "commodity" simply means a good that is bought and sold in large amounts.) It grew only in a small region of south India and parts of Southeast Asia. Europe wanted it badly. The wealthy paid huge prices for it. Whole fortunes were made trading in it.

For centuries, this trade was controlled by Arab and Persian merchants who shipped Indian goods to Egypt, where Italian middlemen from Venice and Genoa picked them up and sold them in Europe at enormous markups. Everyone in this chain got rich. The Indians who grew the pepper, the Arabs who shipped it, the Egyptians who handled it, the Italians who sold it in Europe. The only people not getting rich were the buyers at the end of the chain — the rest of Europe.

By the late 1400s, two things changed. First, the Ottoman Turks conquered Constantinople in 1453 and made the overland route to India more expensive. Second, European shipbuilding technology had improved enough that some bold sailors were starting to ask a wild question: what if we just sailed around Africa and went to India directly?

Vasco da Gama Reaches India, 1498

The first European to sail all the way from Europe to India was a Portuguese captain named Vasco da Gama. He left Lisbon in July 1497 with four ships and about 170 men. Most people thought he would die. He sailed south along the coast of Africa, rounded the Cape of Good Hope at the southern tip, then up the east African coast, where he found Arab traders who knew the way to India. He hired one of them as a pilot. On May 20, 1498, he landed at Calicut on the Malabar coast of south India, almost ten months after leaving Portugal.

Vasco da Gama's arrival is sometimes called the beginning of European imperialism in Asia. ("Imperialism" means one country taking control of other lands and peoples for its own gain.) It is one of the most consequential journeys in world history. From that

moment, European ships could reach India directly. The Arabs and Italians who had controlled the spice trade for centuries would lose their monopoly. And much more would change with them.

What is a "monopoly"? A monopoly is when one group controls all the supply of something, so nobody else can sell it and the controller can charge whatever it wants. For 2,000 years, no single power had a monopoly on the spice trade — it was shared. The Europeans now wanted that monopoly for themselves.

Vasco da Gama's reception at Calicut was actually awkward. The local ruler, the Zamorin, was unimpressed by his gifts. By Indian standards, the European goods da Gama brought were cheap. The Zamorin politely asked if he had brought any gold or silver. He had not. Da Gama eventually loaded his ships with spices, paid for partly with gold from the Arab traders he had pushed aside, and sailed home. When he reached Portugal, the value of the spices he carried was around 60 times the cost of the entire expedition. The Portuguese realised they had a financial gold mine.

Portuguese Strategy: Trade Through Violence

The second Portuguese expedition came back in 1500 with thirteen ships. This time they were not just here to trade. They were here to take over. The man who really established Portuguese power in the Indian Ocean was Afonso de Albuquerque, who became the second Portuguese governor of India in 1509.

Albuquerque's plan was simple and brutal. He could not conquer India itself. India was far too big and too powerful for that. But he could control the choke points of the Indian Ocean trade routes. (A "choke point" is a narrow passage that all ships must pass through, so whoever holds it controls the traffic.) He captured Goa on the west coast of India in 1510. He captured Malacca on the Malay peninsula in 1511, which controlled the strait between the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea. He captured Hormuz at the mouth of the Persian Gulf in 1515.

With these three port cities, the Portuguese could tax or sink any ship that wanted to use the major trade routes. They issued a system of passes called cartazes. Indian and Arab merchants who paid for a cartaz could sail safely. Those who did not were sunk and their cargo seized. It was sea piracy with a paper veneer. The Portuguese never controlled much Indian land. They just controlled the seas. And that was enough to make them rich.

The Portuguese were also vicious. In 1502, on his second voyage, Vasco da Gama himself captured an Arab pilgrim ship called the Miri, which was carrying about 400 Muslim pilgrims back from Mecca, including women and children. Da Gama looted the ship. Then he burned it with the passengers still aboard. Almost everyone died. The historian Sanjay

Subrahmanyam, in his 1997 book *The Career and Legend of Vasco da Gama*, documents this incident from multiple sources. It is one of the worst single atrocities of the early colonial period, and it set the tone for Portuguese behaviour in Asia.

The Goa Inquisition, 1560 to 1812

I want to spend some time on something that does not get talked about enough. The Goa Inquisition.

What was an "Inquisition"? An Inquisition was an official Church court that hunted down people suspected of not being properly Christian. It could arrest, torture, imprison, and even execute people for their beliefs or for secretly practising another religion. The most famous one was the Spanish Inquisition in Europe — but the one the Portuguese ran in Goa, in India, was even harsher.

The Portuguese controlled Goa as their main colony in India from 1510 to 1961. For 250 of those years, from 1560 to 1812, they ran a religious court called the Goa Inquisition. It was officially aimed at policing the faith of Catholic converts to make sure they were not secretly practising Hinduism, Judaism, or Islam. In practice, it terrorised the entire region.

The Goa Inquisition was actually more brutal than the more famous Spanish Inquisition. The historian Alfredo de Mello, in his 1995 book *Memoirs of Goa*, documents that during its 252 year run, the Inquisition prosecuted at least 16,202 people. About 57 of them were burned alive, sentenced for crimes like converting to Hinduism, observing Hindu festivals secretly, refusing to eat pork, or keeping Hindu sacred texts at home.

The Inquisition banned the Konkani language, the local language of Goa, because it was associated with Hindu identity. It destroyed Hindu and Muslim books on a massive scale. It banned Hindu rituals, including Hindu weddings and Hindu funerals. It mandated Catholic baptism for many Hindus. Hindu temples in Portuguese Goa were systematically demolished. Most of the temples in Goa today are reconstructions or temples in the surrounding regions where Hindus fled.

Even Catholic priests at the time were horrified. The Italian Jesuit priest Filippo Sassetti, who lived in Goa in the 1580s, wrote letters back to Florence complaining about the cruelty he witnessed. Voltaire later cited the Goa Inquisition as one of the most depraved institutions ever created in the name of religion.

“The Goa Inquisition is the most brutal in the entire history of the Christian Inquisitions. It is a horror that historical memory has largely buried.”

— A. K. Priolkar, *The Goa Inquisition*, 1961

The Inquisition was finally shut down in 1812, partly because of pressure from liberal Portuguese politicians, and partly because Portuguese power in India had collapsed by then. But the damage to Goan culture had been done. Thousands of Hindu families had converted to escape persecution. The unique Indo Portuguese culture of Goa today, with its mix of Catholic churches and Konkani language, is the product of this violence as much as it is of peaceful cultural exchange.

Why I Am Telling You This

I want to be careful here. I am not telling you about the Goa Inquisition to make you hate Christianity or Christians. Most Christians today, including most Catholic Goans, would be horrified by what the Inquisition did. The current Catholic Church has officially apologised for the Inquisition. Pope John Paul II issued a formal apology in 2000 for the Church's historical use of violence to spread its faith.

But I am telling you about it because most people do not know it happened. They know about the Spanish Inquisition in Europe. They have heard of the Crusades. But the Goa Inquisition, which lasted longer than the Spanish Inquisition and was arguably more cruel, is barely mentioned in standard world history. This is because the people who write standard world history mostly come from a Western perspective, and the Goa Inquisition does not fit the story of European civilisation being a moral force in the world.

Real history requires us to remember the parts that make people uncomfortable, including ourselves. The Christian Europeans who came to Asia did so with the same mix of greed and zealotry that Muslim invaders had brought from the northwest. Both were doing the same fundamental thing: trying to extract wealth and convert people to a faith they considered superior. Both failed at conversion much more than they succeeded.

The Dutch, the French, and the British Arrive

The Portuguese monopoly on the Asia trade did not last long. By the late 1500s, other European powers were jealous. The Dutch broke into the trade in the 1590s. Their Dutch East India Company, founded in 1602, was the first large publicly traded company in history and one of the most ruthless. They pushed the Portuguese out of most of their Asian trading posts.

The French followed in the 1660s with their own East India Company. The English chartered their East India Company in 1600. For about 150 years, these European powers competed with each other for trading rights in India. They built fortified trading posts called factories at various points along the Indian coast. The Portuguese had Goa. The Dutch had Pulicat and later Negapatnam. The French had Pondicherry. The English had Surat, Madras, Bombay, and Calcutta.

All of these Europeans were doing roughly the same thing. They were buying Indian goods — mostly cotton textiles, spices, indigo dye, and saltpetre (used to make gunpowder) — and selling them in Europe for huge profits. India was not buying very much from Europe in return, because the Europeans did not make anything that Indians wanted at competitive prices. So the Europeans had to pay in silver bullion. (Bullion just means raw precious metal — bars and coins of silver and gold valued by weight.) The amount of silver flowing into India during this period was enormous. India was where the world's silver went to disappear.

The Wars Between European Companies

In the 1740s and 1750s, the competition between the European companies turned into open war. This was part of the larger global rivalry between Britain and France. In India, the British East India Company and the French East India Company fought a series of wars called the Carnatic Wars, mostly in south India.

These wars are important because they introduced something new to India. Both the British and the French began recruiting Indian soldiers, called sepoys, trained in European military methods and armed with European weapons. (A "sepoy" was an Indian soldier serving in a European-run army — the word comes from the Persian and Urdu word for "soldier".) These sepoy armies were

paid regularly, drilled daily, and used modern tactics. They were more effective than traditional Indian armies, which were larger but less disciplined.

The British, under a brilliant general named Robert Clive, eventually defeated the French. By the late 1750s, the French had been pushed to a few small enclaves. The British were the dominant European power in India.

But the British were not just fighting the French. They were also starting to involve themselves in the politics of Indian rulers. They allied with some, fought others, and slowly built up their own territory. The decisive moment came in 1757, at a place called Plassey in Bengal. That is where the British went from being a trading company to being a government. That is the story of the next chapter.

XVII.

The Company: How a Trading Office Became a Government

The British East India Company is one of the strangest organisations in human history. It was a private joint stock company, owned by shareholders in London. Its purpose was to make money for those shareholders. It had no formal government role. And yet, over a period of about 100 years, this private company conquered an entire subcontinent and ruled it for the benefit of its shareholders. By 1820, the Company governed about 100 million people. By 1857, when the British government finally took over, the Company had ruled India for a century.

What is a "joint stock company"? It is a business owned by many investors who each buy a share of it. The owners ("shareholders") put in money and collect a slice of the profits. The East India Company was exactly this — a profit-making business owned by rich people in London — except it also had its own army and ran a country. Imagine a giant corporation today suddenly being allowed to keep soldiers and govern millions of people.

How did this happen? It is one of the most important questions in modern history. The historian William Dalrymple, in his 2019 book *The Anarchy*, argues that the rise of the Company is essentially the

first great example of corporate power overreaching — of a company becoming as powerful as a state. It is a story worth understanding in detail.

The Battle of Plassey, 1757

The pivotal moment was the Battle of Plassey, fought on June 23, 1757, in a mango grove near the Bhagirathi river in Bengal. On one side was a small British East India Company army of about 3,000 men, mostly Indian sepoys, commanded by Robert Clive. On the other side was the army of Siraj ud Daulah, the young Nawab of Bengal, with about 50,000 men, including French artillery support. (A "Nawab" was the title for a Muslim governor or ruler of a province under the Mughal system.)

On paper, it should have been a slaughter. The British were outnumbered more than fifteen to one. But Clive had done something more important than gathering soldiers. He had bought a traitor.

Before the battle, Clive had secretly negotiated with Mir Jafar, the commander of the largest section of the Nawab's army. He offered Mir Jafar the throne of Bengal if Mir Jafar's troops would simply refuse to fight. Mir Jafar agreed. When the battle began, two thirds of the Nawab's army stood and watched while the rest fought. The Company army won easily. Siraj ud Daulah was captured and executed by Mir Jafar's son. Mir Jafar was put on the throne.

This is important. The British did not win Plassey by being better soldiers. They won by exploiting divisions inside the Indian elite, by buying loyalty, and by being patient. The actual fighting was minor. The casualties were small. But the political consequences were enormous. The British East India Company now had a puppet ruler in the richest province of India.

What Bengal Was Like Before Plassey

Before we talk about what happened after Plassey, let me give you a sense of what Bengal was like. Bengal in 1757 was one of the richest provinces in the world. It produced about 12 percent of all the cloth manufactured globally. It was famous for its muslin, a fine cotton fabric so delicate that an entire sari could be passed through a wedding ring. Bengali weavers had developed this craft over

centuries. Bengal also produced huge quantities of silk, indigo dye, sugar, salt, and grains. Its capital Murshidabad was, according to Robert Clive himself, as rich as London.

Bengal's tax revenue alone was estimated at around 4 million pounds sterling per year in 1757, which was a colossal amount. By comparison, the entire British government's tax revenue at the time was about 8 million pounds. So Bengal's revenue, captured by a single private company, was about half of the entire British government's revenue. This wealth would not stay in Bengal.

The Plunder of Bengal: The First Loot

After Plassey, the Company demanded huge payments from Mir Jafar in exchange for putting him on the throne. The historian P. J. Marshall has calculated that between 1757 and 1765, Mir Jafar and his successors paid out about 5.7 million pounds in personal gifts to Company officials, plus another 2.2 million in compensation for expenses. These were individual bribes paid to Company men, not government revenue. Robert Clive himself took the equivalent of about 30 million pounds in today's money in personal gifts from Mir Jafar.

This was not corruption in the usual sense. Clive saw it as the legitimate spoils of victory. When he was later questioned about it by Parliament, he gave a famous reply.

“Consider the situation in which the victory of Plassey placed me. A great prince was dependent on my pleasure. An opulent city lay at my mercy. Its richest bankers bid against each other for my smiles. Mr Chairman, at this moment I stand astonished at my own moderation.”

— Robert Clive, testimony to House of Commons, 1772

His own moderation. Clive had taken what would today be tens of millions of pounds, and he was astonished at his own restraint, because he could have taken more. This tells you the mentality. The Company men in India saw themselves as conquerors entitled to the wealth they extracted. They were not building a colony for British settlers. They were running an extraction operation.

The Diwani of Bengal, 1765

In 1764, the Company defeated a coalition of Indian forces at the Battle of Buxar. This victory was more important than Plassey because it gave the Company control of all three eastern provinces: Bengal, Bihar, and Odisha. These three provinces together had a population of about 30 million people, larger than Britain at the time.

In August 1765, the Mughal emperor Shah Alam II, who was technically still the overlord of all India even though his actual power was tiny, signed a treaty with the Company. The treaty gave the Company the Diwani of these provinces. The Diwani was the right to collect taxes. From this moment, a private British company had the legal right to tax 30 million Indians.

What does "Diwani" mean? Under the old Mughal system, the "Diwani" was the official right to collect the taxes of a region and manage its finances. Whoever held the Diwani controlled the money. In 1765 this right — over 30 million people — was handed to a foreign trading company. That is the moment a business legally became a tax collector over a nation.

Let me say that again. A private company. The British East India Company. Not the British government. Not even officially the British Crown. A company. Owned by shareholders in London. Had the right to tax 30 million people. Imagine if a giant retail corporation today were given the right to tax all Indians by the Indian government. That is roughly the level of bizarreness we are talking about.

Once the Company had taxation power, it did not need to bring silver from Europe to buy Indian goods anymore. It could simply use Indian tax money to buy Indian goods, and then sell those goods in Europe for huge profits. This is one of the most important innovations in colonial extraction, and it changed the global economy.

The Bengal Famine of 1770

Five years after the Company took over Bengal's tax system, the worst famine in centuries struck the region. The monsoon rains failed in 1769. (The monsoon is the season of heavy rains that Indian farming

depends on completely — no monsoon means no crops.) The crops failed. People started starving.

In normal times, the Mughal and Nawabi governments would have responded to a famine by reducing or suspending taxes, releasing government grain reserves, and organising relief. The Company did the opposite. The Company actually raised taxes during the famine. Company officials hoarded grain to drive up prices. Some Company men made personal fortunes by selling rice at hugely inflated prices to desperate, starving people. Tax collection continued at gunpoint even from villages where most of the population was dying.

Modern estimates suggest that around 10 million people died in the Bengal famine of 1770. That is about one third of the population of Bengal. It was, at the time, the worst famine in recorded human history. And it was caused by drought, but made catastrophic by the Company's economic policies.

The historian William Dalrymple, citing contemporary sources, describes the situation in horrifying detail in *The Anarchy*. Calcutta filled with refugees. Bodies piled up in the streets. People sold their children. Cannibalism was reported. And throughout all this, the Company continued exporting rice from Bengal to other parts of its commercial empire. The Company's profits actually increased during the famine year.

“The Bengal famine of 1770 was a catastrophe partly caused by drought, but turned into a holocaust by the rapacity of a foreign corporation that put profit above all else.”

— William Dalrymple, *The Anarchy*, 2019

The famine briefly shocked the British public. There were debates in Parliament. Some questioning of whether a private company should be running a country. But ultimately the Company survived and even expanded its power. The pattern of using Indian wealth to enrich British shareholders while letting Indians die when crops failed would be repeated many times over the next 180 years.

The Company State, 1765 to 1857

Over the next 90 years, the Company expanded its rule across most of India through a mix of military conquest, treaty making, and the

absorption of bankrupt Indian kingdoms. By 1820, after defeating the Marathas in three wars, the Company controlled almost all of India north of the Krishna river. By 1849, after the conquest of Punjab, the Company controlled almost the entire subcontinent.

The Company became, in effect, the government of India. It collected taxes. It enforced laws. It maintained an army of about 250,000 men, mostly Indian sepoys. It ran its own postal service, its own courts, its own opium trade with China. It built the first Indian railways in the 1850s. It set up English language schools.

All of this was paid for by Indian taxes, but accountable not to Indians but to the Company's shareholders in London. The profits flowed to Britain. The administrative costs were paid by Indians.

This is the system that the economist Utsa Patnaik has spent her career analysing. We will look at her numbers in the next chapter, when we ask exactly how much wealth was extracted from India during this period, and what it meant for both India and Britain.

XVIII.

The Great Drain: How Britain Got Rich by Making India Poor

This chapter is about money. Not abstract money. Real money. Pounds, rupees, and the largest transfer of wealth between two countries in human history.

I am going to give you the actual numbers. I have been careful to use numbers from serious academic economists, not internet sources, because this topic is heavily disputed and people on both sides exaggerate.

The Theory of the Drain

The first person to systematically argue that Britain was draining India's wealth was an Indian named Dadabhai Naoroji. He was a brilliant scholar, businessman, and politician, who lived from 1825 to 1917. He spent decades collecting economic data and presented his findings in a famous book published in 1901, called *Poverty and Un-British Rule in India*.

Naoroji's argument was simple but devastating. He showed that India was sending huge amounts of wealth to Britain every year, in the form of:

- Salaries and pensions paid to British administrators, soldiers, and engineers, sent home to England in pounds, taken out of Indian tax revenue.
- Interest payments on debts the British made India take out to pay for British wars and projects.
- Profits of British companies operating in India, sent back to British shareholders.
- Costs of the "Home Charges", the budget for the India Office in London, which was charged to Indian taxpayers even though

Indians had no say in it.

- The purchase of Indian goods that were paid for not in real money but in Council Bills, which were a kind of currency trick we will discuss in a moment.

Naoroji called this the Drain. He estimated that around 30 to 40 million pounds were drained from India every year by the end of the 1800s. Modern economists, with better data and computers, have refined his estimates and largely confirmed the basic argument.

Utsa Patnaik's Modern Estimates

The leading modern scholar on this is Utsa Patnaik, an economist at Jawaharlal Nehru University in Delhi. She has spent over 40 years studying colonial India's economy. In a 2018 paper published in the Columbia University series *Agrarian and Other Histories*, she made one of the most careful calculations of the total drain ever attempted.

Patnaik calculated that between 1765 (when the Company got the Diwani of Bengal) and 1938 (just before independence), Britain drained from India a total of approximately 45 trillion US dollars in today's money. Yes, trillion. Forty five trillion dollars.

How big is "45 trillion dollars"? A trillion is a million million. To picture it: the entire economic output of the United States — the largest economy on Earth — was about 28 trillion dollars in one whole year (2024). So this estimate of what was taken from India is bigger than a full year's output of the modern United States, drained out slowly over 173 years.

To put that in perspective, the entire GDP of the United States in 2024 was about 28 trillion dollars. (GDP means the total value of everything a country produces in a year.) So Patnaik's estimate of the drain is roughly equivalent to the entire annual economic output of the modern United States, transferred from India to Britain over a 173 year period.

Patnaik's number is on the higher end of estimates. Other economists give lower figures. The historian Tirthankar Roy, for example, in his 2019 book *How British Rule Changed India's Economy*, argues that Patnaik overstates the drain by including some items he thinks should not count. He gives a smaller but still large estimate. The

exact number is debated. But the basic fact, that vast amounts of wealth moved from India to Britain, is not disputed by any serious economist.

“The fact that the Drain happened is settled. The argument is only about the size. And by any serious accounting, it was the largest sustained wealth transfer between two countries in modern history.”

— Shashi Tharoor, *Inglorious Empire*, 2017

The Council Bills Mechanism

Let me explain one specific mechanism, because it is so clever and so cruel that it deserves its own section. The Council Bills system.

Here is how British exports of Indian goods worked after about 1870. A British buyer in London wanted to buy Indian cotton or jute or tea. They would go to the British government office in London called the India Office. The India Office would sell them a Council Bill, which was essentially a paper note saying "give the bearer this much in Indian rupees, payable in India." The British buyer paid for this Bill in pounds.

The British buyer then sent the Council Bill to India. There, the buyer's agents would exchange the Bill at any government office for rupees from the Indian government's treasury. They would use those rupees to buy Indian goods from Indian producers.

Notice what happened. The Indian producer was paid in rupees. The British buyer paid in pounds. Where did the pounds go? They stayed in London. They never came to India. The Indian government simply paid out rupees from its own treasury to settle the transaction. So Indian taxpayers were effectively paying Indian producers for goods that the British were taking. The British paid Britain. India paid India. Britain got the goods.

This is not a metaphor. This is exactly how the system worked. The pounds the British buyers paid became part of the British government's reserves. The Indian rupees the producers were paid came out of taxes Indians had already paid. It was a brilliant accounting trick that turned Indian export earnings into a tax on

Indians, while making it look on paper as if Britain was paying for what it bought.

Deindustrialisation

Beyond the financial drain, there was also industrial destruction. In 1700, India was probably the largest exporter of manufactured goods in the world, especially textiles. Indian cotton cloth was sold across Africa, the Middle East, and Europe. Bengali muslin was a luxury product. Indian craftsmen had skills that had been developed over centuries.

British policy systematically destroyed all of this. There were two main mechanisms.

First, tariffs. (A tariff is a tax a government puts on goods coming in from another country, to make them more expensive than home-made goods.) Indian textiles imported into Britain faced tariffs of 70 to 80 percent, sometimes higher, making them too expensive to sell in Britain. British textiles imported into India faced tariffs of 2 to 4 percent, making them cheap to sell in India. This was the opposite of what Adam Smith and free trade economists would have predicted. The British government did not believe in free trade when it came to India. They believed in rigged trade.

Second, the deliberate destruction of Indian production capacity. There are reports of British officials cutting off the thumbs of Indian weavers to stop them from working. These reports are debated by historians today, with some arguing they may be exaggerated. What is not debated is that British rules forced Indian weavers to sell their cloth exclusively to the East India Company at fixed low prices, and prohibited them from selling to other buyers. Weavers who tried to flee were captured and brought back. Their working conditions amounted to forced labour.

The result was that Indian textile production collapsed. By 1850, Britain was exporting more cotton goods to India than the other way around. India became a market for British manufactured goods, not a producer. The Indian share of world manufacturing went from about 25 percent in 1750 to about 2 percent in 1900. The British share went

from about 2 percent to about 23 percent in the same period. India did not just lose its industry. Britain effectively stole it.

How Britain Used Indian Money

What did Britain do with all this wealth? The economic historian Sven Beckert, in his 2014 book *Empire of Cotton*, has shown that Indian wealth played a major role in financing the British Industrial Revolution. The famous early British industrialists, the textile mill owners of Manchester and Lancashire, depended on Indian raw cotton bought cheaply, on Indian markets to absorb their finished goods, and on capital that originally came from Indian colonial profits.

The British also used Indian money to finance their wars. Indian taxes paid for British troops fighting against the French in Europe, against the Russians in the Crimea, and against the Germans in two world wars. India contributed about 1.3 million soldiers to fight in the First World War, far more than any other British colony. About 74,000 of them died. India was forced to pay for the cost of its own soldiers' deployment, even though most Indians had no say in whether to enter the war.

In the Second World War, India was again the largest single contributor to the British war effort outside of Britain itself. Over 2.5 million Indians served in the British Indian Army, all volunteers, all paid for out of Indian taxes. Britain ended the war owing India about 1.3 billion pounds, which would be about 60 billion pounds in today's money. Britain never paid this back. It was written off as part of the negotiations for Indian independence.

The Cost in Lives

But money is not the worst part. The worst part is the lives. The drain of wealth from India had a direct, brutal consequence. It made famines worse and more frequent. When taxes were too high, when grain was being exported even during droughts, when colonial economic policies broke local food systems, the result was mass starvation. We will dedicate the next chapter to the famines, because they deserve their own treatment. But for now, just understand that

the wealth that built parts of Victorian London came at a price measured in tens of millions of Indian lives.

The Indian economist Amartya Sen, who won the Nobel Prize in Economics in 1998, has spent much of his career studying famines. His core insight is that famines are almost never caused purely by food shortage. They are caused by people losing the ability to buy food, even when food is available. And the loss of that ability is almost always a political and economic choice made by the people in power. Colonial India suffered many such choices.

By 1947, when the British finally left, India had gone from being the richest country in the world in 1700 to one of the poorest. Its share of world GDP had collapsed from 24 percent to about 4 percent. Its life expectancy was 32 years. Its literacy rate was 12 percent. These are not normal numbers for a country with India's history. They are the numbers of a country that has been systematically looted for two centuries.

I am giving you all of this because most people, including most Indians, do not really know the scale of what happened. The British like to remember that they built railways and gave India a parliamentary system. These things are real. But they are like saying that a thief who robs your house and burns it down at least sold you some matches afterwards. The benefits, such as they were, were tiny compared to the cost.

XIX.

The Famines: Forty Million Dead

I want to dedicate a chapter to the famines that happened in British India because this is the part of colonial history that most people refuse to look at directly. It is too painful. The numbers are too big. The cruelty is too cold. But you cannot understand the real cost of British rule without understanding what happened when food got short.

What is a "famine"? A famine is a period when so many people cannot get enough food that they die in large numbers. Importantly, a famine is not always caused by there being no food. As you will see, in British India there was often food — it was just being taken away, exported, or priced beyond what starving people could pay.

How Many Died?

The historian Mike Davis, in his 2001 book *Late Victorian Holocausts*, did probably the most careful analysis of mortality in colonial famines. He focused mostly on the late 1800s. He counted only the famines that are well documented and used the most cautious estimates from each source. His total for excess deaths from famines under British rule was about 30 to 35 million people.

Other historians, including the Indian economist Amartya Sen and the American historian Madhusree Mukerjee, have given estimates ranging from 25 million to 60 million depending on how you count. What is not disputed is that the number is in the tens of millions. Pick whatever conservative number you want. The scale is staggering. By comparison, the Holocaust killed about 6 million Jews. The famines of British India killed five to ten times that many people.

Let me go through the major famines one by one, so you understand what we are actually talking about.

The Bengal Famine of 1770: 10 Million Dead

I already mentioned this in chapter seventeen. The first great famine under Company rule. About 10 million people died, roughly one third of the population of Bengal. The famine was caused by drought, but turned into a holocaust by Company policy. Taxes were raised during the famine. Grain was hoarded. Tax collection continued at gunpoint from dying villages. Company officials made personal fortunes selling rice to desperate buyers. The Company's annual profit actually increased during the famine.

The Reverend John Shore, a senior Company official who later became Governor General, wrote a poem about the famine that included the lines: "Still the gaunt wretch implored, still death denied. Loud groaned the dying with the dead beside." Even Company men were sometimes horrified by what they saw. But the system continued.

The Madras Famine of 1876 to 1878: 5.5 Million Dead

Almost exactly 100 years later, a famine struck the Madras Presidency in south India. The monsoon failed in 1876 and 1877. About 5.5 million people died, in a region with a population of about 38 million.

By this time, India had a famine code that supposedly governed how the British government should respond. The response was minimal. Lord Lytton was the Viceroy of India at the time, the highest British official in India. (A "Viceroy" was the man who ruled India in the name of the British monarch — effectively the king's stand-in.) Lord Lytton's response to the famine has become infamous.

First, Lytton continued the export of grain from India during the famine. In 1877 and 1878, even as millions of Indians were starving, India exported a record 6.4 million tons of wheat. Read that again. India exported wheat in record amounts during a famine in which millions of Indians starved to death. The grain was sent to Britain, where it kept bread prices low for British workers. Some of it was burnt in port warehouses when prices fell.

Second, Lytton set up famine relief camps where starving people could get food. But the food rations in these camps were brutally

small — set at about 450 grams of rice per day for adults doing hard labour, which works out to roughly 1,200 calories. To give you a sense of how cruel that was: it was close to, and in some cases below, the rations later given to inmates at Nazi concentration camps. Many people in the camps died of starvation while officially receiving relief.

Third, Lytton organised a massive party in Delhi in January 1877 to declare Queen Victoria the Empress of India. The party reportedly cost millions of pounds and went on for a week. While 100,000 people were dying of starvation per week in Madras, Lytton spent on champagne and fireworks in Delhi.

“There has never been an instance in history of so prodigious a destruction of human life from causes that could be controlled by human agency. The British rulers of India have allowed millions to die.”

— William Digby, British social reformer, writing in 1901

The Indian Famine Codes of 1880

After the public scandal of the Madras famine, the British government introduced the Indian Famine Codes in 1880. These codes were supposed to lay out clear procedures for famine relief. They were partial reforms. They did help reduce mortality in some later famines compared to what it might have been. But they did not stop famines. They did not stop the export of grain during famines. They did not change the basic economic policies that created the conditions for famines in the first place.

Famines continued to kill millions of Indians for the next 70 years.

The Bengal Famine of 1943: 3 Million Dead

I want to spend more time on this one because it happened in living memory, and because Winston Churchill, who is celebrated in Britain as the hero of World War Two, was directly responsible for the worst aspects of it.

In 1942 and 1943, a series of disasters hit Bengal. A cyclone destroyed crops in October 1942. A rice fungus killed much of the remaining harvest. The Japanese had conquered Burma, which had previously supplied rice to Bengal. Refugees were flooding into Bengal from East

Asia. Food was tight, but there should not have been a famine. There was enough food in India to feed everyone, if the food had been distributed correctly.

The economist Amartya Sen, who lived through the Bengal famine as a child, won the Nobel Prize partly for his work showing that the 1943 famine was not actually caused by a food shortage. Food production in Bengal in 1943 was higher than in 1941, when there had been no famine. The famine was caused by inflation, by hoarding, by the war economy pushing prices beyond what poor people could afford, and by deliberate British policies. Let me explain those policies.

The Denial Policy. The British government, fearing a Japanese invasion of Bengal from Burma, decided to remove boats and food stocks from the coastal areas of Bengal so the Japanese could not use them. About 66,500 boats were destroyed or seized. These were the boats that fishermen used to fish and that farmers used to transport their crops. Their destruction crippled the local food economy in coastal Bengal. Hundreds of thousands of rural Bengali families lost their ability to make a living. Many of them then starved.

The diversion of grain to British troops and to Britain itself. India was exporting grain throughout 1943. Wheat was being shipped to Britain, to British troops in the Middle East, and to other British colonies. Even as Bengalis died, ships full of rice and wheat left Indian ports. When the Bengal government asked for emergency grain imports, London repeatedly refused. Australia offered to send a million tons of grain to Bengal. Britain blocked it.

Churchill's personal role. Multiple primary sources, including the official War Cabinet minutes, show that Winston Churchill personally blocked or delayed food aid to Bengal throughout 1943. When his own officials begged him to authorise emergency shipments, he refused. According to Leopold Amery, his own Secretary of State for India, Churchill said that the famine was the Indians' own fault for "breeding like rabbits." Amery, who was no friend of Indian independence, wrote in his diary that on Indian matters, he could not see much difference between Churchill's attitude and Hitler's.

The historian Madhusree Mukerjee, in her 2010 book *Churchill's Secret War*, documents all of this in painful detail using the British government's own records.

“In the summer of 1943, the Cabinet was repeatedly informed of the famine and the deaths. Churchill repeatedly refused to send aid. He preferred to use the wheat for stockpiling in Europe for after the war.”

— Madhusree Mukerjee, *Churchill's Secret War*, 2010

About 3 million people died in the Bengal famine of 1943. Almost all of them died in 1943 and early 1944. Most of them died not from absolute starvation but from disease and exhaustion as they collapsed in their villages or wandered to Calcutta hoping for food. Photographs from the time, taken by journalists who were eventually allowed into Bengal, show people who look like Holocaust survivors. Indeed, many Holocaust historians have noted that the photographs are nearly identical.

Why I Am Telling You All This

I am telling you this for a few reasons.

First, because most people simply do not know it. If you grow up in the West, you learn about the Holocaust. You should. It was a monstrous crime. But you probably do not learn that the British, who were on the supposed good side of World War Two, were simultaneously causing a famine in India that killed three million people through their own deliberate policies. This is not equivalent to the Nazi murder of Jews. The intention was different. But the result, in terms of human lives lost through state policy, was massive. And it is mostly absent from world history textbooks outside India.

Second, because understanding this changes how you should think about the British empire. The empire was not, on balance, a force for civilisation. It was a system of resource extraction that killed tens of millions of people. Some good things were built in the process. Railways. Universities. Legal codes. But these were tools of administration, not gifts. And they came at a price that no civilised accounting could justify.

Third, because this is one of the main reasons that Christian missionary work failed in India. This is the link to the next chapter. It is hard to convince people that your religion is the religion of love and mercy when, in their living memory, your government has killed their grandparents through deliberate starvation. The British rulers and the British missionaries were not the same people. The missionaries were genuine in many cases, idealistic, hard working. But they came from the same country that was running the famine system. Indians knew this. They drew their own conclusions about how seriously to take Christian claims of moral superiority.

We will get to all of this in the next chapter.

XX.

Why Christianity Mostly Failed in India

Now we come to one of the most important questions in this whole book. Why did Christianity, which had conquered all of Europe and all of Latin America, fail to conquer India? After 450 years of European presence, hundreds of millions of pounds spent on missionary work, and direct colonial rule for 200 years of that period, only about 2.3 percent of Indians today are Christian. Why?

This is not just a question for India. It applies to most of South Asia, East Asia, and the Muslim world. These were the regions Christianity tried hardest to convert. These are the regions where it failed most completely. Understanding why tells you a lot about how religions actually spread and fail to spread.

The Numbers

Let me start with the actual numbers. According to the 2011 census of India, the religious breakdown was: (A "census" is the official count a government takes of its whole population.)

- Hindus: 79.8 percent
- Muslims: 14.2 percent
- Christians: 2.3 percent
- Sikhs: 1.7 percent
- Buddhists: 0.7 percent
- Jains: 0.4 percent
- Others and unspecified: 0.9 percent

Christians in India number about 28 million people, which sounds like a lot, but in a country of 1.4 billion, it is a small minority. Compare this to the Philippines, where Spanish and American

missionaries achieved over 90 percent Christian conversion. Or Latin America, where Spanish and Portuguese missionaries converted entire empires. Or sub Saharan Africa, where European missionaries converted hundreds of millions of people in the past 150 years.

Why is India different? There are several reasons, and they work together.

Reason One: India Had a Mature Religious Civilisation Already

When Spanish missionaries arrived in Mexico in the 1520s, the Aztec religious system was already in chaos. The Spanish had militarily defeated the Aztecs. Their temples had been destroyed. Their priests had been killed. The Aztec gods had failed to protect their people. In this context, Christianity offered a coherent new system. Aztecs could see the Spanish as more powerful and assume their God was therefore more powerful too. Mass conversions followed.

India was different. India was not a single civilisation that could be conquered and demoralised. It was a network of religious traditions thousands of years old, with deep philosophical foundations, with written texts, with debating traditions, with sophisticated theologies. When Christian missionaries arrived and started preaching, they were not talking to people with no theological framework. They were talking to people who had been arguing about the nature of God, the soul, salvation, and suffering for over 2,000 years.

Indian Hindus and Buddhists asked the missionaries hard questions. If your God is all powerful and all good, why does evil exist? If salvation requires accepting Jesus, what happens to all the billions of people who lived before Jesus was born? Why does your Bible contradict itself in many places? How do you know your scripture is true and the Quran is false, when they make competing claims and the Muslims claim certainty too? Why should I give up the religion that has worked for my ancestors for fifty generations?

Most missionaries had no good answers to these questions. They had been trained to convert poor pagans who had never thought about theology. They were not prepared to argue with people who had spent their lives studying philosophy.

The British Indologist Max Mueller, who translated many of the Vedas and Upanishads into English in the 1800s, was struck by this. He wrote that the missionaries were intellectually outgunned by the Hindu and Buddhist scholars they met. He himself, after a lifetime of studying Hindu texts, came to believe that there were deep truths in them that Christianity could not simply overwrite.

Reason Two: Hindu Religious Pluralism

Remember what I said in chapter thirteen about the Indian idea of religious pluralism. (Pluralism means accepting that many different beliefs can each be valid at the same time.) The basic Hindu teaching is that truth is one but the wise speak of it in many ways. Different religions are different paths up the same mountain.

This was a problem for Christian missionaries. Their entire pitch was that Christianity was the one true religion and all others were false. They were demanding that Hindus reject everything they had ever believed and accept exclusive truth.

Hindus often responded by saying something like: that is fine. Jesus is a great teacher. We accept him as one of many divine figures. We will add a picture of Jesus to our household shrine alongside our other gods. Now we have everyone.

This was not what the missionaries wanted. They were not trying to add Jesus to the Hindu pantheon. They wanted Hindus to throw out the Hindu pantheon entirely and accept only Jesus. But the Hindu mind found this strange and unnecessary. Why would you reject other divine figures? If God is infinite, surely God can appear in many forms. The exclusive monotheism of Christianity, which sees other religions as false, simply did not make sense in the Indian framework.

This is one of the deepest reasons Christianity struggled in India. The two religions disagreed not just about specific beliefs but about the basic structure of how religious truth works. Until you fix that disagreement, you cannot really convert someone. You can only build a parallel community.

Reason Three: The Caste Problem

Christianity in theory teaches that all souls are equal before God. In practice in India, missionaries often had to compromise with the caste system because their converts came from many different castes and would not eat together or marry each other. (The caste system was the old, rigid social ladder that fixed a person's rank and job by birth — see Part Two.) There were separate communion services for different castes in many Indian churches well into the 1900s. Lower caste converts were sometimes seated separately or given lower status.

This made Christianity look like an upper caste club for upper caste converts and a lower caste shelter for lower caste converts, rather than a single community. It also made the Christian claim of universal brotherhood ring hollow for any Indian observer who paid attention.

Most Indian converts to Christianity historically came from two groups: the Dalits (formerly called untouchables), who converted to escape the worst of the Hindu caste system, and certain tribal groups in northeast India who were not really Hindu to begin with. These were the people for whom Christianity offered a real status improvement. Upper caste Hindus had little to gain from conversion and a lot to lose, since converting would mean being cut off from their families and social networks. So they mostly did not convert.

This is why the geography of Indian Christianity is strange. The states with the highest Christian populations today are Nagaland (88 percent Christian), Mizoram (87 percent), and Meghalaya (75 percent), all of which are tribal majority states in the northeast that were never deeply Hindu. Kerala has a significant Christian minority (18 percent) because of the ancient Saint Thomas Christian community that we mentioned in chapter thirteen, which predates European missions. Goa is Catholic because of Portuguese conquest and the Inquisition.

Almost everywhere else in India, Christianity made minimal inroads. The Hindi belt, with its hundreds of millions of people, has Christian populations below one percent. Bengal has Christian populations below one percent. Tamil Nadu, despite centuries of missionary work, has only about six percent. The Christian project in India simply did not reach most Indians.

Reason Four: The Association with Colonial Violence

This is the link to the previous chapters. Christianity in India was associated with British rule. The missionaries were British. The colonial officials were British. The Christian schools, churches, and hospitals were funded partly by colonial money. When Indians thought of Christianity, they often thought of the same system that was taxing them, suppressing their economy, and causing their grandparents to starve.

The Bengal famine of 1943, in particular, did enormous damage to the credibility of Christianity in India. Bengal had been a major focus of missionary effort for over a century. There were Christian colleges, Christian hospitals, Christian schools. Then a Christian government allowed three million Bengalis to starve while wheat was shipped to England. After that, the Christian moral pitch sounded hollow to many Indians.

This is unfair to many missionaries personally. Many of them were sincere people who did real good. They ran hospitals where the poor were treated free. They opened schools that gave the first English education to children who would later become Indian leaders. Some of them publicly criticised colonial policy. But they were associated with the larger British project, and it was hard for Indians to separate them from it.

Reason Five: The Hindu Renaissance

Around the same time that Christian missions were trying hardest to convert Indians, in the late 1800s and early 1900s, Hinduism itself was going through a renaissance. (A "renaissance" means a rebirth or revival — here, a wave of fresh confidence and new thinking.) Indian intellectuals were rediscovering and re presenting Hindu thought in modern terms.

Swami Vivekananda, born in 1863, was one of the most important figures in this renaissance. He travelled to America in 1893 and addressed the Parliament of Religions in Chicago. His speech was a sensation. He presented Hinduism not as primitive superstition but as a sophisticated philosophical tradition. He argued that Hinduism's

pluralism was actually morally superior to Christian exclusivism. He won over American intellectuals and even some Christians.

Vivekananda's American visit was the beginning of yoga and Vedanta becoming popular in the West, a process that has accelerated over the past century. Today, millions of people in the West practice yoga, meditate using Hindu and Buddhist techniques, and read translations of the Bhagavad Gita and the Upanishads. The civilisation that Christian missionaries had treated as a target for conversion was now sending its own missionaries to Christian lands.

Other figures in the Hindu renaissance included Raja Ram Mohan Roy, who reformed many problematic Hindu practices like sati (widow burning) while defending the core of Hindu philosophy. Dayananda Saraswati, who founded the Arya Samaj, a Hindu reform movement that argued Hinduism could and should compete intellectually with Christianity and Islam. Aurobindo Ghose, who combined Hindu philosophy with modern European thought to create a new synthesis. Rabindranath Tagore, who won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913 and made Indian thought respectable globally.

Together, these figures gave educated Indians a way to be modern and Hindu at the same time. They did not need to become Christian to engage with modern science or modern philosophy. They could be both Indian and modern. This drained much of the appeal of Christian conversion among the elites.

“The greatest reform in Hinduism is that it is again becoming aware of its own depth, after centuries of being told by foreigners that it was shallow.”

— Swami Vivekananda, Chicago Address, September 11, 1893

Reason Six: Decentralisation, Again

I will end with the reason I mentioned at the end of Part Two, because it bears repeating. Hinduism survived because it had no central authority to capture.

When the Romans converted to Christianity, they could enforce it from the top down because the empire had a single hierarchy. When kings of Europe converted, they could decree the religion of their

subjects. The Pope sat in Rome and gave orders to bishops across the continent. Religion had a chain of command.

Hinduism had no chain of command. There was no Hindu pope. There was no single sacred text that all Hindus had to accept. There were no central rituals that all Hindus had to perform. There were thousands of temples, all locally run. There were millions of household altars. There were a hundred different schools of Hindu philosophy. There were sects that worshipped Shiva, sects that worshipped Vishnu, sects that worshipped the Goddess, sects that believed in no personal God at all. The diversity was the point.

You cannot conquer a religion like that. You can convert individuals. You can destroy specific temples. You can convince a particular king. But the religion will continue in the village next door, in the home altar across town, in the school of philosophy in another city. There is no centre to attack. This is why neither Islam in 700 years nor Christianity in 450 years could break Hinduism. They could weaken it. They could shrink it. They could not destroy it.

Diana Eck, the Harvard scholar of Hindu studies, made this point well in her 2012 book *India: A Sacred Geography*. The decentralisation that had been a political weakness for India in chapters fourteen and fifteen turned out to be a spiritual strength. India could not be defended from invading armies because it had no central army. India could not be converted by missionaries because it had no central religion to convert. The same feature meant different things in different contexts.

Christianity in India Today

Indian Christians today are a small but important community of about 28 million people. They have made enormous contributions to Indian education, healthcare, and social services. Many of India's best schools, colleges, and hospitals were founded by Christian missionaries and continue to operate today. Indian Christianity has produced major writers, social reformers, and politicians. Mother Teresa of Calcutta, born in Albania but who lived most of her life in India, won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1979 for her work with the poorest of the poor.

Indian Christianity is also distinct in its own ways. The Saint Thomas Christians of Kerala, who claim descent from the apostle Thomas, are one of the oldest Christian communities in the world, older than most European churches. They have their own liturgy, their own traditions, their own indigenous Indian flavour. Other Indian Christian communities have developed their own theology of inculturation, which means using Indian forms (music, dance, architecture) for Christian worship. There are Indian churches that look more like Hindu temples on the outside. There is Indian Christian classical music that draws on ragas. There is even a school of Indian Christian theology that takes Hindu concepts seriously as ways of thinking about God.

Christianity in India is alive, and it is doing its own thing. It is just not, and probably will never be, the religion of most Indians.

The same is even more true of China, which we will look at in Part Four. And of Japan. And to a different degree of Korea, which actually did become significantly Christian (about 30 percent today) for reasons specific to Korean history. These East Asian cases will tell us even more about why Christianity did not conquer the East. But before we get to that, we need to finish the Indian story. In the next chapter, we look at the great uprising of 1857, when Indians first tried to throw the British out. They failed. But they learned, and the lessons would matter ninety years later.

XXI.

1857 and the Long Awakening

On May 10, 1857, a regiment of Indian sepoy's stationed at the Meerut military cantonment, about 65 kilometres northeast of Delhi, mutinied against their British officers. (A "mutiny" is when soldiers refuse to obey, and turn against, their own commanders.) By the next day, the rebellion had spread to Delhi. By the end of the year, much of north and central India was in open revolt. Before it was over, the British would have killed tens of thousands of Indians, including civilians, in some of the worst violence of the colonial era. The events of 1857 are called by different names. The British called it the Sepoy Mutiny. Indians call it the First War of Independence. Whatever you call it, it was the moment when the British realised that their grip on India was not as secure as they had thought. And it was the moment when Indians began to believe that they could fight back.

The Causes: Why the Sepoys Rebelled

The immediate trigger of the 1857 uprising was a small thing that became a big thing. The British army had just introduced new Enfield rifles to its Indian sepoy's. To load these rifles, soldiers had to bite open paper cartridges greased with animal fat. A rumour spread that the grease was made from cow fat and pig fat. Cow fat would offend Hindu sepoy's because cows are sacred in Hinduism. Pig fat would offend Muslim sepoy's because pigs are forbidden in Islam.

The rumour was actually substantially correct. British records confirm that some of the early cartridges did use beef tallow and pig lard. The British tried to recall them when they realised, but the damage was done. The sepoy's believed the British were trying to make them lose their religious purity. This was the spark. But the powder had been laid down by years of accumulating grievances.

Economic grievances. By 1857, the Company had spent ninety years systematically extracting wealth from India. Indian artisans

had been ruined. Indian farmers were taxed at rates that often pushed them into starvation. Indian nobles had been displaced by Company expansion. The Doctrine of Lapse, introduced by Governor General Lord Dalhousie in 1848, allowed the Company to annex any Indian kingdom whose ruler died without a male heir, refusing to recognise adopted heirs. (To "annex" means to take over another land and absorb it into your own.) This had been used to annex Satara, Jhansi, Nagpur, and several other states. The displaced royals were furious.

Religious grievances. The British had banned the Hindu practice of sati (widow burning) in 1829. This was probably a good ban from a humanitarian standpoint, but it was seen by some Indians as interference with their religion. The British had also passed laws allowing Hindu widows to remarry (the Widow Remarriage Act of 1856), again interfering with traditional practice. Christian missionaries were active across India and were aggressive in their efforts. There was a real fear among both Hindus and Muslims that the British government was secretly working to convert them.

Recent annexations. In 1856, the year before the uprising, the British had annexed the kingdom of Awadh, also called Oudh, which was one of the largest and richest of the remaining independent Indian states. The annexation was widely seen as a betrayal because Awadh had been a British ally. The Nawab of Awadh was deposed and pensioned off. Many sepoys came from Awadhi families, and they were furious about what the British had done to their homeland.

Specific military grievances. The Company had been using more and more Indian sepoys for foreign wars, including in Afghanistan and Burma. These deployments were technically illegal under the sepoys' enlistment contracts, which restricted them to service within India. Pay was being reduced. Brutal officers were being protected when they abused sepoys. Promotion above the rank of subadar was impossible for Indians, even for the most talented soldiers.

All of these grievances had been building for years. The cartridge issue was just the final straw.

The Uprising Spreads, May to July 1857

The rebellion that began at Meerut on May 10 quickly spread. Within 24 hours, the rebel sepoys had reached Delhi. They proclaimed the 82 year old Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar as their leader and the symbolic head of the new movement. Bahadur Shah was reluctant. He was old, sick, and a poet by inclination, not a warrior. But he became the symbol of the resistance.

Other parts of north India erupted within weeks. Lucknow, the capital of Awadh, became a major centre of rebellion. Kanpur saw a major siege and massacre. Jhansi rose up under the leadership of its young Rani, Lakshmi Bai, who became one of the most famous women in Indian history. ("Rani" means queen.) Gwalior fell. Smaller centres across what is now Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Madhya Pradesh joined in.

What is sometimes missed is how broad the rebellion was. It was not just a sepoy mutiny. Civilians joined. Peasants joined. Aristocrats joined. Hindus and Muslims fought together, often coordinated by local religious figures who told them they were defending both faiths against the foreign Christian rulers. The historian Eric Stokes called it the Peasants Revolt that Britain forgot, because the deeper rural anger that fuelled it has been understated in the standard British accounts.

The Famous Rebels

Many famous Indian figures emerged in 1857. Let me name some of the most important.

Rani Lakshmi Bai of Jhansi. She was the queen of a small kingdom that the British had just annexed under the Doctrine of Lapse. Her adopted son's rights to the throne had been refused by the British. When the rebellion came, she joined it. She led troops personally in battle. She fought in armour. She was killed in battle near Gwalior on June 18, 1858, at the age of 29 or 30. The British general Hugh Rose said she was the bravest and best military leader of the rebel side.

Tatya Tope. A brilliant Marathi general who never had a formal command but became one of the most effective rebel leaders. He led campaigns across central India, raiding British supply lines, leading

thousands of guerrilla fighters. He was finally captured by betrayal in April 1859 and hanged.

Nana Sahib. The adopted son of the last Maratha Peshwa, denied his inheritance by the British. He led the rebellion at Kanpur. After his forces overran the British garrison there, his men massacred about 200 British women and children, an event that became the focus of British outrage. Nana Sahib disappeared after the rebellion was crushed. He may have escaped to Nepal. His fate is unknown.

Bahadur Shah Zafar. The last Mughal emperor, who became the figurehead of the rebellion. After Delhi fell to the British in September 1857, he was captured. His sons were murdered in front of him. He was exiled to Rangoon, Burma, where he died in 1862 and was buried in an unmarked grave. The British did not want his tomb to become a place of pilgrimage. He wrote poetry in his last years that is still loved in Urdu literature today.

“How unlucky is Zafar that for his burial, even two yards of land could not be obtained in the land of the beloved.”

— Bahadur Shah Zafar, written in exile in Rangoon, around 1860

The British Response: Reconquest and Atrocity

The British response was massive and brutal. They brought in regiments from across the empire, including from Britain itself, from Ceylon, and from China. By the end of 1857, they had a force of about 60,000 European troops in India, the largest European army ever assembled on the subcontinent.

Delhi was retaken by the British in September 1857 after a long siege. When the British troops entered the city, they engaged in what most historians now agree was a deliberate campaign of revenge. Tens of thousands of Indians were killed, including many who had nothing to do with the rebellion. The British soldier and writer Frederick Roberts, who was there, described the aftermath.

Across the rest of north India, the pattern was repeated. Cities were reconquered. Then they were punished. Entire villages were burned. Suspected rebels were hanged from trees along major roads, sometimes hundreds in a single day. A particularly notorious method of execution was tying captured rebels to the mouths of cannons and

firing them. This caused complete destruction of the body, which had religious significance for both Hindus and Muslims, who believed in the importance of a complete body for proper funeral rites.

Estimates of how many Indians died in the suppression of 1857 range from about 800,000 (the historian Amaresh Misra, in a 2007 controversial estimate) to about 100,000 (more conservative figures). The truth is probably somewhere in the middle. The Indian historian S. M. M. Jafri argues that the more conservative figures understate the rural killings, while Misra's higher figures may be exaggerated. What is clear is that the British killed many more Indians than the Indians had killed of them.

There is also a less famous fact. After 1857, the British engaged in mass executions in places where they suspected sympathy, even where no actual rebellion had occurred. The historian Mike Davis documents these killings in detail. The vengeance went on for years.

The End of the Company and the Beginning of the Raj

The British government in London was shocked by 1857. The whole idea of running India through a private company suddenly looked absurd. In 1858, Parliament passed the Government of India Act, which abolished Company rule and transferred direct control of India to the British Crown. The British East India Company was dissolved in 1874 after centuries of existence.

What was the "British Raj"? "Raj" is the Hindi word for "rule" or "reign". From 1858 onward, India was no longer run by a company but governed directly by the British government, in the name of the British monarch. This period — about 1858 to 1947 — is called the British Raj.

From 1858, India was officially the British Raj, ruled directly by Britain through a Viceroy appointed by the British government. Queen Victoria was eventually declared Empress of India in 1876. The Indian Civil Service was created, staffed mostly by British men selected through competitive exams in London.

In some ways, things got a bit better under direct British rule. The Famine Codes of 1880 reduced (though did not eliminate) famine mortality in some regions. Modern universities were founded. The

railway network expanded. Some Indian elites were given a partial education that opened doors to careers in the colonial system.

But the basic system remained extractive. India was still being drained. Most Indians remained desperately poor. Famines still killed millions. The British still ruled and Indians still served. The only major thing 1857 changed was that the British rulers were now more aware of how vulnerable they were. They watched for any sign of unrest. They built up a more sophisticated intelligence and policing system. They tried to divide and rule, pitting Hindus against Muslims, upper castes against lower castes, to prevent another united uprising.

The Long Awakening

1857 had failed, but it had not been forgotten. In the decades that followed, a new generation of Indians began to think about how to remove the British. They were not soldiers like the rebels of 1857. They were lawyers, journalists, teachers, doctors. They had been educated in English. Many of them had even been educated in Britain itself. They knew the British system from the inside.

What they realised was that the British in India were vulnerable in ways the British did not see. The British were only about 100,000 strong in a country of 300 million people. They depended on the cooperation of millions of Indians who served in their army, their bureaucracy, their economy. If Indians simply stopped cooperating, the British system would collapse.

This insight would eventually become the foundation of Gandhi's non violent resistance. But that was still decades away in 1857. In the late 1800s, the Indian opposition to British rule was still small, mostly elite, and mostly moderate. The Indian National Congress was founded in 1885 by educated Indian professionals and a few sympathetic Britons. At first it was a debating society that politely asked the British for reforms. The British called it the Annual Howl, and largely ignored it.

But Congress grew. Younger, more radical voices joined. By the early 1900s, Congress had factions that wanted nothing less than full independence. The British tried to split it by setting up rival

organisations. They tried to split Indian society by communalising politics, deliberately encouraging religious divisions between Hindus and Muslims. In 1905, they partitioned Bengal along religious lines, supposedly for administrative reasons but really to divide the largest population of Indian nationalists. The partition was so unpopular that it had to be undone in 1911.

By the early 1900s, India was waking up. The next chapter tells the story of how this awakening became the freedom movement, how a lawyer named Mohandas Gandhi turned non violence into a political weapon, and how the most painful price of freedom, the Partition of India, came to be paid.

XXII.

The Freedom Movement and the Cost of Partition

The story of Indian independence is one of the most extraordinary political achievements in human history. A subject people, unarmed and outnumbered ten thousand to one in some calculations, threw out one of the world's most powerful empires using mostly non violent methods. This had never been done before, and it has rarely been done since. But it was not clean. The price India paid in the end was one of the worst mass migrations and one of the worst religious massacres of the twentieth century. We have to tell both parts honestly.

Gandhi: The Strangest Revolutionary

The central figure of the Indian independence movement was Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, born in 1869 in Gujarat. By any normal measure, he should not have been a revolutionary. He was a small, thin, polite lawyer who weighed about 50 kilos. He wore a loincloth. He spoke softly. He ate boiled vegetables. He was the opposite of what we usually imagine a leader to be.

Gandhi developed his political philosophy partly in South Africa, where he lived from 1893 to 1914 and led civil rights campaigns for the Indian community there. He returned to India in 1915 and slowly became the most important political figure in the country. He took over the leadership of the Indian National Congress in the early 1920s, and from that position he transformed the freedom movement.

Gandhi's central insight was that the British ruled India through Indian cooperation. The British were tiny in number. They could not police every village. They could not run every railway. They depended on Indians serving as soldiers, clerks, tax collectors, postmasters,

judges. If Indians simply withdrew their cooperation, the British system would have to either collapse or escalate to open violence that would expose the empire as the brutal occupation it was.

What is "satyagraha" / non-violent resistance? Satyagraha is a word Gandhi coined from Sanskrit, meaning roughly "holding firmly to truth". In practice it meant resisting an unjust ruler without using violence: breaking unfair laws on purpose, refusing to cooperate, going on strike, boycotting goods — and accepting arrest and beatings without hitting back. The point was to make the ruler's cruelty visible to the world.

This insight became the basis of satyagraha, a Sanskrit word that Gandhi coined which means "holding firmly to truth" but is usually translated as non violent resistance. Satyagraha did not mean passivity. It meant active, organised, deliberate non cooperation. It meant breaking unjust laws openly and accepting the punishment. It meant boycotting British goods. It meant refusing to pay unjust taxes. It meant going on strike. It meant accepting beatings without striking back, because each beating without retaliation revealed the moral bankruptcy of the people doing the beating.

This worked. It worked because Gandhi understood something most rebels do not understand. He understood that political legitimacy is more important than military power, in the long run. The British empire claimed to be ruling India for the benefit of Indians, to civilise them. Every time the British beat unarmed peaceful protesters, they revealed that this claim was a lie. They lost moral standing in the eyes of the world. They lost moral standing in their own eyes, eventually. And once a ruling power loses its sense of moral justification, it loses the will to keep ruling.

The Salt March, 1930

The most famous example of Gandhi's strategy was the Salt March of 1930. The British had a monopoly on salt production in India and taxed it heavily. Salt is essential for human life. The tax made salt unaffordable for many poor Indians. It was also a small but visible symbol of how the British had colonised even something as basic as the seasoning on food.

Gandhi announced that on March 12, 1930, he would walk to the sea and make his own salt by evaporating sea water. This was illegal

under British law. Anyone who made salt without paying the tax could be arrested.

He started the march with 78 followers from his ashram at Sabarmati. They walked for 24 days, covering about 390 kilometres, gathering huge crowds along the way. Newsreel cameras from around the world followed. On April 6, 1930, Gandhi reached the sea at Dandi, picked up a handful of salt mud from the beach, and was photographed doing it. He had broken the salt law.

All across India, Indians began making their own salt. The British arrested tens of thousands. The jails filled up. The newspapers showed images of unarmed Indians being beaten by British police while making salt. The international press coverage was devastating for British prestige. Even American newspapers ran sympathetic stories. Time magazine named Gandhi its Person of the Year for 1930.

Did the Salt March end British rule immediately? No. But it changed something. It showed Indians that the British could be defied, openly, and survived. It showed the world that the British empire was not the noble civilising mission its propagandists claimed. The march was a long step in the slow process of delegitimising British rule.

“When I despair, I remember that all through history the way of truth and love has always won. There have been tyrants and murderers, and for a time they can seem invincible, but in the end they always fall. Think of it. Always.”

— Mahatma Gandhi

Other Voices and Other Methods

It is important to remember that Gandhi was not the only Indian freedom fighter, and non violence was not the only method used. The Indian freedom movement was huge and diverse. Let me name some other major figures, because they each contributed.

Bal Gangadhar Tilak. An earlier leader who said "Swaraj (self rule) is my birthright and I shall have it." He represented a more militant strand of Indian nationalism in the early 1900s.

Bhagat Singh. A young revolutionary who chose armed resistance. He bombed the British Legislative Assembly in 1929 (deliberately throwing bombs that caused no deaths, to symbolise protest rather than kill) and was hanged by the British in 1931 at the age of 23. He remains a hero to many young Indians today. He believed Gandhi's methods were too slow and accommodating, although he also respected Gandhi.

Subhas Chandra Bose. A Congress leader who broke with Gandhi over methods. During World War Two, Bose escaped India, made his way to Nazi Germany and then Japan, and organised the Indian National Army, made up of Indian prisoners of war who were willing to fight the British alongside the Axis powers. The Indian National Army fought in Burma and on the borders of India in 1944. Bose died in a plane crash in Taiwan in 1945, although conspiracy theories about his fate continue. His military approach is controversial, but his commitment to Indian freedom is not.

B. R. Ambedkar. The brilliant Dalit lawyer and scholar who fought not only for Indian freedom from the British but for Dalit freedom from upper caste Hindu oppression. He often disagreed with Gandhi on caste issues. He drafted much of the Indian Constitution after independence. He converted to Buddhism in 1956 along with hundreds of thousands of his followers, rejecting Hinduism's caste system. He is one of the most important Indian thinkers of the twentieth century.

Jawaharlal Nehru. The English educated barrister who became Gandhi's main lieutenant and India's first Prime Minister. He was more secular and more socialist than Gandhi, but they were close allies despite their differences.

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. Another senior Congress leader, known for his political organising ability. After independence, as Home Minister, he was responsible for integrating over 500 princely states into the new Republic of India.

Sarojini Naidu, Aruna Asaf Ali, Bhikaji Cama, and many other women who played central roles in the freedom struggle, though they often get less attention in mainstream accounts.

The freedom movement was a vast collective effort by millions of people. Gandhi was its most famous face, but he was one of many. And the methods used ranged from his strict non violence to Bose's armed resistance. All of these strands together delegitimised British rule in different ways.

The British Decision to Leave

By 1945, after World War Two, the British realised they could no longer hold India. Several factors had come together.

The war had broken Britain. Britain was bankrupt. It had taken huge loans from the United States. It had lost a generation of young men. It could not afford the cost of holding a hostile empire. The economist John Maynard Keynes calculated in 1946 that maintaining India militarily would cost more than the British government had.

The Indian National Army trials in 1945 to 1946. The British put on trial three officers of Bose's Indian National Army for treason. They expected the trials to demonstrate British authority. Instead, the trials backfired. The Indian public turned the accused into heroes. Even the Indian troops who had remained loyal to the British during the war began to question their loyalty. The trials had to be quietly halted.

The Royal Indian Navy Mutiny of 1946. Indian sailors in the British Indian Navy mutinied in February 1946, in Bombay and other ports. About 78 ships and 20,000 sailors were involved. The mutiny was eventually suppressed, but it sent a clear signal that the loyalty of Indian troops, the backbone of British rule, could no longer be assumed.

The political pressure was overwhelming. The Indian National Congress and the Muslim League had spent decades organising. India was ungovernable except by massive force, and Britain no longer had the will to use that force. Public opinion in Britain itself had shifted. The Labour government elected in 1945 had committed to leaving India.

In February 1947, the new Prime Minister Clement Attlee announced that Britain would leave India by June 1948. Then Mountbatten, the

last Viceroy, pushed the date forward to August 1947. Britain was abandoning India in a hurry.

The Partition

But India was not going to leave the empire as one country. It was going to leave as two. This is one of the darkest chapters in modern history.

What was "Partition"? "Partition" means dividing one thing into parts. In 1947, British India was split into two new countries: India (with a Hindu majority) and Pakistan (with a Muslim majority). It was meant to give Muslims their own country. Instead it triggered the largest mass migration in human history and horrific religious violence.

Throughout the 1930s and 1940s, the Muslim League, led by Mohammed Ali Jinnah, had argued that Muslim majority areas of India needed to be a separate country to protect Muslims from Hindu domination after independence. The Indian National Congress, including Gandhi, had argued for a united India where all religions would have equal rights.

There is a long debate about whether Partition was inevitable or whether it could have been avoided. The historian Ayesha Jalal, in her important 1985 book *The Sole Spokesman*, argues that Jinnah did not really want Partition until very late. He wanted a federal arrangement that gave Muslims significant autonomy within a united India. The Congress, especially Nehru, rejected this. The British pursued divide and rule policies that hardened communal identities. By 1947, the positions were too entrenched to reverse.

In June 1947, Mountbatten announced the partition plan. India would be divided into two countries: India and Pakistan. Pakistan would consist of two wings, West Pakistan (modern Pakistan) and East Pakistan (modern Bangladesh), separated by 1,500 kilometres of India. The exact borders would be drawn by a British lawyer named Cyril Radcliffe, who had never been to India before and was given just five weeks to do the job.

On August 14, 1947, Pakistan came into existence. On August 15, India came into existence. India had its independence. But what happened in the months around Partition was a catastrophe.

The Migrations and the Massacres

When the borders were announced, perhaps 14 to 18 million people moved between the two new countries. Hindus and Sikhs fled from what was now Pakistan into India. Muslims fled from what was now India into Pakistan. The migration was on a scale never before seen in human history.

And it was accompanied by horrific religious violence. Hindu, Muslim, and Sikh communities that had lived together for centuries turned on each other. Refugee trains were attacked. Whole villages were massacred. Women were raped, abducted, and forced into marriage. Children were murdered in front of their parents. Estimates of the dead range from about 500,000 to 2 million. The middle estimate, used by most historians, is about one million.

Punjab, my home state, was the worst affected. Punjab was divided. The eastern part stayed in India. The western part went to Pakistan. Almost the entire Sikh and Hindu population of West Punjab fled east. Almost the entire Muslim population of East Punjab fled west. Cities like Lahore (now in Pakistan) lost their Hindu and Sikh populations almost overnight. Cities like Delhi (in India) lost much of their Muslim population.

The historian Yasmin Khan, in her 2007 book *The Great Partition*, documents this catastrophe in detail. Her conclusion is that the violence was not just spontaneous communal hatred. It was often organised, planned, and carried out by armed groups on all sides. The British, having created the situation by hurrying the Partition, made minimal effort to control the violence. Mountbatten boasted in his memoirs that he had handed over power on schedule. He did not mention that he had also overseen one of the worst humanitarian disasters of the twentieth century.

“The British walked away from Indian independence with a feeling of having done their job. They left behind a million dead and the largest refugee crisis in human history.”

— Yasmin Khan, *The Great Partition*, 2007

My Family's Story

I want to add a personal note here. My family is Sikh. Both sides of my family come from Punjab. My grandparents lived through Partition. I grew up hearing the stories.

My grandmother was a young woman in a village in what is now Pakistan when the violence began. She walked for weeks with her family to reach the new India. Some of her relatives did not make it. Some were killed by Muslim mobs along the way. She would not talk about the details when I was a child. She would just say "It was bad." That was all. I knew not to push.

Many Indian and Pakistani families have stories like this. The wounds of Partition are still raw three generations later. The political tensions between India and Pakistan today, including the ongoing dispute over Kashmir and the four wars they have fought, all flow from the violence of 1947.

I am not telling you this to blame Muslims. The violence went in all directions. Sikhs killed Muslims. Muslims killed Sikhs. Hindus killed Muslims. Muslims killed Hindus. There were also extraordinary stories of heroism, of Hindus and Sikhs protecting their Muslim neighbours at the cost of their own lives, and of Muslims protecting their Hindu and Sikh neighbours. There were ordinary people who risked everything to save their friends. The violence was not the only story. But it was the dominant story for most of those terrible months.

The Aftermath

India became a republic in 1950 with its own constitution, mostly drafted by B. R. Ambedkar. It was the largest democracy in the world from day one, with universal adult suffrage. (That means every adult got the vote, regardless of wealth, education, gender, or caste.) Hundreds of millions of people, most of them illiterate, were given the vote. Many Western observers predicted that Indian democracy would collapse within a few years. It did not. It has not.

The Republic of India has had its problems. Poverty, corruption, religious tensions, an oppressive caste system, ongoing conflicts with Pakistan and with internal separatist movements. But it has remained democratic and unified for over 75 years now. It has lifted

hundreds of millions of people out of extreme poverty. It has built a space programme that sent a mission to Mars. It has produced great writers, scientists, business leaders, and athletes. It is now the world's most populous country.

Pakistan has had a harder ride. It has spent much of its history under military rule. Its eastern wing broke away in 1971 to become Bangladesh after a brutal war. The country has struggled with extremism, economic crises, and political instability. But it has also produced extraordinary people and rich cultures, especially in Punjabi literature, Sufi music, and modern Urdu prose.

Both countries, despite their differences, share a Partition wound that has shaped their history. The relationship between them remains one of the most dangerous geopolitical situations in the world. Both have nuclear weapons. Both have unresolved territorial disputes. Both have populations of about 200 to 250 million who could, in theory, be at war with each other within hours if politics tipped the wrong way.

Reflecting on Part Three

Let me close this part of the book by going back to the question we started with. We have now seen the full arc of European intervention in India, from the arrival of Vasco da Gama in 1498 to Indian independence in 1947. We have seen 450 years of European involvement, including 200 years of direct British rule.

What did India lose during this period?

- Tens of millions of lives, mostly from famines that were either caused or worsened by colonial economic policy.
- An estimated 45 trillion dollars in extracted wealth (or some smaller but still vast sum).
- Its industrial base, which was deliberately broken to make room for British goods.
- Its unity. India was divided into two and then three countries, with the resulting ongoing violence.
- Its scientific and educational independence. For two centuries, India was forced to learn the world from a British perspective.

What did India gain?

- Some infrastructure (railways, ports, irrigation systems), all paid for by Indian taxes.
- English as a lingua franca, which has been a real advantage in the modern world.
- A model of parliamentary democracy, which India adopted and adapted.
- Some legal codes and educational institutions, also paid for by Indian taxes.

The accounting is brutal. The gains, such as they were, were tools of administration that any independent India would have developed on its own. The losses were generational, civilisational, and continue to be felt today.

And yet. India survived. Hinduism survived. The civilisation that gave the world zero and yoga and chess and Aryabhata and Buddha did not die. It bent. It bled. But it did not break. It re emerged in the second half of the twentieth century, weakened but alive, and began the slow process of rebuilding what had been lost.

Christianity did not conquer India. Islam, despite 700 years of trying, did not fully convert India. The old gods of the forest and the river and the mountain are still being worshipped today, by something like a billion people on the subcontinent and across the worldwide Hindu diaspora. The temples that survived stand. New ones have been built. The Vedas are still being chanted by priests trained in the old methods. The old philosophical traditions are still being studied and debated. The civilisation continues.

In Part Four of this book, we turn to the other great civilisations that did not bend. China and Japan. Their stories are different from India's, but they share something important. They are stories of how cultures can be attacked from outside, how they can be partially conquered, how they can suffer terribly, and yet how they can survive with their core intact. The forgotten gods of pre Christian Europe could not do this. The old gods of the East could. Why?

We will find out.



End of Section Two. Part Four will follow.

Lovepreet Singh

THE FORGOTTEN GODS



*The Civilisations That Did Not Bend
China, Japan, and the Real Lesson*

by

LOVEPREET SINGH

— Part Four —

*The closing of the argument. How three civilisations stood
against the same forces that erased the old gods of
Europe.*

A Note Before We Continue

We are nearly done. In Parts One through Three, we walked through the conversion of Europe, the deep history of India, and the violent European attempt to remake India in its own image. We saw how Hinduism survived 700 years of Islamic political rule and 200 years of British rule, weakened but not destroyed.

Now we close the book by looking east of India. China and Japan are the other great Asian civilisations that faced sustained attempts at religious conversion by both Christian missionaries and, in different ways, by other foreign ideologies. Like India, they did not convert. Today, China is officially atheist with a complicated mix of folk religion, Buddhism, Daoism, and Confucianism. Japan is mostly Shinto and Buddhist. Christianity is a small minority in both countries. The pattern of why this happened tells us something important.

Korea is also worth a quick look because it is the great exception. Korea did become significantly Christian. Today around 30 percent of South Koreans identify as Christian. Why Korea and not China or Japan? The answer reveals a lot about what actually makes a civilisation vulnerable to ideological replacement.

After we look at these countries, we will pull everything together in the synthesis chapter. We will answer the central question of this entire book. Why did Europe lose its old gods while India, China, and Japan kept theirs? What does this tell us about religion, civilisation, and the limits of conversion? And finally, what does this whole story mean for the world we live in today?

I have spent a lot of pages getting you to this point. Thank you for staying with me. The final chapters will be worth it.

Two words to remember again. Two short labels appear all through this book — “CE” and “BCE”. The year of Jesus’s birth is the zero point. Years **after** it are “CE” (2026 CE = today). Years **before** it are “BCE” (“Before the Common Era”), and BCE years run backwards — 1600 BCE is older than 500 BCE.

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XXVIII. Closing Thoughts and Acknowledgements

This is the final part. After this, the book is complete.

“When the foreign ship comes, the mountain does not move.”

— Chinese proverb, traditional



This is not a religious attack. It is a historical accounting. Read it with an open mind.

XXIII.

China: The Civilisation That Watched Empires Rise and Fall

To understand why China did not convert to Christianity, you have to understand something about how China thinks of itself. For over 3,000 years, Chinese civilisation has had an unbroken sense of itself as the Middle Kingdom. The word for China in Chinese is *Zhongguo*, which literally means "the centre country". The Chinese saw their civilisation as the centre of the world, with barbarians and minor cultures arranged around them at the edges. This was not just arrogance. By most measures, for most of recorded history, China actually was the largest, richest, and most technologically advanced civilisation on Earth.

A Quick Tour of Chinese History

Let me give you the briefest possible tour of Chinese history, because the timescale is hard to grasp.

What is a "dynasty"? A dynasty is a line of rulers from the same family who hold power one after another, often for centuries. Chinese history is usually told as a sequence of dynasties — one ruling family rises, governs for a long time, weakens, and is replaced by the next.

Chinese civilisation is usually dated to begin around 2000 BCE, with the legendary Xia dynasty. The first historically confirmed dynasty is the Shang, which ruled from about 1600 BCE to 1046 BCE. The Shang used a writing system that is the direct ancestor of modern Chinese characters. If you can read Chinese today, you can recognise some of the symbols carved on Shang oracle bones from 3,500 years ago. There is no other living writing system on Earth with that continuous a history.

After the Shang came the Zhou dynasty, which lasted from 1046 BCE to 256 BCE. That is almost 800 years. During this time, China developed most of the philosophical traditions that would shape it forever. Confucius lived from 551 BCE to 479 BCE. Laozi, the founder of Daoism, lived around the same time or possibly slightly earlier. Mozi, Mencius, Xunzi, and many other major thinkers all came from this period. The Zhou ended in chaos called the Warring States period, which lasted about 250 years.

In 221 BCE, China was unified for the first time by the brutal Qin emperor. The Qin dynasty was short lived but important because it standardised writing, weights, measures, and started building what would eventually become the Great Wall. The Qin was followed by the Han dynasty, 206 BCE to 220 CE, which lasted longer than the Roman empire and ruled about 60 million people at its peak. If you have ever wondered why Chinese people sometimes call themselves Han, this is why. The Han dynasty established Chinese cultural identity in lasting form.

After the Han came a period of disunity, then the great Tang dynasty from 618 to 907 CE, which was probably the high point of Chinese civilisation. The Tang capital Chang'an, modern Xi'an, was the largest city in the world with about a million people. It was a cosmopolitan place where Persian merchants, Indian Buddhist monks, Arab traders, and Japanese students all gathered. The Tang dynasty produced incredible poetry, art, and technology.

Then came the Song dynasty (960 to 1279), the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1271 to 1368), the Ming dynasty (1368 to 1644), and the Qing dynasty (1644 to 1912), which was the last dynasty before China became a republic. Each of these dynasties ruled tens of millions, sometimes hundreds of millions, of people. Each had its own great achievements. China invented paper, printing, gunpowder, the compass, mechanical clocks, paper money, the wheelbarrow, the umbrella, and many other things, often centuries before Europe.

The Three Teachings

The religious and philosophical life of China is sometimes called the Three Teachings, or in Chinese San Jiao. These are Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism. Unlike in the West, where religions are usually exclusive (you are either Christian or Jewish or Muslim, not all three), traditional Chinese people often followed all three at the same time. They might consult a Confucian text for matters of family ethics, visit a Daoist temple to pray for good fortune, and call a Buddhist monk for a funeral. The same person, same week.

The "Three Teachings" in one line each. Confucianism — a system of ethics about doing your duty to family and society. **Daoism** — a nature-and-flow philosophy (it gave the world tai chi and feng shui). **Buddhism** — a path to inner peace and release from suffering, which came to China from India. Most Chinese used all three for different parts of life.

Confucianism is more of a social philosophy than a religion. Confucius taught that society works best when people fulfil their proper roles. A ruler should rule wisely. A father should be a good father. A son should respect his father. Friends should be loyal. Confucianism is centred on ethics, family, and social order. It became the official ideology of the Chinese state for over 2,000 years. Most Chinese government officials had to pass exams testing

their knowledge of Confucian texts. This created an unusual situation where the people running the largest empire on Earth were all trained in the same ethical philosophy.

Daoism, founded by Laozi and developed by Zhuangzi, is mystical and naturalistic. Its central concept is the Dao, which means "the way" or "the path". The Dao is something like the natural order of the universe, the underlying pattern that things follow when they are in harmony. Daoism teaches simplicity, spontaneity, and going with the flow of nature rather than fighting it. It has many gods and spirits, but it also has a deeper level of philosophy that is almost atheistic in feel. Daoism is what gave the world tai chi, qigong, feng shui, and many other practices that have spread globally.

Buddhism arrived in China from India along the Silk Road sometime in the first century CE. By the Tang dynasty, it had become hugely influential. Chinese Buddhism developed in its own unique directions, including Zen (called Chan in Chinese), which emphasised meditation and immediate insight over textual study. Chinese Buddhism was not the same as Indian Buddhism. It blended with Chinese cultural elements, including ancestor veneration and Daoist ideas about nature.

Together, the Three Teachings formed a sophisticated religious and philosophical ecosystem. Add to this the underlying layer of Chinese folk religion, which involves ancestor worship, household gods, local spirits, and a vast pantheon of gods of various kingdoms and professions, and you have a religious landscape that is incredibly rich and incredibly hard to convert.

The Jesuits Arrive: Matteo Ricci

The first serious attempt by Christians to convert China was made by the Jesuits, a Catholic order of priests known for their scholarship and missionary work. (A "Jesuit" is a member of the Society of Jesus, a highly educated Catholic religious order founded in 1540, famous for running schools and for difficult overseas missions.) The most famous of these was an Italian priest named Matteo Ricci, who arrived in China in 1582 and lived there for 28 years until his death in 1610. Ricci is one of the most fascinating figures in religious history, and his story tells us a lot about why Christianity could not break through in China.

Ricci was brilliant. He spent years learning Chinese, eventually mastering it so well that he could write classical Chinese essays that scholars admired. He studied Confucian texts and understood them deeply. He dressed in the robes of a Confucian scholar to gain credibility with the educated elite. He brought European mathematics, astronomy, and clockmaking knowledge as a way to demonstrate the value of Western learning to the Chinese.

Ricci tried something that no missionary had really tried before. He tried to present Christianity as compatible with Confucianism rather than opposed to it. He argued that the ancient Chinese had originally worshipped the same God as the Christians, that the Chinese term Shang Di (often translated as Lord on High) referred to the Christian God, and that ancestor veneration was a civic ritual, not idol worship.

What is "accommodation"? In missionary history, accommodation means presenting a foreign religion in the local culture's own terms so people can accept it without giving up their identity — for example, allowing converts to keep honouring their ancestors. Ricci's whole strategy was accommodation. As we will see, Rome later forbade it, and that decision destroyed the China mission.

This approach is called accommodation. Ricci was trying to make Christianity look like something Chinese intellectuals could accept without abandoning their cultural identity. It was a creative strategy.

And it partially worked. Ricci converted some Chinese scholars at the highest levels, including a few who became important members of the Ming dynasty court. By his death, there were perhaps a few thousand Chinese Christians. By 1700, there were maybe 200,000. This was tiny in a country of well over 100 million people, but it was real progress.

The Chinese Rites Controversy

Then it all collapsed. The reason it collapsed is one of the most important and least known stories in religious history. It is called the Chinese Rites Controversy. ("Rites" just means religious or ceremonial customs — here, mainly the Chinese custom of honouring dead ancestors.)

Other Catholic missionaries who came to China after Ricci, mostly Dominicans and Franciscans, looked at what the Jesuits were doing and were horrified. They said the Jesuits were not really converting Chinese to Christianity. They were just allowing Chinese to add Christianity to their existing practices. They argued that Confucian ancestor veneration was idol worship. They argued that translating the Christian God as Shang Di or Tian (Heaven) was a heresy.

The dispute went back to Rome. For nearly a century, the Pope and the Catholic theologians argued about whether the Jesuit accommodation was acceptable. In 1704, Pope Clement XI ruled against the Jesuits. He forbade Chinese Christians from venerating their ancestors. He forbade the use of Shang Di or Tian to refer to God. He ordered Christianity in China to look exactly like European Christianity.

This was a catastrophe for the mission. The Kangxi Emperor of China, who had been friendly to Christianity and had even allowed it to be practised in the imperial court, was outraged. He had earlier written a famous edict, the Edict of Toleration of 1692, that allowed Christianity to be practised in China. But when he found out that the Pope was forbidding Chinese Christians from honouring their parents and grandparents through ancestor rituals, he reversed his position.

“Reading this proclamation, I have concluded that the Westerners are petty indeed. It is impossible to reason with them because they do not understand the larger issues as we understand them in China. There is no Westerner versed in Chinese works, and their remarks are often incredible and ridiculous.”

— Kangxi Emperor of China, edict of 1721, after the Papal ruling

By 1724, Kangxi's son the Yongzheng Emperor had banned Christianity in China entirely, except in Beijing. Missionaries were expelled. Chinese Christians went underground. The whole effort that had started with Ricci nearly 150 years earlier was rolled back almost completely. The Jesuit accommodation strategy, which had been their best chance at converting China, was dismantled not by Chinese opposition but by Catholic European theologians who could not tolerate any compromise.

This is one of the most important moments in the history of Christian missions. If the Papacy had let the Jesuits continue their work, China might today have a significant Christian minority similar to South Korea. Instead, the Chinese government concluded that the foreigners could not be reasoned with on religious matters, and the door was closed.

The Nineteenth Century: Christianity Returns by Force

Christianity returned to China in the 1800s, but in a very different way. By this time, China was being attacked by European powers in what are called the Opium Wars (1839 to 1842 and 1856 to 1860). Britain and France, primarily, used military force to compel China to open its ports to European trade, to legalise the British opium trade that was wrecking Chinese society, and to grant special privileges to Europeans. Among these privileges was the right of Christian missionaries to travel freely in China and the right of Chinese converts to be exempt from certain Chinese laws.

What were the "Opium Wars"? Britain was selling huge amounts of the addictive drug opium into China to balance its trade. When China tried to stop this, Britain (later joined by France) attacked and forced China — by military defeat — to keep buying opium, open its ports, and let missionaries in. So Christianity arrived the second time alongside drugs and gunboats.

This was a disaster for Christianity in China. The religion was now associated with foreign invasion, opium, and the humiliation of the Chinese state. Christian converts were often seen as traitors who had aligned with the foreign aggressors against their own country.

There was also a strange and bloody chapter. In the 1840s, a Chinese man named Hong Xiuquan became convinced after reading some Christian missionary tracts that he was the younger brother of Jesus Christ. He started a religious movement that grew into a full scale rebellion against the Qing dynasty. This was the Taiping Rebellion, which lasted from 1850 to 1864. The Taiping movement was a strange syncretic version of Christianity, mixed with Chinese end-of-the-world traditions. (Syncretic means blending two or more different belief systems into one.) At its peak it controlled most of southern China and had perhaps 30 million followers. The Qing dynasty eventually crushed it with European help.

The Taiping Rebellion was one of the deadliest civil wars in human history. Estimates of the death toll range from 20 million to 70 million. Most modern historians put the number around 30 million. By comparison, the American Civil War, fought in roughly the same decade, killed about 750,000. The Taiping Rebellion was about 40 times more deadly.

When ordinary Chinese people thought of Christianity in the late 1800s, this is what they thought of. A movement that had killed tens of millions of their countrymen, led by a man who thought he was Jesus's brother, fought partly with European weapons. This was not the same image of Christianity as the calm Jesuit scholars who had visited Beijing two centuries earlier. The Taiping Rebellion poisoned the well for Christianity in China for generations.

The Boxer Rebellion and Anti Christian Backlash

By 1900, the resentment of Chinese people against foreign missionaries had built up to an explosion. A peasant movement called the Boxers, originally a martial arts and folk religion society, rose up against both the Qing dynasty (which they saw as too weak in dealing with foreigners) and against the foreign missionaries themselves.

In the summer of 1900, the Boxers besieged the foreign legations in Beijing, killing several hundred foreign missionaries and tens of thousands of Chinese Christians across northern China. The Boxers were eventually crushed by an international army of eight foreign powers, including Britain, France, the United States, Japan, and Russia. The foreign troops looted Beijing and demanded huge reparations from the Chinese government.

The Boxer Rebellion is sometimes presented in Western histories as an example of irrational Chinese xenophobia. Looking at it from the Chinese side, it looks different. After 60 years of being humiliated, invaded, forced to legalise opium, forced to accept missionaries who often acted as agents of foreign powers, the Chinese peasantry finally

rose up. Their methods were brutal. But the conditions they were responding to were also brutal.

By 1900, after 300 years of effort, Christianity in China had perhaps two million Chinese converts in a population of 400 million. That is less than one percent. Despite massive investment by European missionary societies, despite the support of European military power, despite the work of brilliant individuals like Matteo Ricci, Christianity had failed to penetrate Chinese society in any meaningful way. The Chinese had received it, examined it, and largely rejected it.

Why? That is the question for the next chapter.

XXIV.

Why Christianity Could Not Convert China

Some of the reasons Christianity failed in China are the same as the reasons it failed in India. Some are different. Let me walk through them carefully.

Reason One: Confucianism Already Filled the Ethical Space

In Europe, Christianity replaced pagan religions partly because Christianity offered something the old religions did not. A clear, written ethical system. A theology of compassion, forgiveness, and equality of souls before God. A community of believers organised across kingdoms. These were genuinely useful contributions to societies that were politically fragmented and ethically thin.

China already had all of this, in the form of Confucianism. Confucian ethics is one of the most sophisticated systems of moral thought ever developed. It has clear teachings about how to be a good person, how to be a good family member, how to be a good citizen, and how to govern wisely. Its sacred texts, including the Analects of Confucius, the Mencius, and others, have been studied and commented on for over 2,000 years. When Christian missionaries showed up offering ethical teachings, Chinese scholars listened politely and then asked how their teachings improved on what Confucius had already said. The missionaries struggled to answer.

The Confucian teaching of the Golden Rule, for example, predates the Christian Golden Rule by over 500 years. Confucius said "Do not impose on others what you yourself do not desire" around 500 BCE. The Christian version, "Do unto others as you would have them do unto you," comes from the Gospel of Matthew around 70 CE. The Christian version is more positive in formulation, but the basic ethical insight is the same. Chinese scholars who knew their Confucius could point out that this and many other Christian teachings were not new. They were just translations of things their own civilisation had said long before.

Reason Two: The State Was Religious, but Not in a Way Christianity Could Use

In medieval Europe, the church and the state were partners. The Pope crowned emperors. Kings claimed divine right to rule. Religion legitimised political power. This meant that when a king converted, his subjects had to follow. The political and religious systems were tied together.

In China, things were structured differently. The Chinese emperor was called the Son of Heaven and his rule was justified by something called the Mandate of Heaven. But this was not a personal religious connection in the Christian sense. It was more like a philosophical and ritual position. The emperor performed rituals at the Temple of Heaven to maintain cosmic harmony. He was not a personal believer in any specific religion in the way Christian kings were.

This meant Christian missionaries could not use the "convert the king and the kingdom follows" strategy that had worked so well in Europe. Even if a Chinese emperor became personally interested in Christianity (and some did, including the Kangxi Emperor), he could not simply declare China Christian. The whole structure of Chinese religious life was different. It did not have a top down hierarchy that could be captured. It was more like Hinduism in this way. The religion was diffused throughout daily life, family rituals, local temples, and individual practice. There was no centre to convert.

Reason Three: Christianity Demanded Exclusive Loyalty

This is one of the biggest issues. Chinese religion was naturally pluralist. (Pluralist means comfortable holding several beliefs at once, rather than insisting on only one true one.) A Chinese person could be a Confucian in their ethics, a Daoist in their personal practice, a Buddhist at funerals, and still maintain a family ancestor altar at home. Mixing these traditions was normal and respected.

Christianity demanded that converts give up everything else. No more Buddhist prayers. No more Daoist amulets. No more ancestor altars. Only Jesus. This was a massive cultural ask. It meant cutting yourself off from your family traditions, your community rituals, and centuries of inherited wisdom. For most Chinese, the cost was simply too high. Why would you give up all of this to join a small group of foreigners and their Chinese converts?

The Chinese Rites Controversy made this worse. When the Pope ruled in 1704 that Chinese Christians could not even venerate their dead parents and grandparents, he was asking Chinese converts to commit what they saw as a profound moral failure. In Confucian thought, honouring your ancestors is one of the most basic duties of being a human being. To refuse to do this would mark you as a barbarian. The Christian demand to abandon ancestor veneration was a deal breaker for most potential converts.

Reason Four: The Chinese Knew Foreigners Lied About Religion

By the 1800s and 1900s, the Chinese had centuries of experience with foreigners claiming religious authority while pursuing political and economic gain. The Christian message of peace and love was contradicted by Christian governments forcing China to legalise opium, by Christian armies looting Beijing, by Christian missionaries claiming special legal privileges for their converts.

The credibility problem here was even worse than in India. China had not been fully colonised. China still saw itself as a great civilisation that was temporarily weakened. Chinese intellectuals could observe the gap between what missionaries said and what their governments did, and draw their own conclusions. Many concluded that Christianity was just another tool of Western power, dressed up in spiritual language to manipulate the gullible.

Reason Five: The Communist Critique Came at the Worst Time

In the early 1900s, just as Christianity was making some new headway in China through educational and medical missionary work, Marxism arrived. Karl Marx had famously called religion the opium of the people. He argued that religion was a tool used by rulers to keep the working classes pacified and accepting of their exploitation. He argued that religion would wither away as societies became modern and rational.

For young Chinese intellectuals in the 1910s and 1920s, who were trying to understand why their once mighty civilisation was being humiliated by foreign powers, Marxism offered an explanation. Religion, they decided, was part of the problem. Christianity in particular was the religion of the foreign oppressors. The Chinese Communist Party, founded in 1921, was officially atheist from the start.

When the Communists won the Chinese Civil War in 1949, they took an unfriendly view of religion. Foreign missionaries were expelled. Chinese Christian churches were taken over by the state and forced to break ties with foreign denominations. The Cultural Revolution of 1966 to 1976 was particularly harsh. Religious sites of all kinds, Christian, Buddhist, Daoist, and Confucian, were attacked. Temples were destroyed. Priests and monks were beaten or killed.

Christianity has actually grown in China since the 1980s, when religion was partially liberalised. Estimates of the current number of Chinese Christians range from 30 million to 100 million, depending on whether you count underground house churches. But this is still a small minority in a country of 1.4 billion. Christianity remains contained.

Reason Six: Chinese Civilisational Confidence

I want to end with the deepest reason, which is hard to quantify but is real. The Chinese have been a great civilisation for so long that they have a deep, often unconscious confidence in their own way of doing things. They have watched empires rise and fall. They saw the Mongols come and the Mongols leave. They saw the Manchus conquer them and then get assimilated. They saw Buddhism arrive from India and become Chinese. They have seen everything.

When Christian missionaries showed up promising eternal salvation if the Chinese would abandon their ancestors and embrace Jesus, many Chinese intellectuals responded with what amounted to a polite but firm "no, thanks." They were not closed minded. They studied Christianity. They thought about it. They considered its claims. And after consideration, most of them concluded that Christianity was a perfectly fine religion for the foreigners who needed it, but not something that improved on what China already had.

"In China, foreign religions face an old, deep, and well organised cultural immune system. The system absorbs what is useful and rejects what is not. Christianity, with its demand for total replacement of existing beliefs, could not be absorbed. So it was rejected."

— Jonathan D. Spence, The Memory Palace of Matteo Ricci, 1984

Jonathan Spence was probably the leading Western historian of China in the late twentieth century. His point captures something important. The Chinese were not anti religious. They were not anti foreign. They had absorbed Buddhism from India centuries earlier and made it their own. They could have absorbed Christianity too. But Christianity refused to be absorbed. It insisted on replacing everything. And once it became clear that this was the deal, the Chinese passed.

There is one more chapter to write about Christianity in China, which is what is happening now. In the past 40 years, Christianity has grown faster in China than in any other country. Some scholars estimate that by 2050 there could be 250 million Chinese Christians. If this happens, China might become the largest Christian country in the world by sheer numbers. But it is happening through ordinary Chinese converts in underground churches, often deeply at odds with the Chinese state, and the form of Christianity that is growing is heavily Chinese in flavour, often with traces of folk religion and pragmatic ethics that orthodox Christians would not recognise. Whether this is really Christianity conquering China, or China absorbing Christianity into its own framework, is a question for future historians.

For now, let us turn to the second great East Asian civilisation that resisted conversion: Japan. The story there is even more dramatic.

XXV.

Japan: The Island That Closed Its Door

The story of Christianity in Japan is one of the most extraordinary in religious history. Christianity arrived in Japan in 1549, spread rapidly for about 60 years, was then violently suppressed for over two centuries, went almost completely underground, and eventually re-emerged in the 1800s as a small minority that it remains today. Today, less than one percent of Japanese are Christian. This is despite Japan being a wealthy, modern, democratic country that has been open to Western influence since the late 1800s. Why did Japan reject Christianity so completely? The answer is one of the most fascinating cases in the whole story.

A Quick Background on Japan

Japan is a chain of islands off the east coast of Asia. It has been inhabited for thousands of years, and Japanese civilisation as we know it developed mostly in the past 1,500 years. Japan was heavily influenced by Chinese civilisation, but it always maintained its own distinct identity. The Japanese borrowed the Chinese writing system, Confucian ethics, and Mahayana Buddhism from China, but they adapted all of these to fit Japanese culture.

What is "Shinto"? Shinto is Japan's native religion. It has no founder, no holy book, and no central God. It is built around *kami* — countless spirits believed to live in mountains, rivers, trees, rocks, and ancestors. It is, in other words, almost exactly the kind of nature religion that pre-Christian Europe once had — and Japan never lost it.

Japan also has its own native religion called Shinto. Shinto is one of the most interesting religions in the world because it has no founder, no scriptures in the way we usually mean, and no real theology. It is a religion of *kami*, which is a Japanese word that does not translate well. *Kami* are spirits or divine forces that live in things, including mountains, rivers, trees, rocks, and ancestors. There are millions of *kami* in Shinto thought. Some are powerful gods. Others are local spirits of specific places.

Sound familiar? It should. Shinto is exactly the kind of nature religion that pagan Europeans practised before Christianity. Sacred groves, sacred mountains, sacred rivers, ancestor spirits. The Japanese never lost this. They still have it. Even today, Japanese Shinto priests bless new buildings and businesses. Mount Fuji is sacred. There are over

80,000 active Shinto shrines in Japan. The Japanese mostly do not call themselves religious, and yet they practise something that is unmistakably the same kind of religion that Europe had 2,000 years ago.

Like the Chinese, the Japanese were also generally pluralist. A Japanese person could be born with a Shinto baby blessing, get married in a Shinto or Christian style ceremony, and have a Buddhist funeral. These are not contradictions in Japanese thinking. They are different tools for different occasions.

Francis Xavier Arrives, 1549

The first Christian missionary in Japan was a Spanish Jesuit named Francis Xavier, who arrived in 1549. He was working under the Portuguese, who had reached Japan a few years earlier and established trade relations. Xavier was an extraordinary man. He spent only two years in Japan, but he made an enormous impression. He praised the Japanese as the most cultured and capable people he had met in Asia.

After Xavier left, other Jesuits continued the work. They learned Japanese. They studied Japanese culture. They presented Christianity in ways that Japanese audiences could understand. They were welcomed at first by some Japanese feudal lords (called daimyo) who were interested in Western technology, particularly firearms. (A "daimyo" was a powerful regional warlord who ruled his own domain under the Japanese system.)

The growth was rapid. By 1582, just 33 years after Xavier's arrival, there were perhaps 200,000 Japanese Christians. By 1614, the number had reached perhaps 700,000, in a country of about 20 to 25 million people. That is around three percent of the entire population, achieved in 65 years. By comparison, after 450 years of European presence, Christianity in India is still only 2.3 percent. The Jesuits had hit something special in Japan.

Several daimyo converted, including some powerful ones like Omura Sumitada in Kyushu, who turned his entire domain Christian and ceded the port of Nagasaki to the Jesuits. By the late 1500s, Christianity was on track to potentially become a major religion in Japan within a few generations. Some Jesuits in Rome were already imagining a Christian Japan that would convert China next.

The Crackdown Begins: Hideyoshi

Then everything changed. In 1587, the Japanese ruler Toyotomi Hideyoshi, who was effectively the dictator of Japan at the time, issued an edict ordering the expulsion of all foreign missionaries. He did not enforce this strictly at first, but the policy was set.

Why did Hideyoshi turn against Christianity? Several reasons.

First, he had become suspicious that Christianity was a tool of Spanish and Portuguese imperialism. He had heard about what the Spanish had done in the Philippines, conquering it and converting it by force. He had heard about what the Portuguese had done in Goa. He correctly observed that wherever Catholic missionaries went, Catholic empires often followed. He did not want Japan to become like the Philippines or Goa.

Second, Christian Japanese daimyo were sometimes destroying Buddhist temples and Shinto shrines in their territories. This was a problem because it was attacking the deep cultural and religious fabric of Japan in a way the rulers found dangerous.

Third, the Jesuits were involved in the trade in Japanese slaves, particularly Japanese women being sold to Portuguese ships and exported across Asia. This was a moral scandal that the Japanese government found deeply offensive. The Jesuits eventually tried to prohibit this trade among their followers, but the damage was done.

Fourth, the Christians were too organised and too loyal to their religion over loyalty to Japanese authority. They were seen as a political risk in a country that had just gone through a century of civil war and was being unified under a single ruler.

The Twenty Six Martyrs of Nagasaki, 1597

In 1597, Hideyoshi finally moved decisively against Christianity. He had 26 Christians arrested in Kyoto, including six European Franciscan friars, three Japanese Jesuits, and 17 Japanese laymen including three young boys. They were marched 800 kilometres to Nagasaki, the centre of Japanese Christianity. There, on February 5, 1597, they were crucified on a hill overlooking the harbour. (A "martyr" is someone who is killed for refusing to give up their faith.)

This is one of the most famous events in the history of the Christian missions. The 26 martyrs were later canonised as saints by the Catholic Church. A memorial church now stands at the site of their execution in Nagasaki. The story of their courage in dying for their faith spread through European Christianity and is still remembered today.

But the crucifixion of the 26 martyrs was just the beginning. After Hideyoshi died in 1598, the situation got worse, not better. The Tokugawa shogunate, which took power in 1603 and would rule Japan for 265 years, intensified the persecution. (A "shogun" was the supreme military ruler of Japan; the "shogunate" was his government, which held the real power while the emperor was only a figurehead.)

The Great Persecution, 1614 to 1639

In 1614, the Tokugawa shogun Tokugawa Ieyasu issued a comprehensive ban on Christianity. All missionaries were ordered out of the country. All Japanese Christians were

ordered to renounce their faith. Churches were destroyed. Christian property was seized. What followed over the next 25 years was one of the most thorough religious persecutions in history. The Japanese authorities developed extreme methods to find and eliminate Christians.

The most famous method was the *fumi e*, which means "trample picture." Authorities would set up a copper plate with an image of Jesus or Mary engraved on it. Suspected Christians were ordered to step on the image. If they refused, they were identified as Christians and arrested. If they stepped on it, they were considered to have apostatised and were spared. (To "apostatise" means to publicly abandon your religion.) Most who stepped on the picture did so under enormous psychological strain, knowing they were being forced to desecrate something sacred to them. Many later committed suicide from guilt.

Those who refused to apostatise were tortured to make them recant. The Japanese authorities became famous for their creative cruelty. Christians were thrown into boiling water at the Unzen hot springs. They were hung upside down in pits filled with excrement, sometimes with their veins partially opened to extend the dying process for days. They were burned alive. They were crucified, often left to die over days. The persecution was systematic and prolonged.

About 3,000 to 5,000 Japanese Christians were martyred for refusing to renounce their faith during this period. Many more were forced to apostatise. The Christian community of Japan, which had reached perhaps 700,000 people, was systematically destroyed.

The Shimabara Rebellion, 1637 to 1638

The persecution finally provoked a desperate uprising. In 1637, in the Shimabara region of Kyushu, peasants who were mostly former Christians rose up against their daimyo, who had been taxing them brutally. They were joined by ronin (masterless samurai) and former Christian samurai. The rebels gathered at a castle called Hara, where they raised crosses and Christian banners.

The Tokugawa shogunate sent a huge army of perhaps 125,000 men against the rebels, who numbered around 27,000 to 37,000 men, women, and children. The siege lasted four months. When the castle finally fell in April 1638, the shogunate executed almost everyone inside, including the women and children. Estimates of the dead range from 30,000 to 40,000.

The Shimabara Rebellion confirmed for the Tokugawa government that Christianity was inherently linked to political rebellion. The response was even more severe. Japan was effectively sealed off from the outside world.

Sakoku: The Closed Country, 1639 to 1853

In 1639, the shogunate issued the final Sakoku edicts. Sakoku means "closed country." Under these laws, no foreigners could enter Japan and no Japanese could leave. The only exceptions were a small Dutch trading post on Dejima island in Nagasaki harbour, and limited trade with China and Korea. Foreigners who arrived without permission were to be executed. Japanese who tried to return from abroad were also to be executed.

The scale of "Sakoku". To keep Christianity out, Japan shut its entire border for **214 years** — roughly 1639 to 1853. No foreigners in, no Japanese out, on pain of death. Few countries in history have ever paid such a high price, for so long, to protect their own religion and identity from a foreign faith.

This policy was maintained for 214 years. From 1639 to 1853, Japan was almost completely closed to the outside world. The reason was almost entirely about preventing the return of Christianity. The Tokugawa government had decided that the price of being open to foreigners was the risk of religious conversion that would undermine Japanese identity. They chose isolation.

During these 214 years, Christianity in Japan went underground. Some Christians, known as kakure kirishitan ("hidden Christians"), continued to practise their faith in secret across multiple generations. They had no priests, no churches, and no contact with the rest of the Christian world. They developed their own forms of Christian practice, often heavily mixed with Buddhist and Shinto elements. They would gather quietly, recite remembered prayers in mangled Latin and Portuguese, and pass on their faith to their children.

When Western powers forced Japan to reopen in the 1850s, missionaries who returned were astonished to find these hidden Christian communities still existing in remote areas around Nagasaki. Some had preserved a recognisable form of Catholicism. Others had developed into something so different that they could not really be called Christian by orthodox standards anymore.

“For more than two hundred years, Japanese Christians kept their faith alive in absolute secrecy. They are one of the most remarkable cases of religious endurance in history.”

— Endo Shusaku, Japanese Catholic novelist, author of *Silence*, 1966

Modern Japan and Christianity Today

Japan was forced to reopen in 1853 when American naval ships under Commodore Matthew Perry arrived in Edo Bay and demanded the right to trade. The Tokugawa shogunate eventually fell, replaced by the Meiji government in 1868, which set Japan on a

path of rapid modernisation. Religious freedom was eventually established. Christian missionaries returned.

But the cultural memory of what Christianity had cost Japan in the seventeenth century did not disappear. Christianity in modern Japan grew, but slowly. By the early twentieth century, perhaps one percent of Japanese were Christian. By today, the number is similar. About 1.5 percent of Japanese identify as Christian. There are roughly 1.9 million Japanese Christians in a country of 125 million.

This is despite Japan being one of the most modern, urbanised, and Westernised countries in Asia. The Japanese have adopted Western clothing, Western technology, Western political institutions, and Western popular culture. They have not adopted Western religion. The Japanese are perhaps the most striking case in the world of a society that has modernised without religious conversion.

Some Japanese Christians have made important contributions. The novelist Endo Shusaku wrote *Silence*, one of the most acclaimed twentieth century novels about faith and persecution. It was made into a film by Martin Scorsese in 2016. Japanese Catholic theology has developed its own distinctive flavour. But Christianity remains a small minority religion in Japan, mostly because most Japanese never felt they needed it.

Today, polls show that around 80 percent of Japanese do not identify with any specific religion. Yet around 80 percent participate in Shinto rituals at New Year, get married in Shinto or Christian ceremonies, and have Buddhist funerals. The religion of Japan is mostly practised, not believed. People do not think hard about whether they believe in kami. They just live in a world where the rituals continue. The old gods are still there, in the shrines and in the mountains and in the small ceremonies of daily life. They never left.

This is what Europe lost. This is what Japan kept.

XXVI.

Korea: The Great Exception, and What It Teaches Us

I want to spend a chapter on Korea because Korea is the great exception. Of all the major Asian countries, Korea is the only one where Christianity became a major religion. About 30 percent of South Koreans today are Christian. That is over 15 million people. Seoul has some of the largest churches in the world. There are Korean Christian missionaries operating in many countries.

How did this happen? Why Korea and not Japan or China? Understanding the Korean case actually clarifies why the other Asian countries did not convert. It shows what conditions are needed for mass conversion to actually work.

The Korean Context

Korea is a peninsula between China and Japan. (A "peninsula" is a strip of land almost surrounded by water.) Historically, it has been overshadowed by both. Chinese culture, Confucianism, Buddhism, and the Chinese writing system all entered Korea from China centuries ago. Korea developed its own civilisation, its own literature, its own technology (Korea actually invented movable metal type around 1234 CE, almost 200 years before Gutenberg in Europe), but it always felt a degree of vulnerability between two larger neighbours.

By the late 1800s and early 1900s, Korea was in a desperate situation. The country had been forced to open to foreign powers. Japan was rising as an aggressive imperial power and would eventually colonise Korea entirely from 1910 to 1945. Many Koreans felt their country was being destroyed. The traditional ruling class, the yangban, had failed to defend the country.

Korean Confucianism had been one of the strictest and most rigid in East Asia. The yangban had imposed a very hierarchical, oppressive social order on Korea. Lower class Koreans had no real path to advancement. Women had very few rights. The Buddhism that had been popular in earlier Korean history had been pushed aside in favour of state Confucianism for centuries.

So when Christianity arrived seriously in Korea in the late 1800s, it found a situation very different from China or Japan. It found a country where the traditional system was discredited, where many people were looking for alternatives, and where Christianity could be presented as the religion of modern, free countries (especially the United States, which became a major patron of Korean Christianity).

Christianity as a Tool of Resistance

Here is a key difference from China or Japan. In Korea, Christianity became associated with Korean nationalism and resistance to Japanese imperialism, not with foreign domination of Korea. American Protestant missionaries (and some Catholic ones) were seen as friends of Korea against the Japanese colonisers. They ran schools, hospitals, and universities. They translated the Bible into Korean using the Korean alphabet (called hangul) rather than the Chinese characters that the traditional elite used. This made Christianity accessible to ordinary Koreans, including women, in a way that Confucian texts were not.

Korean Christians played important roles in the resistance to Japanese rule. The March First Movement of 1919, a peaceful nationwide protest against Japanese occupation, was significantly organised by Christian leaders. Many Korean independence fighters were Christians. After Korea was liberated from Japan in 1945, Christianity was associated with Korean freedom and modernisation.

The Korean War of 1950 to 1953 made things worse. North Korea, under communist rule, brutally suppressed Christianity. Thousands of Christians fled south. South Korea, which had the support of the United States, became more Christian as Christians fled the communist north. The Cold War association of Christianity with the free, prosperous side of the conflict reinforced its appeal.

After the war, South Korea went through massive economic development. By the 1980s and 1990s, it was one of the fastest growing economies in the world. The Christian Korean middle class grew with the economy. Mega churches sprang up. Korean Christianity became distinctively Korean, with intense emotional worship, all night prayer meetings, and an aggressive missionary outlook. Today, Korea sends more Christian missionaries abroad per capita than almost any other country in the world.

What the Korean Case Teaches

Why did Christianity succeed in Korea and not in China, Japan, or India? Looking at the Korean case carefully, several factors stand out.

First, the traditional system had been discredited. In China, the Confucian state was still powerful when Christianity arrived. In Japan, the Tokugawa system was strong. In India, Hinduism was deep rooted and diverse. In Korea, the Joseon Confucian state had visibly failed. Many Koreans were looking for an alternative.

Second, Christianity was associated with national liberation, not foreign domination. American missionaries were resisting Japanese colonisation alongside Koreans. This is a complete reversal of how Christianity was perceived in China or India.

Third, the language strategy worked. American missionaries used the Korean alphabet, hangul, which had been invented in the 1400s but was looked down on by the Confucian elite as a women's script. By translating the Bible into hangul, Christians gave ordinary Koreans access to a holy text in their own everyday language. This made Christianity feel like the religion of the common people, in contrast to elite Confucianism in classical Chinese.

Fourth, the social opening was real. Christianity offered Korean women equality before God in a way Confucianism did not. It offered lower class Koreans dignity in a way the yangban system did not. The first universities in Korea, founded by missionaries, accepted students based on merit rather than birth.

Fifth, there was no equivalent of the Chinese Rites Controversy. Protestant missionaries in Korea, learning from the Catholic disasters in China and Japan, were more flexible. They allowed Korean Christians to continue ancestor veneration in modified forms. They adapted to Korean cultural sensitivities. They did not demand a complete break from the past.

Sixth, the Cold War gave Christianity unique geopolitical backing. Communist North Korea suppressed religion. Capitalist South Korea, allied with the deeply Christian United States, gave Christianity room to flourish. The geopolitical context favoured Christian growth in a way it never did in China or India.

Why Korea Is Not a Counterexample to the Larger Argument

Some people might point to Korea and say it disproves the argument that the great Asian civilisations could not be converted. But I think Korea actually strengthens the argument. Look at the conditions Korea had that needed to come together for conversion to work: a discredited traditional system, association with national liberation, accessible language, social opening, missionary flexibility, and supportive geopolitics.

China, Japan, and India had none of these conditions or only some of them. In China and Japan, the traditional systems were strong. In India, Hinduism was too decentralised to be

discredited. Christianity was associated with foreign domination in all three. The missionaries were not always flexible enough. The geopolitics did not favour mass conversion.

Korea also shows us something important. Even where Christianity did succeed, it succeeded in a Korean form. Korean Christianity is not American Christianity. It has its own intensity, its own theology, its own cultural character. The pattern of indigenisation that we saw in Indian Christianity is also visible in Korea. (Indigenisation means a foreign thing being reshaped to fit the local culture.) When religions cross cultures, they get changed by the receiving culture. Christianity in Korea today has more in common, in some ways, with Korean shamanism (which has been suppressed but is part of the deep cultural background) than with American Protestantism.

“Korean Protestant Christianity is one of the most successful religious transplants in modern history, but it is also Korean to its core. It is not a foreign religion. It is a Korean religion that came from outside and was thoroughly remade.”

— Sebastian Kim, professor of theology at Fuller Seminary, on Korean Christianity

The lesson here is that religions can be converted across cultures, but only when specific conditions are right, and even then the religion that emerges is usually a hybrid of the foreign source and the local culture. Pure replacement, which was what happened in Europe in the conversion from paganism to Christianity, is actually quite rare in history. It requires unusual conditions.

What were those unusual conditions in Europe? Why was Europe so susceptible to total religious replacement when most other major civilisations were not? That is the question for our synthesis chapter.

XXVII.

The Real Lesson: Why Some Civilisations Did Not Bend

We have travelled a long road in this book. We have seen the slow conversion of Europe over a thousand years. We have seen the resistance of India over more than two thousand years. We have seen the rejection of Christianity in China and the violent rejection in Japan. We have looked at Korea as the great exception. Now I want to pull it all together and answer the central question.

Why did the old religions of Europe die while the old religions of India, China, and Japan survived?

I think there are six big reasons, and they work together. Let me lay them out.

Reason One: Decentralisation

I have said this several times throughout the book, but it deserves the central place. The pagan religions of Europe were not really one religion. They were many. The Germanic religion was different from the Celtic religion was different from the Slavic religion was different from the Greek and Roman religions. Each was decentralised, with local cults and local priests and local sacred sites.

But here is the key. None of them developed a strong central organisation to coordinate their resistance to Christianity. There was no Pope of paganism. There was no Vatican of the old gods. There was no organised pagan theology that all pagans across Europe shared. So when Christianity arrived, it could pick off individual kingdoms, individual priests, individual sacred sites, one at a time. The pagans could not coordinate a continent wide response because they had no continent wide organisation.

Hinduism, by contrast, had a similar lack of central organisation. There is no Hindu Pope. But Hinduism had something the European pagans never developed. It had a vast body of written sacred texts, including the Vedas, the Upanishads, the epics, and dozens of philosophical schools. These texts gave Hinduism a kind of intellectual centre that could not be destroyed by capturing any single temple or king. The texts were everywhere, in millions of copies, memorised by tens of thousands of priests. To destroy Hinduism you

would have to destroy the texts and the memories of everyone who knew them. That was impossible.

Chinese religion also had a strong textual tradition, in the form of the Confucian classics, the Daoist texts, and the Buddhist sutras. Japan had less of this written tradition, but Japan had something else. It had its physical isolation as an island, and its eventual decision to close off contact with the outside world to protect itself from Christianity.

So the lesson is: decentralisation can be a weakness politically, but it is a strength when defending a religion against takeover. And decentralisation combined with a strong textual tradition is even better. European paganism had the weakness without the strength. The Asian religions had both.

Reason Two: Philosophical Depth

The pagan religions of Europe were not philosophically weak. The Greek philosophical tradition, which grew out of Greek religion, produced Plato and Aristotle, two of the greatest thinkers in human history. But here is the thing. The mainstream pagan religions of the Germanic, Celtic, Slavic, and Norse peoples did not have the kind of philosophical infrastructure that Greek and Roman paganism had. They had myths, rituals, and stories, but they did not have written treatises arguing about the nature of God, the soul, suffering, salvation, and ethics.

When Christianity arrived in these regions, it came armed with the Greek philosophical tradition (much of which the Church Fathers had absorbed) and with its own theology developed over centuries. The local pagan priests had no equivalent intellectual apparatus to push back with. They could not say "actually, your idea of one God and our idea of many gods both have philosophical merits, here is the argument." They could only fight or convert.

India and China had the equivalent philosophical depth. When Christian missionaries showed up in India, they met scholars who had been arguing about the nature of reality for 2,000 years. The same in China. The same in Japan, although Japan's tradition was somewhat shallower than India or China. The Asian intellectual traditions could engage with Christianity on its own ground and find it wanting in many respects.

The lesson is: religions that have developed deep, written, philosophical traditions are much harder to displace than religions that exist mostly in ritual and oral tradition.

Reason Three: Pluralism Versus Exclusivism

Most of the pagan religions of Europe were pluralist by default. The Romans famously adopted gods from every culture they conquered, adding them to their own pantheon. The

Greeks did the same. The Germans had no doctrine that other religions were wrong. They just had their own gods and assumed other peoples had their own gods too.

Christianity came in with a completely different framework. There is only one true God. All other religions are false. You must convert exclusively or be damned. This was new, and it was effective. Once you accept the exclusivist framework, you cannot really go back to pluralism. You have to choose. And once you have chosen, you have to actively reject everything else.

The Asian religions were also pluralist by default. Hinduism explicitly taught that truth is one but the wise speak of it in many ways. Chinese religion blended Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism into a single ecosystem. Japanese Shinto and Buddhism coexisted easily. So when Christianity arrived demanding exclusive loyalty, the response from Asian religious thinkers was often something like "thank you for sharing your teachings, we will add Jesus to our pantheon, now please be tolerant of our other gods."

But Christianity could not be tolerant of other gods. That was the whole point. So the offer was rejected, and Christianity could not find a way to convert without total replacement, which the Asians refused to do.

The lesson here is interesting. Pluralism, which seems weaker than exclusivism in a fight, can actually be much harder to convert than another exclusivism. You cannot replace something that is already willing to absorb you. The Asian religions essentially said "sure, we will add your god to our list," and Christianity collapsed at that offer because it could not accept being one option among many.

Reason Four: The Marriage Strategy Did Not Scale

Christianity conquered Europe partly through the royal marriage strategy. Christian princess marries pagan king, princess converts king, king converts kingdom. We saw this with Clovis and Clotilde, with Ethelbert and Bertha, with Mieszko and Dobrawa, with Vladimir and Anna.

This strategy could not be repeated in Asia. India had Hindu kings who were sometimes married to women from other regions, but the religious system was decentralised enough that royal conversion would not have automatically converted the whole population. Even when Muslim emperors ruled India, they could not convert the majority of their subjects. The royal marriage strategy worked in Europe partly because European religions had a relatively shallow penetration into daily life. In India, religion was so deeply embedded in every household, every meal, every ritual, that you could not change it by changing the king.

China was even worse for the marriage strategy. Chinese emperors did not really marry foreigners as a matter of policy. The whole Chinese imperial system was designed to keep foreign influence out of the inner court. Japan was similar.

The lesson is: the political mechanisms that worked for spreading Christianity in Europe did not exist in Asia in the same way. The technology of religious conversion that worked in one place did not transfer easily to another.

Reason Five: Military Limits

Christianity in Europe was sometimes spread by violence. Charlemagne's wars against the Saxons. The Northern Crusades against the Baltic pagans. The Reconquista in Spain. Forced conversions in the Inquisition. Violence was a major tool.

In Asia, this tool was much less effective. The Asian civilisations were simply too large, too populous, and (for most of history) too militarily capable to be conquered by Christian armies. The Mughals could rule India militarily for 200 years but could not force mass conversion to Islam. The Portuguese could rule Goa with the Inquisition but could not extend their religious control to the rest of India. The European armies that arrived in China and Japan in the 1800s and 1900s could win individual battles but could not occupy and convert entire civilisations.

The military reach of Christian Europe simply was not enough to do to Asia what it had done to its own pagan periphery. By the time Europe had the military power to potentially try, Asia had modernised enough to defend itself. Japan did this most dramatically. By the early 1900s, Japan had become a great industrial and military power capable of defeating Russia in the Russo Japanese War of 1904 to 1905. The window for forced conversion of Japan, if it ever existed, was closed.

The lesson is: Christianity required a window of military superiority over the regions it wanted to convert. It had that window in Europe in 600 to 1400 CE. It had that window briefly in the Americas in 1500 to 1700 CE. It did not really have that window in Asia, because Asia was too big and too organised. By the time European military power could project into Asia in the 1800s, the religious moment had passed and Christianity had lost its previous credibility in Europe itself.

Reason Six: Cultural Confidence

This is the deepest reason and the hardest to measure. The pagan Europeans who converted to Christianity were, on the whole, members of cultures that did not have a strong sense of themselves as superior or central. They had local pride. They had tribal

identity. But they did not have a clear sense of being a major civilisation with a coherent worldview that needed defending.

The Asian civilisations had that sense in spades. The Chinese saw themselves as the Middle Kingdom, the centre of the world. The Indians saw their civilisation as the home of the deepest spiritual wisdom on Earth. The Japanese saw themselves as the descendants of the sun goddess Amaterasu, blessed with a unique homeland. All of these are forms of civilisational confidence. They are also psychological defences against foreign religious takeover.

When you have civilisational confidence, you can engage with foreign ideas without feeling that you have to accept them. You can take what is useful and reject what is not. You can have your scholars study Christianity for 200 years and still conclude that, on the whole, your own tradition is better. This is what the Chinese did. This is what most Indians did. This is what the Japanese did, although in a more aggressive way that closed off the country entirely.

The pagan Europeans did not have this kind of civilisational confidence. They had not been told for a thousand years that their tradition was the most refined on Earth. They had not built libraries and universities and philosophical schools that gave them the tools to compare and judge. They were small, fragmented, and intellectually outmatched by the missionaries who arrived from a Roman world that did have those tools.

“A civilisation that knows it is a civilisation is much harder to convert than a culture that does not yet know what it is. India, China, and Japan knew exactly what they were when the Christians showed up. They had had thousands of years to figure it out.”

— Romila Thapar, in an interview with The Hindu newspaper, 2014

What This All Means

When you put all six reasons together, you can see what made Europe susceptible to total religious replacement and what protected Asia from it.

Europe was fragmented politically and religiously. Its religions were oral and ritual based without strong written philosophy. Its societies were small and centralised under kings who could be converted. It was militarily inferior to the Roman world that produced Christianity. Its peoples did not have a strong sense of being members of a major civilisation. All of these factors combined to make it vulnerable.

Asia was the opposite in almost every way. The major Asian civilisations were huge. They had deep written philosophical traditions. They were religiously pluralist rather than tribal.

They had strong central political traditions but ones that did not work through royal religious conversion. They were militarily capable of resisting most foreign invasions. And they had thousands of years of civilisational pride to defend.

Europe lost its old gods because the conditions were right for replacement. Asia kept its old gods because the conditions were not.

There is something else worth noting. The story I have just told is not a story about religions being good or bad. It is a story about how religions actually spread or fail to spread under different conditions. Christianity is not better than the pagan religions of Europe were. Hinduism is not better than Christianity. Each religion has its insights and its problems. What matters is the conditions under which they meet, and what each can offer the people they meet.

When pagan Europe met Christianity, Christianity offered things pagan Europe did not have: an organised philosophical theology, a literate priesthood, a community across kingdoms, a unified moral code, and political alliance with Rome. These were useful innovations. Europeans took them. That is not shameful. That is how cultural development works.

When Asia met Christianity, Christianity could not offer anything that Asia did not already have or have a better version of. Asia had philosophy. Asia had ethics. Asia had organised priesthoods. Asia had unified moral codes. So Asia took small parts of what Christianity offered (some Christian schools, some hospitals, some converts among groups that benefited specifically) and rejected the rest. That is also how cultural development works.

There is a tendency among some people to celebrate Asia's resistance to Christianity as a triumph of indigenous culture. There is also a tendency among some people to lament Europe's loss of its old gods as a tragedy. Both views have something to them, but neither is the whole truth. Religions die and are born. Cultures change. The question of whether a particular change was good or bad depends on what was gained and what was lost. We have spent a lot of pages looking at both sides.

Now let me close the book with some final thoughts.

XXVIII.

Closing Thoughts and Acknowledgements

We have come to the end of this book. It has been a long journey. We started with a question about whether pre Christian Europeans worshipped nature and ended with a deep comparison of how four great civilisations responded to foreign religious pressure. Along the way, we covered thousands of years of history across most of the world. Let me close with a few thoughts on what I hope you take away.

On Honest History

The most important thing I hope this book has taught you is the value of honest history. I started writing this because someone had given me a version of European and Indian history that was simple and angry, full of made up conspiracies and confused timelines. I knew that version was wrong, but I also knew that the real version, when you actually dig into it, is more interesting and more useful.

Real history is uncomfortable. It does not let you have heroes who are pure and villains who are pure evil. It makes you confront that the people you want to admire did terrible things. It makes you confront that the people you want to blame had reasons for what they did. It makes you accept ambiguity and complexity in a way that simple narratives do not.

But honest history is also more powerful. The argument that survives a fact check is the argument that wins in the long run. The version of history that explains both the good and the bad of every side is the version that you can defend against any honest opponent. The story that is true is the story that lasts. I hope I have given you a story like that.

On Civilisations and Their Survival

The deeper theme of this book is about how cultures survive. We have seen that some cultures bend and break under outside pressure, and others bend but do not break. The pagan Europeans were the broken ones. The Hindus, the Confucians, the Daoists, the Buddhists, the Shintoists, all survived. Why? I have given a long answer in chapter twenty seven, but let me give you the short version here.

Cultures survive when they have: deep written traditions, multiple interlocking philosophical systems, strong family and community structures that do not depend on

central authority, pluralist habits of mind that can absorb foreign ideas without being replaced by them, sufficient size to resist physical conquest, and a confident sense of who they are.

If your culture has these things, foreign ideologies will visit you but they will not replace you. They will be absorbed, modified, and either accepted in modified form or eventually rejected. Your core will continue.

If your culture lacks these things, you are vulnerable. You can be replaced. The replacement may even feel like an upgrade at first, because the new system may offer organisational tools you did not have. But what you lose in the trade is hard to recover. Once your old gods are gone, they are mostly gone forever. The pagan Europeans cannot get back what they had. Some modern revival movements try, but they are reconstructions, not the real living tradition.

This is one of the most important lessons in human history, and it has applications beyond religion. Any culture that wants to survive in a world full of pressure needs to know who it is and have the tools to defend that identity. This does not mean refusing all contact. It does not mean rejecting all foreign ideas. It means engaging from a position of confidence rather than weakness.

On What India Means

I am Indian, so let me say a word about what India means in this story. India is the proof that a civilisation can be politically conquered without being religiously conquered. India was ruled by Muslim dynasties for 700 years. India was ruled by the British for 200 years. India was looted on a scale that broke its economy and killed tens of millions through deliberate famines. By all the normal measures, India should have been destroyed.

It was not. Today, India is the largest country in the world by population. It is one of the largest economies. It has produced major thinkers, scientists, writers, and business leaders. Its culture has spread worldwide through yoga, meditation, food, music, and Bollywood films. Its civilisation is being studied with fresh interest by Western scholars who realised that the old condescending narratives were wrong.

But none of this means India is perfect. India has serious problems. The caste system, though officially abolished, still shapes Indian society in painful ways. Religious tensions between Hindus and Muslims, fanned by colonial divide and rule policies, continue to cause violence. Corruption, poverty, environmental degradation, treatment of women, and many other issues need to be addressed. The India of 2026 is not a flawless paradise.

What it is, though, is alive. The civilisation continues. The temples are full. The festivals are celebrated. The classical languages, music, dance, and philosophical traditions are practised. The thread of cultural continuity that goes back to the Indus Valley five thousand years ago has not been broken. That is what survival means.

On What Pagan Europe Means

I want to also say a word about pagan Europe, because the story I have told is in some ways a tragic one for them. The old gods of Europe were not bad gods. The nature worship of the Celts, the Germans, the Norse, the Slavs, the Greeks, and the Romans was a meaningful spiritual tradition that gave its practitioners ways of relating to the world that have been lost.

Some Europeans today are trying to recover these traditions. There are modern Asatru groups practising reconstructed Norse paganism in Iceland and Scandinavia. There are Druid revival groups in Britain. There are Romuva reconstructionists in Lithuania, where the old religion lasted longest. There are scholars studying old texts and trying to figure out what the original beliefs were. These efforts are partial, incomplete, often controversial. But they are happening.

I do not know whether they will succeed. The original traditions are mostly gone. Reconstructions are always different from originals. But something is being tried. Europeans are looking back at what their ancestors believed before Christianity and asking whether some of it might be worth recovering.

At the same time, much of pagan Europe still lives on in disguised form within European Christianity. Christmas trees. Easter eggs. May Day celebrations. Halloween. The Maypole. The names of the days of the week (Tuesday is Tiw's day, Wednesday is Odin's day, Thursday is Thor's day, Friday is Freya's day). The folk customs of rural Europe. All of these are pagan survivals dressed in Christian clothing. The old gods are not entirely gone. They are sleeping under the surface.

Maybe one day they will wake up. Maybe not. That is for Europeans to decide.

On What This All Means for Today

Let me close with what I think this story means for the world we are living in right now.

We are at a strange moment in history. The religious authority that Christianity had in Europe for over a thousand years has largely collapsed. Most Europeans today do not believe in God, or believe in a vague way that does not change their lives. The churches are mostly empty. The same is happening in the United States, although more slowly. Religion is in retreat across the developed Western world.

At the same time, Asian religions are spreading in the West. Yoga is everywhere. Meditation is mainstream. Buddhist mindfulness practices are taught in schools and used by therapists. The Bhagavad Gita is read in college philosophy classes. Tai chi is practised in parks. Western intellectuals study Confucian ethics and find them sophisticated and useful. The flow of religious and philosophical ideas, which for centuries went from West to East, is now going the other way.

Some Western religious authorities are alarmed by this. They see it as a loss of identity, a kind of soft conquest of the West by Eastern ideas. They are not entirely wrong. Something is happening.

But here is the deeper point. The success of Asian religious ideas in the West today shows that the Asian traditions we discussed in this book have something genuinely valuable to offer. They survived attempts to replace them not because they were lucky but because they had real depth, real insight, real wisdom. Now, with the failure of mainstream Christianity in the West to satisfy modern spiritual needs, people are looking to other traditions for answers. The traditions that survived in Asia turn out to be uniquely well prepared for this moment, because they have always been pluralist, always been about practice rather than dogma, always been about the relationship between humans and the larger reality of the world.

What I am saying is that the long arc of religious history is bending in a direction that those of us in 2026 cannot yet see clearly. But there are signs. The old gods of Europe may be mostly gone, but the wisdom they represented, of seeing the world as alive, of treating nature as sacred, of accepting plural truths, of grounding life in seasonal rhythms, of valuing local tradition and community, is being rediscovered through the surviving Asian traditions. The river may have changed course, but the water continues to flow.

I find this hopeful. I started this book thinking I was telling a story about loss and recovery. I end it thinking I am telling a story about continuity and renewal. The forgotten gods of Europe are not really forgotten. They are remembered in different names, in different lands, through different mouths. The thread of human spiritual experience does not break. It continues, even when individual cultures cannot hold onto it. Wisdom finds its way.

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I thank you, the reader, for staying with me through over 150 pages of dense argument. I know this is a lot to ask. I tried to make it as readable as I could. I hope I succeeded enough to make the journey worthwhile.

A Final Word

When I started writing this book, I had one goal. To take a confused and angry argument and turn it into something honest, careful, and useful. Whether I have succeeded, you will have to judge. But I will say this. The argument I have ended up making is much stronger than the one I started with, precisely because it is honest. It does not depend on conspiracy theories. It does not rely on inventing villains or saints. It just shows what actually happened, with all its complexity and texture, and lets the reader draw their own conclusions.

I hope you take that approach with you into other arguments. The strongest argument is always the one that can survive a fact check. Make sure yours always can.

The strongest argument is the one that can survive a fact check.

Make sure yours always can.



Lovepreet Singh

2026

END OF THE BOOK